

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **U.S. stocks** shuddered after investors resumed a weekslong bond selloff that has defied the Treasury Department's attempts to curb borrowing costs. The S&P 500, Dow and Nasdaq shed 0.9%, 1.3% and 1%, respectively. **A1**

◆ **All U.S. leading** economic indicators but one edged higher in July, signaling potential moderate growth ahead. **A2**

◆ **Walmart** reported its smallest sales gain in more than six years as some consumers continue to spend cautiously, especially in the retailer's physical stores. **B1**

◆ **Weil, Gotshal & Manges**, known for guiding companies through bankruptcies and advising private-equity firms, faces a wave of partner defections. **B1**

◆ **Abbott** agreed to pay \$670 million to resolve a lawsuit over its specialty formulas for premature infants as well as about 2,000 related claims. **B3**

◆ **Starbucks** will lay off more than 200 corporate staff two years into a turnaround effort pursued by Chief Executive Brian Nicol. **B3**

◆ **Deere** posted higher profit and sales for its fiscal third quarter, as growth in its construction-equipment business helped offset weakness elsewhere. **B3**

◆ **Alibaba's earnings** slumped in its fiscal first quarter as the e-commerce heavyweight continued to pour large sums into artificial intelligence. **B4**

◆ **A bankruptcy court** delayed approval of Google's \$10 million purchase of Spirit Airlines' data after former flight attendants objected to the sale. **B4**

Worldwide

◆ **Romania** said it deployed two F-16 jet fighters to destroy a Russia-launched explosive marine drone that threatened hundreds of lives near one of its gas platforms. **A6**

◆ **The U.S.** began deporting immigrants to Liberia, officials in the West African country said, part of the president's plan to send migrants to third-party countries. **A5**

◆ **Trump** suggested a revival of the long-contested Keystone XL oil pipeline could be in the cards when he said the U.S. was close to reaching a trade deal with Canada. **A5**

◆ **California companies** have drawn about \$366 billion of venture capital since the year began, more than three times the amount of such funding directed to the other 49 states combined. **A3**

◆ **The captain** of an overloaded boat that capsized in New York Harbor this month, killing a woman and her 5-month-old infant, was arrested by federal authorities and faces deportation. **A3**

◆ **A court in China** sentenced Hui Ka Yan to life in prison after the nation's property bust led to the collapse of his China Evergrande Group. **A8**

◆ **Low water levels** in Germany caused by recent heat waves are likely to impede the country's economic growth in the third quarter, the Bundesbank said. **A9**

◆ **Bangladesh's** Parliament elected a stalwart of the country's new ruling party to the presidency after the post fell vacant in July, when the incumbent resigned. **A8**

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Russia Pummels Kyiv as Air Defenses Dwindle

DEADLY STRIKE: A rescuer Thursday helped a local woman after a Russian airstrike on a residential area in Kyiv. At least 15 people were killed in and around the capital Wednesday night as Ukraine is running out of Patriot air-defense missiles. **A6**

Politicians Reverse Positions On Data Centers Amid Outcry

Issue becomes a mounting liability for Republicans and some Democrats

By AMRITH RAMKUMAR AND SABRINA RODRIGUEZ

In November, Texas Gov. Greg Abbott declared his state the “epicenter of AI development” while announcing a \$40 billion investment by Google. Less than a year later, the Republican said he halted approvals of some 1,800 new data

centers worth billions of dollars on concerns that they use too much power and water. The move earlier this month drew the ire of President Trump, who this week staunchly defended the centers as an economic engine. A growing voter outcry over data centers that strain resources and fuel a technology capable of putting Americans out of work is becoming a mounting liability for Republicans and some Democrats in this fall's elections. Abbott's opponent in his bid for a fourth term, Democrat Gina Hinojosa, has hammered him on the issue while climbing within a few percentage points in recent polls.

“The data center issue is the latest example of a governor who has been doing the bidding of moneyed interests instead of the people of Texas,” Hinojosa said in an interview. Abbott has said companies have agreed to guardrails that minimize disruptions to local water and power markets, showing his plan is working and protecting Texas communities. Hinojosa, a state representative, said protections

should be enshrined in law. She released a new ad Tuesday featuring a person asking a chatbot why their electric bill is going up. The bot responds that it is because of data centers approved by Abbott, who has received millions of dollars in campaign donations from executives and companies tied to AI including Elon Musk. Democrats around the country are deploying the same playbook. Abdul El-Sayed, a Please turn to page A4

◆ **Heard on the Street:** AI tests off-grid power..... B10

SpaceX Amasses Big Wins In Trump's Washington

By MICAH MAIDENBERG AND DREW FITZGERALD

SpaceX has had a bumpy ride on Wall Street, but in Washington, Elon Musk's space-and-artificial intelligence company has been racking up big wins. This year, SpaceX has secured billions of dollars' worth of government business to build and launch military satellites, even after lawmakers made an extra push to give other contractors a shot. The Trump administration is allowing SpaceX to sidestep some wireless-network requirements, while pushing to cut environmental reviews related to rocket launches. “There's been a lot of focus on their contract wins,” said Todd Harrison, a defense analyst at the American Enterprise Institute, a conservative-leaning think tank. “In the bigger scheme, the regulatory wins have more systemic, long-term implications for their business model.” SpaceX's mastery of building and launching payloads to space has made it the go-to partner for U.S. military and intelligence offices. SpaceX President Gwynne Shotwell referenced the company's national-security satellite wins during the company's August investor call, saying she was “very bullish on government” deals. A little more than a year ago, people close to the discus-

Please turn to page A5

Per capita out-of-pocket healthcare spending

Year	Spending (Approx.)
2017	\$1,100
2018	\$1,150
2019	\$1,200
2020	\$1,250
2021	\$1,350
2022	\$1,450
2023	\$1,550
2024	\$1,650
2025	\$1,750

Source: Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services

The Claw Machine Is Back. And This Time, You Might Win.

Operators actually want customers to grab the goods—at least once or twice

By LILY BELLE POLING

Stephany Falcon couldn't believe her luck. In just 15 minutes at a Manhattan arcade, the 20-year-old college student and her boyfriend had collected three prizes from the rows of claw machines. After snagging a pink-and-red monster plushie, she excitedly jumped up and down. The claw machine—that infamous promiser of childhood treasures, known for stealing your quarters and almost never yielding up its flimsy prizes—has gotten an upgrade. Modern games, trimmed with neon lights, are filling storefronts and bringing life to malls in cities and suburbs across the U.S. They're stocked with luxe plush toys, Hermès bags, fresh vegetables and even sourdough starter. But the biggest change may be that today's operators actually want their customers to win—at least once or twice. “We only win if you win,” said Brad Howard, co-founder and managing partner of Fantasy Claw Arcade, which is expanding through franchising. “You were gonna buy it for \$20. We want to sell it to you for \$20. But we're going to sell it to you in the form of game play.” Please turn to page A10

Health Benefits Under Pressure

Employers next year might be facing the biggest health-insurance increase in at least two decades. As companies are forced to pay more for insurance, their workers, who typically pay a share of the premium, are seeing their own costs rise roughly in tandem. **B1**

Hawaii Chases The Startup Wave

Officials hope new tech jobs will keep young people from leaving the state

By OWEN TUCKER-SMITH

KAILUA, Hawaii—The sea-side streets bear the unmistakable look of a Hawaiian beach town, an oasis of palm trees, swimsuits and surfboards. Yet tucked behind a café where baristas make \$11 lattes, young workers write code, design machinery and operate an industrial laser that can cut through a car door—all in service of the Airform, a heating and cooling system dreamed up by the engineering startup Normal Corp. Elsewhere on the island of Oahu, students at the University of Hawaii make equipment bound for the moon. In a yurt on a hill overlooking the surf on the North Shore, young scientists create parts on 3-D printers for wastewater-treatment machines. In a Honolulu basement, engineers make textiles out of chicken feathers. These men and women belong to a band of whip-smart engineers building a manufacturing and technology industry that officials hope will rescue Hawaii from a sagging tourism economy, depressed wages and an exodus of young residents to the mainland. The flow of inflation-adjusted tourism dollars into Hawaii's economy peaked Please turn to page A10

INSIDE

U.S. NEWS Colleges are hurtling toward an enrollment cliff as birthrates have fallen. **A3**

MANSION The rich and famous who can't get into Miami's most exclusive country club. **M1**

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U.S. NEWS



CAPITAL ACCOUNT | By Greg Ip

Treasurys’ Haven Status Fades

This year’s upward march in bond yields has many drivers, from sticky inflation to heavy AI-linked corporate borrowing.

Lurking in the background, though, is a more troubling possibility. Treasurys, long the world’s preferred “safe” asset, are looking less safe. Relative to other securities, their yields are no longer quite so low, and in moments of stress, they don’t behave like a haven.

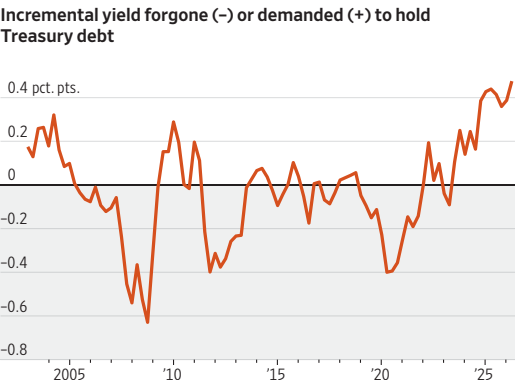
The main reason for this is that since the pandemic, the U.S. has flooded the market with additional debt, reaching \$40 trillion, including intragovernmental debt, this week. There is no sign that the flood will abate.

The U.S. Treasury’s surprise announcement Wednesday that it would boost buybacks of less-liquid longer-term debt simply treats the symptoms rather than the underlying cause. The move, while reducing yields in the short run, might yet raise them in the long run by eroding the U.S.’s reputation for stability and predictability.

Treasury debt has long enjoyed a unique status globally. It is backed by the unparalleled economic and financial strength of the United States, denominated in the world’s preferred reserve currency, and is overseen by strong and stable laws and institutions, in particular the Federal Reserve and the Treasury itself.

Treasurys don’t just fund the U.S. government. They are where investors and governments like to park extra cash, for example, to defend their currencies. They are used to price, hedge and collateralize countless transactions in unrelated markets.

This status brought “a safety premium,” conferring lower everyday borrowing costs for the U.S. and virtu-



Source: Ricardo Caballero, MIT

ally unlimited financing capacity.

These benefits became especially apparent in the wake of the global financial crisis. U.S. borrowing soared, yet yields fell. The reason: Private borrowing collapsed, and securities once thought safe, such as triple-A rated mortgages, turned out not to be safe. The Fed and other central banks began buying their own governments’ debt.

This led to what Ricardo Caballero, an economist at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, dubbed the “safe-asset shortage”: As investors’ demand for super-safe assets collided with a finite supply, yields plummeted.

Those conditions ended with the pandemic when inflation and interest rates rose and deficits shot up. In a recent study, Caballero finds that instead of investors accepting lower yields because Treasurys are so desirable, they are demanding higher yields; the safety premium has become

an absorption premium.

One way Caballero infers this is by comparing Treasury yields to swaps, derivatives used to manage interest exposure that serve as a sort of benchmark for corporate borrowing costs. Historically, Treasurys yielded less than swap rates. But recently, they

have yielded more. He sees this as reflecting the greater strain dealers now bear to trade, warehouse and distribute debt.

Another clue comes from the term premium, the extra return investors demand to hold long-term bonds instead of shorter-term Treasury bills. That term premium has steadily marched higher.

Combining these two, Caballero infers that the shift from a safety premium to an absorption premium explains about 0.75 percentage point of the roughly 2.5 percentage point rise in yields since 2015.

A separate study by Hanno Lustig at Stanford University comes to similar conclusions. Historically, Treasurys yielded less than AAA-corporo-

rate bonds, even after adjusting for default risk, but since 2022, that advantage has disappeared. Treasury yields were also comparable to or lower than other sovereign bonds when hedged into dollars, but have been generally higher since the pandemic.

The study, prepared for the Aspen Economic Strategy Group (of which I am a member), listed signs that investors no longer flee to the safety of Treasurys during stress periods as they once did. When stocks go down, yields now tend to go up—for example, following President Trump’s “Liberation Day” tariffs last year. News of larger deficits tends to put upward pressure on yields, Lustig found. All of this, he argues, shows Treasurys are seen as less safe.

There could be other explanations for these developments, for example, related to market functioning or inflation.

These dynamics cannot be attributed solely to Trump, since they were under way before he took office. But he also hasn’t reversed them. Early on, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said Trump’s priority was lower bond yields, which influence mortgage rates. This, he said, would be achieved through increased energy production that reduces inflation, AI-driven productivity, and a lower budget deficit, which was \$1.8 trillion in fiscal 2024.

Instead, the Iran war has driven up energy prices and inflation. Meanwhile, the Congressional Budget Office projects the deficit will reach \$2.1 trillion this year. As a share of gross domestic product, that is double the 3% target Bessent once envisioned. At the same time, corporations will issue a record \$1.9 trillion in investment-grade debt this year, much of it to finance the AI build-out, according to Barclays. All of this has pushed

bond yields higher instead of lower.

So rather than address the fundamentals behind higher yields, Bessent has turned to fiddling with the bond market itself. Rather than expand bond auctions, he is financing the deficit with more Treasury bills and hinted that auctions of some bonds might actually shrink. He intervened to boost the Japanese yen to keep Japanese interest rates from rising (and spilling into the U.S.) while suggesting Japan borrow from the Fed to finance yen buying without selling Treasurys.

Since the 1970s, Democratic and Republican Treasury Departments alike have sought to make debt issuance “regular and predictable” rather than trying to time the market. Bond sales were detailed at quarterly refundings. Buybacks, launched in 2024 to improve liquidity in little-traded issues, were similarly scheduled at the same time.

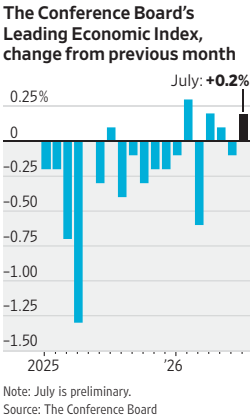
Bessent has also endorsed “regular and predictable,” yet departed from it in announcing the buyback Wednesday just two weeks after the last quarterly refunding.

The buyback caught investors offside and thus achieved its short-term goal: yields fell. But such progress might not be sustained.

If issuance and buybacks are no longer regular or predictable, bonds might become more volatile. Investors might demand a higher yield to “account for this extra unpredictability,” said Blake Gwinn, head of U.S. rates strategy at RBC Capital Markets.

By shifting from bonds to bills, Treasury faces more rollover risk—the chance that interest rates will have risen when that debt must be refinanced.

That, however, might be a problem for a future Treasury secretary.



U.S. Leading Indicators Signal Growth

U.S. leading economic indicators edged higher in July as everything except consumer expectations took a turn for the better, indicating moderate growth could be coming.

The Leading Economic Index published by research group the Conference Board rose by 0.2% to 99.5, following an upwardly revised 0.1% decrease in June.

The index’s six-month growth rate is now positive, rising 0.2% between January and July, which is a sharp reversal from the 1.3% contraction from the prior six months, the Conference Board said.

This is the first time in four years that the LEI’s six-month growth rate turned positive, which suggests some moderate growth ahead, according to Justyna Zabinska-La Monica, a senior manager at the Conference Board.

—Dean Seal

Manufacturing In Philadelphia Area Expands

Manufacturing activity in the Philadelphia area continued to expand past expectations this month, according to a survey from the Philly Fed.

In the reserve bank’s manufacturing business outlook survey, the current-activity index rose to 47.4 in August from 41.4 in July. A reading above zero indicates an increase in business activity. Economists polled by The Wall Street Journal were expecting a reading of 25.

The current new orders and shipments indexes both declined but remained above their long-run nonrecession averages, the report said.

Price increases were less widespread this month but both price indexes remained elevated, the survey said. The prices paid index fell 13 points to 40.9 in August. The current prices received index also declined. The employment index rose 18 points to 27.9, its highest reading since April 2022.

The survey covers businesses in the Philly Fed’s district, which includes Delaware and parts of eastern Pennsylvania and southern New Jersey.

—Jessica Coacci

Jobless Claims Pull Back After Recent Run-Up

U.S. jobless claims eased lower last week after climbing for nearly a month.

The number of people who filed for unemployment benefits was 206,000 in the week through Aug. 15, 6,000 lower than the upwardly revised 212,000 reported a week earlier, the Labor Department said Thursday. Economists surveyed by The Wall Street Journal were expecting 210,000.

Continuing claims, which scale with the total size of the unemployed population, totaled just under 1.8 million in the week through Aug. 8, rising by 18,000 from the upwardly revised total of 1.78 million a week earlier. The data on continuing claims lag the initial-claims data by a week.

Unemployment levels have fluctuated throughout the summer from a mixture of slow hiring with relatively few major rounds of layoffs. Policymakers have suggested that the labor market looks close to equilibrium and isn’t a major source of inflation pressure right now.

—Dean Seal



Home Depot shoppers this week in New York. The retailer has benefited from cost-minded consumers seeking to take on smaller home-improvement projects.

Markets Brush Off Bessent

Continued from Page One

Although Bessent said on CNBC Thursday that coming buybacks could be more than \$4 billion per operation—double or more their current levels—the yield on 10-year Treasury jumped to 4.697% on Thursday.

Describing Treasurys’ action as a short-term response to spiraling U.S. debt, Mike Sanders, head of fixed income at Madison Investments, said, “My fear is that the market is going to try to fight them on it at a certain point.”

Thursday’s actions marked the latest subplot in an unusually dramatic mid-August week for Wall Street.

The market’s quants, or process-driven traders and funds guided by algorithms, endured one of their worst days in recent memory on Wednesday when bets against certain stocks backfired. That included Moderna, whose boffo cancer-therapy results launched its stock up 177% on Wednesday and scorched short sellers betting on its decline.

In a report to clients, Morgan Stanley called it a “MRNA squeeze,” referring to Moderna’s stock symbol. By 1 p.m.

on Wednesday, Goldman Sachs said it was the worst day in more than two years for “systematic long short managers,” a category of quant funds. These funds lost 1.4% on the day at that point, though they remained up 1.7% for the month. The losses were “spread across” all regions, the bank said.

Market moves in biotechnology stocks were a “9/10 pain day for investors,” Morgan Stanley’s trading desk wrote to clients on Thursday. The bank said it was a record for short covering, or closing out short positions, across biotech, and a “genuine tail event” in positioning.

Thursday also brought new signs of economic pressure. Walmart boosted estimates for net sales and operating income this year in part because of gains led by upper-income households. But some customers spent more cautiously, particularly at the company’s physical stores.

“It sort of states the obvious of seeing some incremental pressure on the consumer relative to the beginning of the year with higher fuel prices,” Walmart finance chief John David Rainey said on an earnings call. Pointing to how Walmart has leaned in to lowering its own prices in response, he said, “We’re really proud of that and how we’re trying to be there for our customers and members during this period of time.”

Walmart’s report followed a series of mixed results from

major retailers this week including Target and TJX. Home Depot reported higher quarterly sales despite a frozen housing market, citing homeowners who took on smaller maintenance projects.

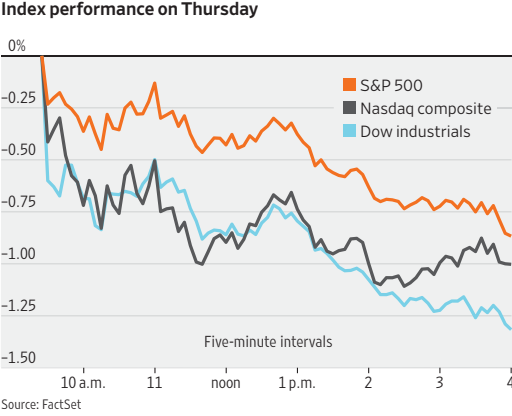
For Lowe’s, which reported sluggish growth, the middle-income homeowners to which the company caters “have a strong personal balance sheet. They got real disposable income growth,” Chief Executive Marvin Ellison said on an earnings call. “Their house is getting older and they have increased equity. But the caveat to all of that is that this consumer is being cautious. And it’s not just about fuel prices.”

U.S. consumers have spent an estimated \$88 billion more on gasoline and diesel in 2026 than they would have without the energy shock linked to the Iran War, according to Brown University’s Climate Solutions Lab. While fuel prices typi-

CORRECTIONS & AMPLIFICATIONS

Hind Rajab was 5 years old in early 2024 when she was killed in Gaza. An April 6, 2024, Page One article about civilian deaths during the war in Gaza misstated her age as 6 years old.

Readers can alert The Wall Street Journal to any errors in news articles by emailing wsjcontact@wsj.com or by calling 888-762-5450.



cally dip as summer winds down, AAA records stretching back to 2000 show nominal gas prices have never been so high this late in the year.

Crude-oil prices that help dictate those fuel costs are climbing again. Brent futures, the international benchmark, rose 2.4% Thursday to \$93.78 a barrel.

For now, many economists believe prices at the pump haven’t veered high enough to force a sharp consumer pull-back from other items that the Federal Reserve watches more closely as it sets policy. There are also some signs that spending among middle- and lower-income people isn’t only stable, but accelerating.

Discretionary spending growth by those groups jumped in July, according to a Bank of America Institute analysis of customer card

data. At the same time, growth by the top 5% of earners dipped slightly after a long run-up, narrowing the gap between income cohorts.

Consumer spending that is not too hot, and not too cold, is keeping a lid on inflation, and that has been key to the stock market’s resilience this year. Investors pared back bets in recent weeks that the central bank will increase interest rates in 2026, helping the stock market stay near records and propelling semiconductor and memory storage makers to soar.

“The economy is strong enough to avoid recession but not strong enough to drive inflation higher,” said Luke Tilley, chief economist at Wilmington Trust. “It’s really good for equity markets because it keeps the Fed on hold.”

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U.S. NEWS

Supreme Court
In a Bind Over
Ballroom Blitz

By James Romoser
and Will Hobson

WASHINGTON—President Trump’s half-built White House ballroom is a 90,000-square-foot embodiment of a recurring legal conundrum: What happens when a boundary-pushing president moves faster than courts can keep up?

The Supreme Court will soon decide whether to allow Trump to continue building the \$400 million project. But he and his administration’s lawyers have told the justices that they have no real choice at all.

Construction of the “concrete-and-steel superstructure,” they say, has advanced so far that it would be “practically impossible” to stop now, let alone tear down what has already been built.

Two lower courts have ruled that the ballroom project is probably illegal because Congress never approved it. But Trump has been allowed to build while the litigation proceeded. He has taken full advantage of that dispensation, leaving the Supreme Court in a pickle as the grace period is set to expire this week.

It is a sequence that has defined many of the legal battles of Trump’s second term. First, the administration barrels forward with some action that raises legal concerns. Lawsuits follow, and skeptical judges try to intervene. The administration then argues that it is too late for courts—either as a practical matter or as a matter of legal jurisdiction—to unwind what has been done.

James Pfander, a law professor at Northwestern University, called it the “first-mover advantage.”

“That puts the courts on their heels,” Pfander said. “It can sometimes be difficult to repair or restore the situation once the first move has been taken.”

At this point, the Supreme Court isn’t being asked to issue a final ruling on the ballroom’s legality. But if it allows the administration to continue building in the interim, the project could be all but done before the court case reaches its conclusion.

If, on the other hand, the high court allows a lower-court injunction against construction to take effect while the case continues, one of the most hallowed sites in the nation could be stuck in extended purgatory.

The unfinished construction zone would sit idle indefinitely, able to be finished only in the unlikely event that a gridlocked Congress approves it.

Trump’s move-first, move-fast strategy has unfolded most forcefully in his mass deportation agenda. When judges have questioned the legality of deportations, the administration has claimed—with mixed success—that people cannot be brought back once they have left U.S. jurisdiction.

And the administration advanced similar arguments last year as it dismantled federal agencies and withheld foreign aid. Courts were limited in what remedies they could order once those cuts were effectively final.

Now, the argument has

reached its most tangible form: the “hardened concrete,” “missile-resistant columns” and “blast-proof glass” that, according to Solicitor General John Sauer in a brief to the Supreme Court, have already been erected as construction crews hustle to complete Trump’s ballroom.

The project, which the president and his lawyers now describe as a “military complex” that comprises both a ballroom and security facilities, sits on the former site of the White House East Wing, which was demolished under Trump’s orders in October.

The administration says it has legal basis for the project under a statute that authorizes the president to manage the “improvement” or “alteration” of the White House Executive Residence.

U.S. District Judge Richard Leon found the project violates a different federal law that requires express approval by Congress for the construction of any “building or structure” on federal grounds in the District of Columbia.

Leon, a George W. Bush appointee, issued an injunction commanding the administration to halt aboveground construction, and a federal appeals panel affirmed him in a 2-1 vote.

But the injunction has been paused for months while the administration has pursued appeals. That pause will expire Friday unless the Supreme Court intervenes.

The construction site itself has become a kind of aspirational tourist attraction in downtown D.C.—a spot observers would love to see, if they can figure out how to get to it.

The site is nestled between the White House and the Treasury Building, an area that normally can be publicly viewed by visitors to Lafayette Park, just to the north. But the administration has hidden the park—and the rest of the White House grounds—behind tall chain-link fences for much of the summer.

The result is that the entire property is obscured from public view to a degree without precedent in recent history, according to Charles Birnbaum, a former National Park Service official.

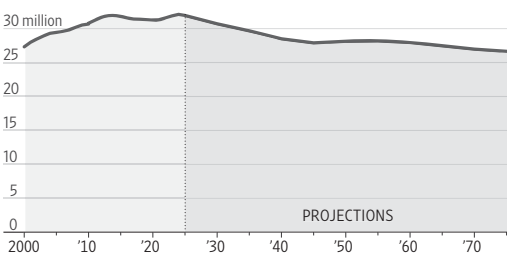
The National Trust for Historic Preservation, a congressionally chartered nonprofit corporation that is challenging the ballroom project, told the Supreme Court that the administration’s petition amounts to an attempt to “outrun judicial review.”

“The solution is not to allow Petitioners to illegally complete the entire ballroom just because they illegally commenced it,” lawyers for the trust wrote.

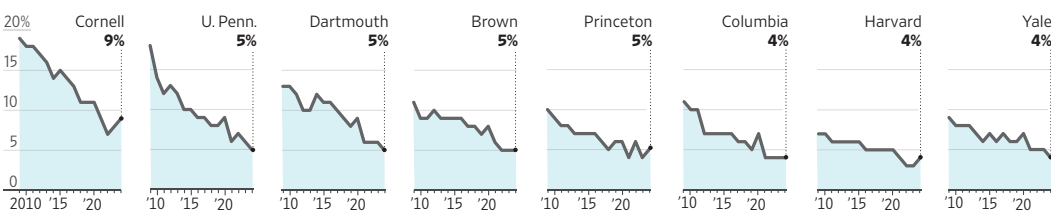
The justices could try to sidestep the issue entirely by finding that the trust doesn’t have legal standing to sue. When the case was at the appeals court, the dissenting judge—Neomi Rao, a Trump appointee—argued that the case should be dismissed for that reason.

If the Supreme Court takes that off-ramp, it would still effectively be a green light for the president.

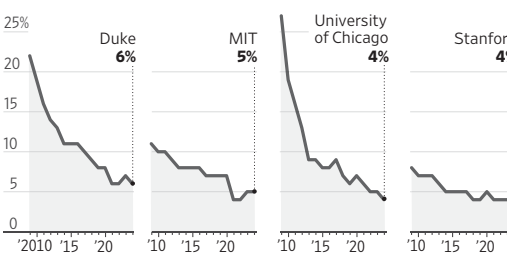
U.S. residents ages 18–24



Ivy League schools | acceptance rates

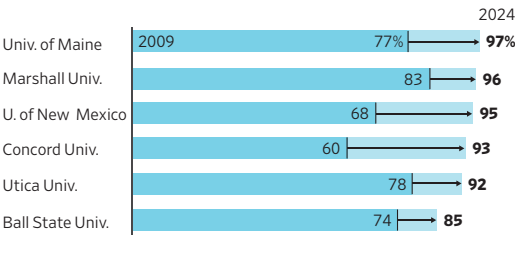


Selective schools | acceptance rates

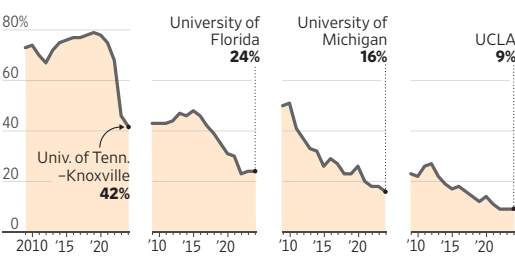


Sources: U.S. Census Bureau (residents); National Center for Education Statistics (acceptance rates)

Less selective schools | acceptance rates



Public universities | acceptance rates



U.S. Colleges Are Hurtling
Toward an Enrollment Cliff

Shrinking applicant pool isn’t expected to make it easier to get into coveted schools

By Douglas Belkin
and Josh Ullick

Higher education is hitting a demographic cliff. After years of growth, the pipeline of 18-year-olds is dwindling—a result of lower birthrates.

The largest number of Americans born in a single year arrived on campus in the autumn of 2025, and now a falloff is looming. College enrollments are forecast to drop

13% by 2041, according to the Western Interstate Commission for Higher Education. In some parts of the country—especially the Midwest and the Northeast—the declines have already begun.

You would think a shrinking pool of students would automatically make it easier to get into college. But that won’t necessarily be true everywhere, especially at the most competitive schools, higher-education analysts say.

It is impossible to precisely predict colleges’ admission rates as those numbers depend on a lot of things, including the reputations of campus culture, sports team wins and even the

weather. But the demographic cliff is hitting as another phenomenon is coming into play: a flight-to-quality, where the most sought-after schools are attracting an ever-growing number of applicants, while less-attractive schools draw fewer.

Part of the reason is rising skepticism about the value of a college degree. More families reason that if they are going to spend tens of thousands of dollars, the diploma better pay off with a good job—otherwise why bother?

This dynamic has been playing out in the Ivy League, where admission rates have fallen over the past decade-plus.

Coveted schools just out-

side the Ivies have gotten more competitive as well.

Many big public flagships are also getting more competitive. Some, such as the University of Michigan, have long held prestige. Other state schools have surged in status and are drawing students who want a classic campus experience but at a lower cost than many private schools. On the other hand, many regional or less-selective schools have become even more accessible.

On average, students now submit nearly seven applications each on the Common App, a rise of 46% since 2015-16, according to a 2024-25 report from the provider.

California Startup Investment
Dwarfs Rest of U.S. Combined

By Paul Kiernan

California is in the midst of a record-shattering investment wave, fueled by the artificial-intelligence boom in Silicon Valley.

Companies based in the Golden State have drawn around \$366 billion of venture capital since the beginning of the year, according to data provider PitchBook. That’s more than three times the amount of venture funding that has gone into the other 49 states combined, and nearly double California’s previous record, set in 2025. New York state ranks a distant second in venture-capital investment, with \$27 billion in deals announced so far this year.

California’s funding keeps coming despite the threat of a billionaire tax that detractors, including Gov. Gavin Newsom, have warned could scare off investors. Thus far, at least, investments in the biggest AI companies are keeping the frenzy going while the state’s billionaire class waits to see if voters back the new levy in November.

The capital pouring into AI has supercharged housing prices in San Francisco and created a new class of millionaires overnight. But the boom is reverberating beyond the tech-centric Bay Area: the money has also helped ease the state government’s chronic budget deficit by helping push income-tax revenues well above forecasts.

In May 2025, California’s finance department projected \$126 billion in personal-income tax revenues for the fiscal year that ended June 30. Actual income taxes instead generated around \$147 billion, as AI enthusiasm fueled a soaring stock market and boosted compensation for tech workers. Future initial public offerings of young AI companies that are raising



Billboards in downtown San Francisco advertise AI services.

venture funding today will produce additional tax revenue from capital gains.

The windfall hasn’t solved California’s long-term budget challenges but has given state leaders some unexpected, near-term flexibility. The state was able to sock away more money in reserves and spend more on education, which is required to get a certain share of revenues. The extra tax revenue also gave the state wiggle room as it funded discretionary items, from new court-houses to litter abatement.

The funding, deployed by venture-capital firms on behalf of investors including pension funds, university endowments and wealthy individuals, is funneled into young companies and startups that show potential for robust growth.

Just two AI companies have accounted for more than half of California’s venture-capital gold rush this year. In March, OpenAI raised \$122 billion in the largest funding round in Silicon Valley history. Rival AI developer Anthropic, meanwhile, has drawn \$95 billion across two funding rounds.

But smaller hauls are spread widely, with more than 4,000 California-based startups hav-

ing raised capital in 2026, according to PitchBook. In addition to AI companies, some of the more-recent deals include a \$1.37 billion funding round announced on Aug. 6 by Torrance-based defense-manufacturing startup Hadrian Automation, as well as a \$545 million raise by live commerce platform Whatnot on Aug. 7.

New technologies often agglomerate, or cluster, in a specific geographic area, whether it’s the auto industry in Detroit, the movie business in Los Angeles, or previous tech booms in the Bay Area. But the latest concentration of AI investment in Silicon Valley is particularly extreme, said Enrico Moretti, a University of California at Berkeley economist who studies the geography of jobs.

“It’s an amount of agglomeration that surpasses even previous waves,” Moretti said. The phenomenon, he said, reflects the extraordinary returns to creativity and innovation, which research suggests can be bolstered by people working in proximity to one another and sharing ideas. A “thick” labor market of workers with specialized skills—and firms that need them—also helps, Moretti said.

ICE Arrests
Captain in
N.Y. Boating
Fatalities

By Jack Morphett

The captain of an overloaded boat that capsized in New York Harbor this month, killing a woman and her 5-month-old infant, has been arrested by federal authorities and faces deportation.

Manuel Ernesto Hernandez-Umana, originally from El Salvador, was facing federal charges of misconduct and neglect of a ship officer resulting in death before he was arrested by Immigration and Customs Enforcement, the Department of Homeland Security said on Wednesday.

A Coast Guard investigation found the boat was overloaded and didn’t have any child or infant-sized life jackets when it capsized near the Statue of Liberty Aug. 8, according to court documents.

Three hours into the tour, investigators alleged Hernandez-Umana attempted to speed through swell during a U-turn and swamped the bow. This caused the boat to capsize, resulting in all 14 people being thrown overboard. The boat’s capacity was 10 people.

Passengers Sara Sanchez, 27 years old, and her 5-month-old daughter Antonella Garcia, from Queens, were recovered from the water but pronounced dead at a hospital.

Immigration authorities alleged that Hernandez-Umana lied about being a U.S. citizen to cross the southern border illegally through Texas in 2017.

“Once he faces justice for his crimes, we will make sure that he is swiftly removed from our country,” Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin said. Hernandez-Umana’s lawyer, Amy Gallicchio, declined to comment.



The ballroom construction site is obscured from public view.

U.S. NEWS

Ossoff Raises Profile With Trump Jabs

In trolling president, Georgia senator excites liberals and raises millions

By Terrell Wright and Cameron McWhirter

ATLANTA—Earlier this year, Sen. Jon Ossoff took the stage at an event in an Atlanta suburb to deliver a fiery condemnation of the Trump administration, declaring, “This is the Epstein class ruling our country.”

Clips of the February speech went viral for Ossoff, a 39-year-old Democrat in a purple state seeking re-election this fall. Donations poured in from all over the country, adding to his huge cash haul. While would-be opponents slugged it out in a Republican primary and run-off, Ossoff ignored them and kept punching at President Trump.

“While you pay more for everything, the first family’s wealth is growing by billions of dollars—because they’re crooks, and everybody knows it,” Ossoff said at an April rally.

Known for much of his time in office as a relative moderate seeking bipartisan compromise on issues like capping prescription-drug costs, Ossoff has built a reputation this year as one of the Democrats’ most relentless Trump critics. Some Democrats started look-

ing past the 2026 contest and have suggested the telegenic Ossoff should run for president in 2028.

Then came the “Natalie” remark.

Speaking Sunday in Atlanta, Ossoff declared Trump would rather “travel with Natalie” than do the job of commander in chief. The comment referenced a recent incident in Turkey, when Trump brought his aide, Natalie Harp, with him when he secretly used a catering truck to escape a potential attack on Air Force One.

The remark—which many Trump allies and critics took as implying an improper relationship—infuriated the White House. Ossoff, who has said he isn’t interested in running for president, didn’t apologize. Amid charges of sexism, he deflected a question on MS Now by saying Trump was retreating into a “bubble of West Wing aides.”

Dust-up

The dust-up came as Democrats have grown confident that Ossoff will win re-election. Before the campaign season ramped up, Republicans in Washington and Georgia saw Ossoff’s seat as a top pickup target in their efforts to retain control of the Senate.

Few see that now. The GOP nominee, Rep. Mike Collins, has been plagued by problems including reports of his son-in-law’s ties to white national-



Georgia Democratic Sen. Jon Ossoff at a rally this year in College Park, Ga. His campaign has raised \$98 million through June.

ism, and polls show Ossoff with a strong lead. Collins said his son-in-law had no ties to his campaign and he condemned racist and antisemitic views.

Some Republicans now think—or hope—Ossoff’s comment on Harp could give Collins a shot to put the Democrat on the defensive for once.

Ossoff “probably had this race won until he started running for the wrong office,” said Chip Lake, a longtime GOP strategist in Georgia. “Picking fights with female White House staffers isn’t a Senate strategy. It’s a 2028 audition tape.”

As of June 30, Ossoff’s campaign had raised about \$98 million this term, with \$77.3 million since the start of 2025. He has easily outpaced Collins, who had raised \$7.4 million since last year, according to the Federal Election Commission filings.

On Tuesday, the Collins campaign issued a news release touting a survey by a conservative pollster that showed Collins was seven points behind. The campaign said it signaled the race tightening from the double-digit deficits other polls showed.

‘Reinvent himself’

Ossoff “can spend all the money in the world trying to reinvent himself, but you can’t buy a new voting record,” said Collins campaign manager Josh Siegel. “Georgians are starting to get a good look at the one he has, and they don’t like what they see.”

Ossoff’s political career began amid Democratic angst over Trump’s victory in 2016. At 30 years old, he garnered national attention and fundraising dollars in 2017 when he was the Democratic candidate in a special election

for a congressional seat in suburban Atlanta.

The documentarian had never run for public office. He had attended a tony private school in Atlanta, and then went on to Georgetown University for an undergraduate degree and a further degree at the London School of Economics. He had worked mostly making investigative videos about corruption and human-rights abuses in Africa and the Middle East.

During that campaign, Ossoff was cautious about criticizing Trump so as not to offend Republican voters in the district. He lost, but he impressed state Democratic Party leaders trying to revive their fortunes after years of GOP dominance. In 2021 Senate runoffs, Ossoff and the Rev. Raphael Warnock unseated Republicans, handing their party narrow control of the Senate.

Once in Washington, Ossoff spent years stressing bipartisanship and focusing on reaching out to constituents, while supporting the legislative agenda of President Joe Biden. But he kept a low profile, rarely speaking to reporters or ruffling feathers.

Seth Clark, a longtime Democratic activist and a former commissioner in Macon-Bibb County, Ga., said Ossoff impressed local officials—Republican and Democrat—in Middle Georgia by focusing on constituent services.

“It was kind of a running joke that Jon Ossoff was back in Macon,” Clark said. “The presence was constant.” Now, he said, he hears from Georgians who are frustrated by inflation, gas prices and the Iran conflict, themes reflected in Ossoff’s campaigning.

“I’m glad he’s mad,” he said. “I think folks on the ground are mad.”

President Reunites With His Fixer-Turned-Foe Cohen

By Philip Wegmann

WASHINGTON—Michael Cohen said before the last presidential election that if Donald Trump ever returned to the White House, he would change his name and flee the country. Two years later, he invited his old boss onto his radio show instead.

Trump’s loyal onetime fixer turned loathed nemesis is once again cordial with the president he warned was unfit for office. The irony of the reconciliation isn’t lost on Cohen. The lead-in music to the interview: “Why Can’t We Be Friends” by War.

“They weaponized you. They weaponized a lot of people,” Trump told Cohen at the beginning of the conversation, adding that “I respect the fact that you recanted everything you said, and that’s a big thing that you did.” The former lawyer didn’t dispute that characterization from his old boss.

There was plenty of bad blood between the two men to overcome.

It was Cohen who served as the star witness in the successful 2023 New York civil trial against Trump, testifying that the then former president commanded him to “reverse engineer” estimates of his financial wealth. Inside the Manhattan



Michael Cohen on May 20, 2024, a day that he testified in Donald Trump's hush-money trial.

courtroom, a stone-faced Trump listened in-person to the testimony of his former lawyer, whom he subsequently, and repeatedly, condemned as a “liar” and a “rat.”

In 2024, Cohen also testified that Trump directed him to pay \$130,000 to porn star Stormy Daniels. A Manhattan jury found Trump guilty of 34 felonies for falsifying records to cover up the hush money payment.

The Thursday interview

marked their first public conversation since their split in 2018. Cohen played a short preview of his interview with Trump on Thursday. The remainder is slated to be aired Sunday.

Cohen spent more than a year behind bars after pleading guilty in 2018 to tax and campaign-finance crimes and lying to Congress about Trump’s plans for a Trump Tower in Moscow, among other federal charges.

A legal bruiser and self-described “fix it guy,” Cohen worked for Trump for over a decade both before and during his time in politics, defending his boss on cable news and conveying legal threats in person. He once boasted of his willingness to “take a bullet” for Trump.

But the relationship began to fray in 2018 after federal agents raided Cohen’s home and legal offices in connection with then-Special Counsel Rob-

ert Mueller’s investigation.

As legal bills began to mount and the White House attempted to distance Trump from Cohen, he reported feeling increasingly isolated and alone. He later entered a plea deal in the Southern District of New York and agreed to testify that the president had “reverse engineered” fraudulent estimates of his wealth, inspiring Trump’s enmity.

After prison, Cohen capitalized on his new infamy as a reliable Trump critic, writing a bestselling book, “Disloyal: A Memoir,” and regularly condemning his former employer in media appearances as “a cheat” and “a mobster.” After flipping on Trump, Cohen later flipped again, this time against New York Attorney General Letitia James and Manhattan District Attorney Alvin Bragg. He wrote in a blog post earlier this year that he “felt pressured and coerced to only provide information and testimony” to help secure a conviction against Trump.

Cohen landed an on-air gig at 770 WABC last month but only after billionaire businessman John Catsimatidis, the owner of the Trump-friendly radio station, said publicly that he sought approval from the White House for the new hire. He quickly teased the possibil-

ity of hosting the president for an interview. Before the Thursday interview, Cohen wrote on social media that he and the president “forgave” one another. He clarified, however, that “forgiveness doesn’t require amnesia.”

Cohen said he first reached out to Trump to make peace after hearing from an intermediary that the president regretted their fallout. Trump texted him back, Cohen said during a July radio interview with Catsimatidis, and said it was “actually time for us to meet.” “We both knew the cost of this war,” Cohen said of their longstanding feud. “In that moment the ice between us, it didn’t just melt, it broke.” A senior White House official was unaware that the former lawyer had texted his old boss and said the two men had not interacted until their August conversation.

In the lead-up to the interview, Cohen said that he had met with Trump three times in the past year. The White House didn’t respond to a request for comment about Cohen’s assertion. Earlier, Cohen told CNN that he had submitted an application for a pardon to President Joe Biden but was denied. He said on Thursday that he has since resubmitted that application to the White House, rewriting the cover letter.

Public Ire Grows Over Data Centers

Continued from Page One

progressive running for Senate in Michigan, has claimed his opponent, former GOP Rep. Mike Rogers, wants to put the centers in the backyards of voters in the state. “People really effing hate data centers,” he said at a July campaign event.

Rogers said at a Thursday event that there should be a “pause” in the sector. He previously said communities should be able to decide if they want the facilities and should be protected from rising power bills.

In Ohio, Sherrod Brown—the former Democratic senator and his party’s nominee in this year’s Senate contest—is tar-

geting Republican Sen. Jon Husted for championing AI, calling him “the face of data centers” and accusing him of backpedaling on his prior support for them. Husted has said his stance hasn’t changed and that he always pushed for companies to pay more for power and pay local taxes. He introduced legislation in Congress last month codifying stricter standards for the facilities.

The committee that works to elect Senate Republicans warned in a Tuesday memo that “data centers are the anchor hanging around Husted’s neck” and the industry will be blamed if Husted loses because of the issue. The committee said candidates can’t “fix the toxic brand of an entire segment of the economy.”

The warning has put the party at odds with its own president. Trump said on Wednesday he would welcome the centers in his state if he were a mayor or governor because of the economic benefits

they present. “If you don’t take it, you’re going to be left behind,” he said.

Ohio Republican gubernatorial candidate Vivek Ramaswamy, a critic of government regulation, pledged earlier this month to pause data-center approvals in Ohio until lawmakers pass a bill requiring companies to meet environmental standards, ensure locals receive free electricity and pay their full property tax bills.

On Wednesday, Nevada’s Democratic candidate for governor, Aaron Ford, pledged to end tax abatements for new data centers.

More than 60% of Americans now oppose new data centers in their area, up from 49% in March, a University of Pennsylvania poll found.

“If you’re a Democrat, we

haven’t had a wedge issue like this in decades,” said Brad Carson, a former Democratic congressman representing Oklahoma who is now president of a think tank advocating for stronger AI regulation.

Even Democrats like Pennsylvania Gov. Josh Shapiro, who previously embraced AI, are feeling the pressure. A potential presidential candidate in 2028, Shapiro signed an executive order Tuesday essentially giving the state the power to block the centers.

Last summer, Shapiro praised companies like Amazon for building such facilities in the state at a summit attended by Trump and other Republican leaders. Like Abbott, Shapiro is being attacked for his previous stance on AI by his opponent in his re-elec-

Voter outcry over data centers is a mounting political liability.

tion campaign.

Other Republicans wielding data centers include Rep. Tom Tiffany, who is running to become governor of Wisconsin and labeled Milwaukee County executive David Crowley “data center David” in a recent ad after Crowley said last year that the state could become an AI hub. Neither candidate has backed a moratorium like progressive Francesca Hong, who lost to Crowley in the primary last week, and both have supported some restrictions.

The backlash is a crisis for AI companies, which are facing bans or pauses on new projects in dozens of states and localities.

The opposition has the potential to slash 2% to 3% off annual economic growth if it metastasizes, venture capitalist Chamath Palihapitiya said on X Thursday. “This is a powder keg,” he wrote.

Industry executives said they would make good on promises to pay more for power and minimize water

consumption, but many locals don’t trust the sector.

“We are trying to catch up to this narrative and it continues to grow by leaps and bounds,” said Dan Diorio, executive vice president of state policy and government affairs for the Data Center Coalition, an industry group.

States like Texas had previously welcomed the facilities, which store many types of on-line data and generate steady streams of tax revenue. Abbott signed legislation more than a decade ago giving data centers tax breaks to attract more technology investment.

ChatGPT’s 2022 launch and the subsequent AI explosion caught states off guard, turbocharging energy and water consumption at facilities that support it.

Because of its abundant land and energy, as well as friendly permitting, Texas now has more than 500 data centers, second only to Virginia, according to industry tracking platform Data Center Map.

U.S. NEWS



Police officers in Liberia stood outside the airport near Monrovia where a plane carrying deportees landed on Thursday.

U.S. Sends Migrants to Liberia Under New Deportation Pact

By VICTORIA ALBERT

The U.S. has begun deporting immigrants to Liberia, officials in the West African country said, part of President Trump’s wider plan to send migrants to third-party countries.

A plane carrying an initial group of deportees landed on Thursday at the Roberts International Airport, about 40 miles east of the capital in Monrovia, a spokesman for the Liberian government said. The flight is part of a broader plan, announced by Liberian officials on Tuesday, for the country to take up to 1,200 deportees in the next year.

Trump has aggressively pursued arrangements that would allow the U.S. to deport

immigrants to third-party countries, usually in the case of people whose home nations are either slow to take them back or refuse to do so. Several attempts to remove deportees in this way have faced legal challenges.

A Homeland Security spokesperson said the department wouldn’t confirm removal operations, citing operational security. The State Department said it doesn’t comment on the details of private diplomatic communications with other governments.

The Trump administration has entered into third-country agreements with more than 35 nations, including South Sudan, Mexico and Uganda, a pair of human-rights groups

tracking the transfers said on Tuesday. More than 23,000 people have been transferred to third-party countries, many of whom have no legal or personal ties to their new home, the groups said.

Humanitarian groups have harshly criticized the transfers, saying they put migrants at risk of incarceration and inhumane treatment. They also cite the potential for what is known as “chain refoulement,” when asylum seekers and refugees are sent by the third country back to the home from which they originally fled.

Liberian officials said migrants sent to the country will be free to leave or apply for asylum. The country’s Ministry of Information said it

hasn’t asked for or received any compensation, instead viewing the agreement as a humanitarian gesture.

“Those being brought to Liberia are being received as guests of the Republic, in keeping with Liberia’s long-standing tradition of being a country that has provided shelter to all those seeking refuge and protection from persecution, wars and other forms of conflict,” said Information Minister Jerolinmek Matthew Piah.

Liberia is a small country tucked between Sierra Leone and Ivory Coast on Africa’s western edge.

The English-speaking nation now has about 5.7 million residents, according to the United Nations.

SAN FRANCISCO
Devices Seized From Ex-Rep. Swalwell

Federal agents seized electronic devices from former Rep. Eric Swalwell and searched his Washington, D.C., home as part of an investigation into allegations of sexual misconduct by the Democratic former congressman from California, a person familiar with the matter said.

Swalwell’s devices were seized at the San Francisco airport on Saturday and agents executed a search warrant at his home a day later, the person said. A message seeking comment was left Thursday with an attorney for Swalwell, who has denied allegations of sexual assault and misconduct.

Swalwell announced his resignation from Congress in April following allegations that he had sexually assaulted a woman twice.

—Associated Press

POLITICS
Convention Site Down to 3 Cities

Democrats on Thursday narrowed the list of potential host cities for their 2028 presidential convention to Boston, Denver and Philadelphia.

A final decision is expected later this year. Republicans have already picked Houston for their 2028 convention.

The Democratic convention, scheduled for Aug. 7-10, 2028, traditionally gives the party a chance to formally introduce its nominee to the country, rally the base and kick-start the most intense period of campaigning ahead of the general election.

The party didn’t specify why Atlanta and Chicago were eliminated. Officials visited all five cities in April and May, considering logistical and fundraising capacity among other factors.

—Associated Press

PENNSYLVANIA
One Dead in Crash Of Plane, Helicopter

An airplane pilot died on Wednesday after a collision with a Pennsylvania State Police helicopter near a runway at a small airport in Carlisle, authorities said. Both state troopers aboard the helicopter survived.

The plane was coming down on the runway and veered into the helicopter, which was near the ground, said Lt. Col. George Bivens, the state’s acting police commissioner. He said part of the investigation will be making sure the pilot was the only person on board. He said the helicopter lost its blades and tail boom and crashed onto its side.

Both of the pilots in the helicopter were trapped until one pushed out a window and helped the other out through it, Bivens said.

—Associated Press

Trump Aims to Revive Keystone XL Pipeline From Canada to Gulf

By RYAN DEZEMBER

President Trump suggested a revival of the long-contested Keystone XL oil pipeline could be in the cards when he said the U.S. is close to reaching a trade deal with Canada to avert new tariffs.

Pipeline developers are already piecing together an alternative to the scuttled Keystone expansion.

Trump has signed his support for the alternative supply line. He issued a permit in April to allow it to cross the border in Montana. That project is part of a trio of proposed pipelines that aim to deliver heavy oil from western Canada to Gulf Coast refineries able to process the sludgy crude.

In other words, it would serve the same function as Keystone XL—without the hot-button name. The new plans even seek to use portions of the stalled Keystone project and may face similar opposition.

“They’re trying to get away from calling it Keystone....They don’t want to be related to it,” said Jaxson Fryer, lead equity analyst at pipeline research firm East Daley Analytics. “But then three pipes makes it even more risky because you need each of those to go through.”

A White House spokeswoman declined to comment on the pipeline plans, and a representative for Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney didn’t immediately respond.

Carney said last fall that he and Trump had discussed cooperating on energy projects, including a Keystone XL revival, as part of their broader trade talks. The Canadian government has long supported Keystone XL.

The roughly 1,200-mile Keystone XL project has been a contentious political issue since it was proposed in 2008, when fuel prices hovered near records. It was planned as an 830,000-barrel-a-day expansion of the existing Keystone Pipe-

line System that connects Western Canada to coastal Texas.

The project was called off in 2021 following a decade of legal challenges and protests from environmental groups, farmers, Native American groups and others who cited the threat of spills. Many opponents hoped that by killing Keystone XL, the crude extracted from Canada’s oil sands would be left in the ground. It is considered among the most greenhouse-gas intensive energy in the world.

In January 2021, on his first day in office, then-President Joe Biden revoked a key permit for Keystone XL. Then-Prime Minister Justin Trudeau said he was “disappointed.” That was expected to be the saga’s end.

“The great Keystone XL Pipeline, long ago killed by Sleepy Joe Biden, may be awoken from the grave!” Trump posted on social media Tuesday night when he said he would pause a 50% tariff on certain goods from Canada while the countries negotiate.

The government of Alberta and Keystone XL’s original proponent, TransCanada, now known as TC Energy, abandoned the expansion plans a few months after Biden revoked the permit. In 2024, TC spun off its liquids pipelines business that includes Keystone into a new Calgary-based company called South Bow.

South Bow executives have told investors that they are eager to make use of a section of the Keystone XL project that was built in Canada before the project was canceled, as well as pipeline capacity between the oil-trading hub in Cushing, Okla., and the Gulf Coast. Chief Executive Bevin Wirzba has said the time is right between control of the White House shifting back to Trump and wars in the Persian Gulf and Ukraine choking off global energy supplies.

U.S. WATCH



MERMAID ALERT: Revelers at the Carnival Parade in Provincetown, Mass., on Thursday.

SpaceX Amasses Big Wins

Continued from Page One

sions said, Pentagon leaders planned to hire Elon Musk’s rocket company to back a big part of President Trump’s planned Golden Dome project. The program, designed to use satellites to track enemy missiles and aircraft, would be worth billions of dollars.

Some lawmakers in Congress were alarmed by the prospect of a single company locking up a major national-security program for years to come, the people said, and they pushed for other suppliers’ involvement.

The U.S. Space Force opened a window for proposals from more companies, but the specific criteria and a challenging timeline kept other potential bidders out of the mix. Some companies avoided bidding at all.

This year, SpaceX was awarded the contract to de-

velop hundreds of tracking satellites, valued at about \$4.2 billion. The Space Force later hired three other companies to serve the program, offering contracts valued at as much as \$615 million.

A Space Force spokeswoman said program requirements are contractor-agnostic and that its acquisition strategy was designed to foster open competition and meet military needs.

“As with any contract awarded to industry, no funding was allocated for any company until after the full and open competitions concluded,” the Space Force said.

SpaceX didn’t respond to requests to comment.

‘Very bullish’

In addition to the missile-tracking contract, SpaceX was also chosen to provide military data satellites and rocket launches for the Golden Dome program.

SpaceX currently is in line for more than \$8 billion in Golden Dome related contracts—at least a third of the total budgeted for the project so far.

SpaceX is the world’s busiest rocket launcher, regularly

deploying satellites and other payloads to orbit from multiple launch sites, with an established record on high-profile government projects.

Musk has maintained close ties with Trump, a Republican. He campaigned with Trump in the last election, had an advisory role in the White House, and plans to spend at least \$100 million to boost GOP candidates during the mid-term elections.

SpaceX also maintains connections with lawmakers of both parties, contributing to campaigns and creating thousands of jobs around the country.

In a filing ahead of its IPO, the company said its business could be damaged by changes in Congress or the presidency. SpaceX’s long-running push for lighter-touch regulations has aligned with the Trump administration’s deregulatory efforts.

Musk has chafed at federally mandated environmental reviews related to the com-

pany’s Starship rockets.

Federal transportation officials proposed in July rolling back environmental oversight covering space-related activities, exempting launches and spaceport development from laws that require federal agencies to assess impacts and alternatives.

Across the spectrum

A Transportation Department spokesman said the effort would help all innovators in the U.S. space sector in the country’s race against China in orbit.

SpaceX has also scored wins at the Federal Communications Commission, which in May approved the company’s plan to purchase spectrum rights to connect mobile phones with satellites.

In greenlighting that deal, the FCC waived a requirement that the owner of the wireless resources maintain ground infrastructure to ensure certain cellular service levels around

the country.

The FCC said in an order that keeping the rule would burden SpaceX, and that the company’s network would promote U.S. leadership in connectivity.

SpaceX secured in January a separate FCC waiver aimed at ensuring satellites stationed closer to Earth wouldn’t interfere with those operating farther away. The FCC granted it as the agency worked on a broader review of related rules.

The FCC is also considering a SpaceX plan to deploy as many as one million artificial-intelligence satellites, core to the company’s ambition to build out its AI operations.

The FCC hasn’t weighed in yet on SpaceX’s proposed AI satellite fleet, but its chairman, Brendan Carr, rebuked one of the company’s rivals for seeking its dismissal.

Amazon.com, which is developing its own satellite network, called on the FCC to reject SpaceX’s proposal, describing it as both vague and speculative.

Carr said on X that Amazon should focus on its own FCC-established satellite milestones “rather than spending

their time and resources filing petitions against companies that are putting thousands of satellites in orbit.”

An Amazon spokesman declined to comment. An FCC spokesman said the space industry is now booming in ways that will benefit consumers.

Facing Pushback

SpaceX’s winning record in Washington has some lawmakers worried about growing reliance on a single company for sensitive projects.

Sen. Jack Reed (D, R.I.), ranking member of the Senate Armed Services Committee, referenced its “long-standing concern about SpaceX’s near monopoly position in launch and proliferated satellite constellations” at a recent hearing.

In August, the Space Force announced it would bring five more companies into a satellite program designed to transmit military data. Those firms will split \$60 million among them, to demonstrate their technology.

Months before, SpaceX had won a contract to deliver what officials called the “backbone” of the network. That deal was worth nearly \$2.3 billion.

SpaceX has secured billions to build and launch military satellites.

WORLD NEWS

Kyiv Hit Hard
As Defense
Options Wane

In its latest attacks, Russia exploits global shortage of missile interceptors

By IAN LOVETT
AND NIKITA NIKOLAIENKO

KYIV, Ukraine—Russia launched a large missile and drone attack on Kyiv, the latest in a string of assaults on Ukraine’s capital, which has been left exposed this summer by the global shortage of Patriot air-defense missiles.

The attack killed at least 15 people in and around Kyiv on Wednesday night, said Ukrainian officials. About 40 others were injured. A children’s hospital and a school were among the locations that were hit.

For much of the war, Ukraine was able to intercept even Russia’s most advanced long-range missiles, using U.S.-designed Patriot air-defense systems. But the wars in the Middle East have stretched the West’s supply of the Patriot interceptor missiles thin. Ukraine now has few left, which means more Russian missiles reach their targets.

Ukrainians fear this could be the first in a wave of brutal assaults leading up to Ukrainian independence day on Monday—a date on which Moscow often has launched missile barrages.

And many residents are wondering how they can last through a winter without sufficient missile defenses. Last winter, Russian attacks knocked out much of Ukraine’s power supply, leaving many homes without heat.

Ukraine’s air force said it shot down 39 of the 44 missiles Wednesday night, as well as 145 out of 168 long-range Shahed-type drones.

“As long as Ukraine does not have enough antiballistic defense, Russia will not consider peace seriously,” Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said Thursday on social media.

While Ukraine was working to build its own missile defense systems, he said, “Patriot interceptors cannot yet be replaced...every additional missile saves the lives of our people.”

Russia targeted sites around the country, Zelensky said, including a border crossing between Ukraine and Moldova, and gas infrastructure in the northern Chernihiv region.

Most of the damage, however, was in Kyiv.

Outside a nine-story apartment building that was struck, residents lined up at a tent outside Thursday morning, applying for compensation. As they stood, pieces of the building continued to shear off and crash to the ground.

Pavlo Petrov, a spokesman for the state emergency services, said the strike started a fire on the top three floors, with people trapped inside. Two bodies were recovered from the rubble, he said, and the search was ongoing.

“There was very little time between the air raid alert and the explosions,” Petrov said. “People simply didn’t have enough time to get downstairs or reach a shelter.”

Oleksandr Avstriievskyyh, 65 years old, was in his fifth-floor apartment around midnight when the air-raid siren went off. He was preparing to go to the shelter when a huge explosion knocked him to the floor.

“I realized that if the attack had already started, I needed to move. I quickly grabbed my documents and the money I



SERHII KOROVANY FOR WSJ (2)



Russian missile and drone strikes hit areas in and around Kyiv this week.

during the attack.

Like so many Ukrainians, the family is wondering how they will make it through the winter. Last year, during the worst of the power outages, family members and neighbors gathered at Yavorskaya’s house, which had a gas-heating system and a generator.

From the damage—a gaping hole in one wall and concrete falling from the ceiling—the house won’t be an option this year.

Yarovskiy said he would try to repair his own apartment, and the entire family would stay there, even though the apartment has electric heating and the temperature inside often dropped below freezing last winter.

“We have nowhere to go,” Yavorskaya said. “This house was built in 1905. It survived all the wars, until now.”

Watch a Video



Russia pounds Ukraine, which faces a shortage of interceptor missiles.

Romanian Jet Fighters Destroy Naval Drone in the Black Sea

By Laurence Norman

Romania said it deployed two F-16 jet fighters to destroy a Russia-launched explosive marine drone that threatened hundreds of lives near one of its gas platforms.

Romanian Defense Minister Radu Miruta said the naval drone was spotted a few hundred yards away from the Neptun Deep platform, 80 miles east of the Romanian Black Sea city of Constanta.

The decision was taken, in consultation with NATO, to destroy the drone to protect the lives of the several hundred people who were working on the platform and to secure the infrastructure, Miruta said in a Facebook post.

He added that the Ukraini-

ans had informed Romania the drone wasn’t theirs.

Romanian President Nicu-sor Dan pointed the finger at Moscow.

“I strongly condemn the intensification of these types of irresponsible incidents on the part of the Russian Federation. We remain vigilant alongside NATO allies to defend ourselves and repel such challenges,” he wrote in a post on X.

The Kremlin didn’t respond to a request for comment.

In June, a Ukrainian naval drone exploded at the Romanian port of Constanta after drifting to Romania’s coast. After that incident, Romania’s government requested Ukraine ensure its drones are programmed to self-destruct if they come near Romanian waters.

The eastern frontier of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, of which Romania is a member, has been plagued by drone incursions this summer, raising fears that the war be-

tween Ukraine and Russia is increasingly bleeding into the alliance’s territory.

NATO jets have scrambled to shoot down the aerial drones, including those that have breached its airspace as a result of Russian electromagnetic warfare.

Russia has deployed spoofing and jamming networks across its western military dis-

trict to disrupt Ukrainian long-range strike drones, leading to numerous incidents in recent months of Ukrainian drones inadvertently crossing into the airspace of neighboring NATO states.

NATO-member engagement with a sea drone is a rarer event, however, and prompted European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen on Thursday to say Europe was facing “an escalating campaign of threats.”

“This is hybrid warfare,” she said in a post on X.

Russia has been systemati-

cally using drones to probe air defenses in Europe, looking for weaknesses to exploit, Germany’s top military officer told The Wall Street Journal recently, amid what he called an intensifying gray-zone campaign aimed at destabilizing the Continent’s governments and institutions.

Neptun Deep is set to become the largest gas producer in Romania, entrenching the country’s place as the European Union’s leading producer of the fuel and crucial to the Continent’s energy security.

The incident on Thursday underscores the security threat to the Black Sea, a hub for global grain trade and Ukraine’s lifeline to the world economy. Attacks by Russia and more recently Ukraine have set ships

and port infrastructure ablaze at both ends of the sea, an ominous sign for the rest of the world’s food supplies.

Last week, NATO scrambled four jets to down a foreign drone that entered Latvia’s airspace on Friday, in what that country’s ministry of defense said was the result of Russian electromagnetic warfare.

NATO jets also recently pursued drones that entered Romanian airspace near the Ukrainian border, the alliance said, without specifying the origin of the unmanned vehicles. NATO said it was aware of the incident on Thursday, and added that the fact the maritime drone was destroyed by an F-16 “demonstrated continued readiness to respond to any potential threat.”

Romania’s president pointed the finger at Moscow.

Spain Moves Migrants From North Africa Enclave



TRANSFER POINT: Spanish authorities cleared a beach in Ceuta on Thursday as part of a plan to relocate migrants to temporary shelters. About 72,000 people, mostly Moroccans, swarmed into the Spanish territory in North Africa this month.

Canada Producer Prices Climb, Buoyed by Fuel

By Robb M. Stewart

OTTAWA—Canadian manufactured-goods prices rose again in July, driven higher by a jump in fuel costs with a resumption of the conflict in the Middle East, though a drop in crude-oil prices early in July helped drive down manufacturers’ raw-material costs.

Statistics Canada’s industrial product price index increased 0.6% in July from the month before. Compared with a year earlier, prices were 12.4% higher.

Cost pressures have remained elevated since the start of the Iran conflict. Product prices have risen in six of the past seven months, after slipping 0.6% in June, as energy prices fell following a tentative peace deal.

Prices for energy and petroleum increased 6.4% for the month, led by rises in diesel fuel and gasoline. Excluding the energy component, Canadian producer prices slipped 0.2% between June and July.

Crude-oil shipments through the Strait of Hormuz recovered briefly in July, pushing crude-oil prices down. However, Statistics Canada noted International Energy Agency data showed that refined product markets remained tight, pushing petroleum refinery margins to four-year highs in early July.

Prices of primary non-ferrous metal products declined 5.2% in July, led by a drop in gold, silver and platinum group metals, and their alloys.

Prices in Canada for chemicals and chemical products fell 3.4%, driven by fertilizers, pesticides and other chemical products as well as lower prices for plastic resins.

Compared with July 2025, prices for most industrial products were higher. Energy and petroleum was up sharply, with prices for diesel fuel 50.3% higher and finished gasoline up 44.7%. Unwrought gold and silver prices also have surged from a year ago.

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WORLD NEWS

Trump Wants a Summit Kim Doesn't Need

North Korea's strengthened role could make it tough to set new meeting

By TIMOTHY W. MARTIN

SEOUL—President Trump wants to meet Kim Jong Un again. But landing another face-to-face exchange will take convincing a North Korean leader who has spurned U.S. outreach in recent years.

Pyongyang has repeatedly asserted it must be recognized as a nuclear-armed state to sit down again with Washington.

Kim makes such demands from a position of strength, with his economy growing, an expanding nuclear arsenal and stronger ties with Russia and China.

Trump said he expects to meet Kim this year, suggesting the North Korean leader had already positively responded. The remarks came after the president ordered a curtailment of U.S.-South Korea military drills, a longtime irritant for the Kim regime. Pyongyang on Wednesday called the

pullback immaterial and disputed the two leaders had recently communicated.

Nonetheless, North Korea described the relationship between Kim and Trump as excellent, leaving open the door for potential talks.

Getting there will require Trump to use his rapport with Kim to engage a North Korea that is seemingly content with the status quo and has fewer apparent reasons to engage with the U.S.

Pyongyang has mastered sanctions evasion and generated billions of dollars in illicit funds, including having cyberoperatives land remote work at U.S. companies. Kim has flaunted his ties with China and Russia, holding summits with Chinese leader Xi and Russian President Vladimir Putin.

North Korea, because of veto power wielded by Moscow and Beijing, doesn't fear pressure from the United Nations as it pursues spy satellites, nuclear submarines and hypersonic missiles.

The activity also includes sanctions-violating weapons tests. On Thursday, North Ko-

'Kim Jong Un is having the best days of his life right now, unfortunately.'



Kim Jong Un greets veterans marking the 73rd anniversary of the Korean War armistice.

rea launched around 10 short-range ballistic missiles from the Pyongyang area.

A Kim regime with fewer vulnerabilities leaves Trump with less leverage to entice Pyongyang.

North Korea has historically sought a drawdown of U.S. forces stationed in South Korea, a removal of U.S. nuclear weapons from the region and a normalization of diplomatic ties with Washington.

In exchange, Kim could of-

fer Trump a splashy foreign-policy victory that has proved elusive in the Middle East and Europe. The two Koreas technically remain at war, following a 1953 armistice that suspended active hostilities. That leaves space for a peace accord.

North Korea, after amassing a sizable stockpile of nuclear warheads, may feel it has enough for now, allowing Trump to potentially tout a production halt.

Kim finds himself being

courted and wooed simultaneously by the leaders of the U.S., China, Russia and South Korea, said Sung-Yoon Lee, a principal fellow at the Sejong Institute, a think tank in Seoul.

"Kim Jong Un is having the best days of his life right now, unfortunately," Lee said.

In 2018 and 2019, Trump and Kim met in Singapore, Vietnam and the Korean Demilitarized Zone. Washington and Pyongyang last held for-

mal nuclear talks nearly seven years ago.

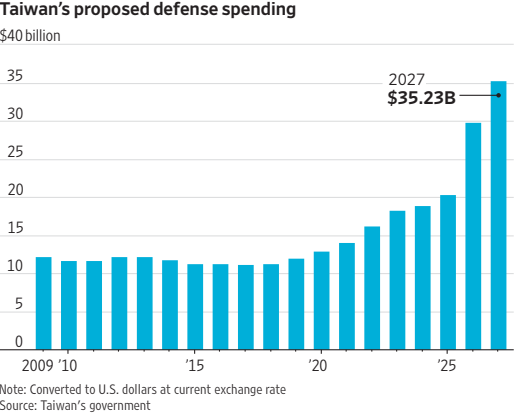
The buildup to that bout of diplomacy stands in contrast to the niceties shared between the two leaders now.

Before meeting face-to-face in Singapore, Trump had slammed Kim as "little rocket man" as Pyongyang carried out a spree of weapons launches, including a long-range missile that could reach the mainland U.S. and a nuclear test. Kim called Trump "mentally deranged" and bragged about the nuclear button sitting on his desk.

The tensions cooled quickly after Kim, in a 2018 New Year's address, extended an olive branch to Seoul. Kim offered to send a delegation to the Winter Olympics, which were held in South Korea. That kicked off talks that resulted in the Singapore summit, with Seoul serving as a key facilitator between Washington and Pyongyang.

In recent years, North Korea has severed ties with the South. Kim abandoned the country's decades-old policy of pursuing peaceful reunification between the two countries.

South Korean President Lee Jae Myung, in a recent speech, proposed reviving dialogue with the North to discuss a formal end to the 1950-53 Korean War. Pyongyang hasn't publicly responded.



Taiwan Raises Budget For Defense to Record

By JOYU WANG

TAIPEI—Taiwan's government proposed its highest level of military spending ever at over \$35 billion, in a \$123 billion budget for 2027 unveiled on Thursday.

The government said the budget includes 1.1225 trillion New Taiwan dollars for defense, equivalent to around \$35.2 billion, a sum that includes funds for the coast guard, pensions and special budgets for buying arms from the U.S.

The proposed defense budget is the first to exceed the symbolic NT\$1 trillion threshold, with an 18% increase from last year. It would put Taiwan's military spending at around 3.93% of 2025 gross domestic product, up from this year's 3.23%, the government said.

President Trump has pushed for more military spending by Taiwan and others in a region that depends on the U.S. to deter China. The new budget—

and the declared spending-to-GDP ratio of nearly 4%—sends a signal that Taiwan is investing in self-defense and is ready to buy more U.S. weapons.

The budget also serves as a reminder of the Taipei government's determination to strengthen the island's defenses against China, which sees Taiwan as its own territory, to be seized by force if necessary. Taiwan aims to make an invasion too potentially painful for China's much larger security force to try it.

For Taiwan to buy U.S. arms, Washington needs to sign off on the sales. Trump has withheld approval of a \$14 billion arms package, calling it "a very good negotiating chip" with China.

The opposition-controlled legislature has repeatedly held up and squeezed President Lai Ching-te's military-spending requests. Lawmakers only just approved a 2026 budget on Friday.

China Sentences Property Tycoon Who Went Bust to Life in Prison

By JIAHUI HUANG

Hui Ka Yan was once one of the world's richest men, a property tycoon who used his company's billions to buy a soccer club and fund medical research at Harvard University.

On Thursday, a court in China sentenced Hui to life in prison after the nation's property bust led to the collapse of his China Evergrande Group.

The court in Shenzhen found Hui, 67 years old, and Evergrande entities carried out sustained and large-scale financial fraud between 2016 and 2021 to inflate assets and hide liabilities, the state-run Xinhua News Agency reported.

Those were the years when Hui was promising to build more than a million housing units across China, while the group he founded in 1996 amassed liabilities that at one point topped the equivalent of \$300 billion.

Hui, who pleaded guilty to the charges in April, was ordered to forfeit all of his personal assets. Evergrande and its flagship property unit were collectively fined the equivalent of more than \$2 billion, Xinhua reported.

The court said authorities would continue seeking to recover Hui's illegal gains.

Evergrande's growth machine was fueled by a simple cycle: borrow, buy land, pre-sell apartments and borrow again. For years, rising home prices and seemingly endless



Hui Ka Yan pleaded guilty to fraud charges in April and was ordered to forfeit his personal assets.

demand in China made the business model look unsalable.

At its peak, Evergrande was far more than a property developer. Hui expanded into soccer, bottled water endorsed by actor Jackie Chan, electric vehicles and finance. In 2010, Evergrande bought Guangzhou's soccer club and poured money into building a team that won the Asian Champions League in 2013.

Hui donated money to Harvard medical research and toured the campus in 2018 with Harvard's then-president.

The university named an immunology center after Ev-

ergrande and called Hui a "generous supporter" in 2020 when he was offering to fund Covid-19 research.

But the pandemic proved to be the trigger for an economic slowdown that led Evergrande to unravel, leaving hundreds of thousands of units unfinished and angry customers who couldn't get their deposits back.

Evergrande defaulted on some debt in late 2021 and

\$300B
Peak liabilities at China Evergrande Group, run by Hui Ka Yan

was ordered into liquidation by a Hong Kong court in January 2024.

The property bust symbolized by Evergrande continues to drag down China's economy, years after the company's demise, and the real-estate market still hasn't hit bottom. Property investment in China in the first seven months of this year fell 19% compared with the same period a year earlier.

WORLDWATCH



POLKA (DOTS) AND FLAMENCO: Dancers and musicians filled the center of Málaga, Spain, on Thursday during the celebration of the annual eight-day Feria summer festival.

CENTRAL AFRICAN REPUBLIC
More Bodies Found In Collapsed Mine

Hopes of finding survivors at a collapsed gold mine in Central African Republic were fading Thursday, two days after the disaster killed more than 100 people and left others buried under debris.

Rescuers continued recovering bodies from the artisanal mining site in Zamboye, near the border with Cameroon, but local workers said the response lacked the equipment and expertise needed for a disaster of this scale.

The local Red Cross was helping with the search, but couldn't say how many people remained buried, volunteer Gervais Ganagoro said.

"We continue to find bodies," he said, adding that more than 10 were recovered on Thursday morning alone.

Local officials and the Red Cross said Wednesday that more than 100 people had died in the collapse and warned the toll was likely to rise.

—Associated Press

BANGLADESH
Veteran Politician Elected President

Parliament elected a stalwart of the country's new ruling party to the presidency on Thursday after the post fell vacant in July following the resignation of the former president, who was a close ally of ousted Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina.

The vote confirmed the expected victory of Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir, a veteran of the ruling Bangladesh Nationalist Party, or BNP, who got 255 votes to 88 for challenger Oli Ahmed of the opposition Jamaat-e-Islami party and its allies.

Alamgir was a longtime BNP secretary-general. He steered the political movement against the 15-year rule of Hasina. She fled the country in August 2024 during a mass uprising over allegations of autocratic rule and corruption in the allocation of government jobs, and her party has been barred from politics since last year.

—Associated Press

NIGERIA
Boat Capsizes, Killing Dozens

A boat capsized on Thursday in a river in Nigeria's northwestern Sokoto state, leaving at least 47 people dead, officials and residents said.

The boat was carrying more than 80 people, most of whom were heading to farms for work in Gorau town in the Goronyo local government area of the state, officials said.

Abdulkadir Yusuf, Sokoto state manager at the National Inland Waterways Authority, said the death toll was 47 people so far.

Deadly boat accidents are common in Nigeria, especially during the rainy season.

A lack of enforcement of safety regulations allows faulty boats to operate in the country.

In January, at least 25 people were killed in Yobe state in a similar accident.

—Associated Press

WORLD NEWS



American soldiers in the Hurtgen Forest in 1944.

WWII Ammo Is Hampering Wildfire Battle

Firefighters use military-style gear to tame blazes raging on old battlefields

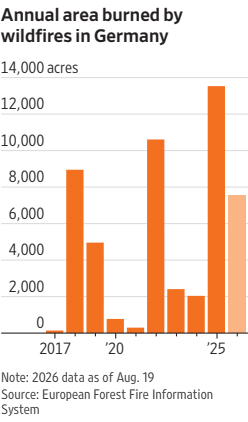
Ed Ballard

Consuming a few hundred acres, the fire in the Hurtgen Forest, western Germany, was a mere barbecue compared with the conflagrations that have recently threatened Mediterranean tourist spots and burned swaths of Canadian forest. But the fire forced the evacuation of nearly 2,000 people from a nearby village. Extinguishing it took almost as many firefighters and other emergency personnel, as well as 10 helicopters. The landscape presented its own challenge: It is littered with ammunition, the legacy of a World War II battle in which the invading U.S. First Army suffered more than 30,000 casualties. The unexploded ordnance, some of

which was heard going off during the dayslong effort to quench the fire, made it harder for firefighters to get close to the blaze. Explosive wildfires are another entry in Europe’s fast-lengthening catalog of weather-related disruption. A scorching summer has shrunk rivers, parched crops and tested the continent’s infrastructure. High-tech responses are emerging. Last year, the state of Brandenburg bought two remote-controlled tanks—one with a grabbing arm and a fire hose that can shoot water or foam 180 feet, another that flays the ground to remove vegetation—and an armored vehicle for their operators to sit in. In the heavily forested state, where large areas served as training grounds in the former East Germany, nearly 20% of the land is suspected to harbor old munitions. The system, which cost



Smoke fills the sky over the village of Gey from a wildfire in the Hurtgen Forest in western Germany earlier this month.



roughly \$3.5 million, was deployed in late July and early August at a forest fire near a former military training area near the town of Jüterbog, said Norman Barth, a wildfire expert working for Brandenburg’s government. The idea is to let firefighters reach areas that hadn’t been checked by bomb-disposal

teams so they can cut firebreaks and douse strategic patches of land to protect key areas. For Lindon Pronto, a Californian firefighter turned wildfire adviser who helped conceive Brandenburg’s setup, the growing risk from unexploded ordnance is just one example of how fiercer blazes are straining firefighting practices in many parts of the world. “It’s changing everywhere,” he said. “The intensity is catching people off guard.” Pronto envisions unmanned tanks aiding firefighters in other former battlegrounds such as Syria and—eventually—Ukraine, part of an array of devices aiding firefighting in hazardous terrain. Others thinking along similar lines include Drone Amplified, a startup whose unmanned aerial vehicles drop balls containing fire-starting chemicals to ignite controlled burns. South San Francisco-based Burnbot has developed monstrous tracked machines with

arrays of torches for the same purpose. If these strategies take off, one ironic outcome might be a new business line for arms manufacturers. Rheinmetall, the standard-bearer for European remilitarization, recently acquired a majority stake in DOK-ING, the company behind Brandenburg’s remote-controlled vehicles (slogan: “Don’t send a man to do a machine’s job”). Rheinmetall has been making ammo since before World War I, and presumably its factories produced their fair share of the shells still lurking in Germany’s soil. In acreage terms, Germany’s wildfires are small, but they are getting worse—and the conflicts of the last century add an extra dimension

of peril. Johann Goldammer, head of the Global Fire Monitoring Center, a research and advisory group in Germany, said extended hot dry spells and the deterioration of old ammunition are making explosions more likely. The cyclical freezing and thawing of soil also brings old shells to the surface, Goldammer said, much as flower beds can seem to produce fresh stones every winter. In the long run, containing Germany’s wildfires may require deeper change. Barth said replacing flammable pine forests with mixed woodlands would help. So would accelerating the process of detecting and removing old munitions. “Maybe we will be ready in 100 years,” Barth said.

In part of Germany, nearly 20% of the land is thought to have old munitions.

Low Rhine Water Levels Seen Slowing Germany’s Economy

By Ed Frankl

Low water levels in Germany caused by recent heat waves, particularly on the River Rhine, are likely to impede the country’s economic growth in the third quarter, the Bundesbank said on Thursday. “The only limited availability of transport routes on major rivers and sharply rising transport costs are expected to place significant constraints on industrial output and export growth,” the country’s central bank said in its August monthly report. The water gauge at the Rhine bottleneck of Kaub, in western Germany, notched a record low in recent days,

meaning ships must carry fewer goods to pass through. Much of Western Europe endured its hottest June and July on record. The shallow water levels are set to lead to additional delivery delays, further exacerbating material shortages, increasing transport costs and delaying production, the Bundesbank said. “This will put a marked strain on industrial activity that has otherwise just started to strengthen,” it said. While the economy has proved more resilient than expected to the jump in energy prices caused by the war in Iran in the first half of 2026, activity is likely to at best only expand marginally in the

third quarter, the report said. After only subdued growth last year, gross domestic product increased 0.4% and 0.2% in the first and second quarters, respectively, mainly driven by strong demand for its exported goods, though that could unwind in the months ahead. Some economists have pointed to the growth in exports as evidence of foreign companies temporarily stockpiling German goods before the expected rise in costs and supply issues because of the conflict in the Middle East. Low capacity utilization in the industrial sector and the rise in European Central Bank interest rates in June are damping corporate invest-



River traffic on the Rhine has fallen, leading to delivery delays and higher transport costs.

ment, it said. Private consumption continues to be weighed down by high energy prices. While there is no sign that the war is triggering second-round inflationary effects through wages, the inflation

rate could temporarily rise further in the coming months, the report said. However, robust recent manufacturing orders, alongside increased investment pledged by the government in defense and infrastructure,

will continue to support the economy ahead. “The German economy is now clearly on a recovery path that the war in the Middle East has also failed to thwart,” the Bundesbank added.

‘Graduate Tax’ Hangs Over British Workers

By Julia Amann

LONDON—When it comes to student debt, Americans think they have it bad. By some metrics, things also are pretty bad in England, where higher education used to be considered a good deal. Graduates in England have among the highest levels of student debt in the developed world, with an average balance of more than \$70,000 by the time they start repaying, according to data from the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development. Student debt has emerged as a political talking point in England as the cost of going to college has risen—a relatively new issue for a country that in earlier decades offered low or no tuition fees, and even issued grants to its lowest-income students. Both tuition and living costs have increased since then, and most students now take out loans. Critics say the modern system unfairly punishes middle and higher earners and stifles economic growth. While lower-earning gradu-

Student Debt Is Soaring

Rising living costs, higher interest rates and more students attending university have pushed Britain’s total loan balance to the equivalent of roughly \$400 billion, up from about \$73 billion in the 2013-14 fiscal year. Barely half of borrowers made even a single payment in 2025, mostly because their earnings fell below the threshold, exempting them from repaying at all.

Advocates of the system say it protects graduates from the levels of debt seen among some U.S. students. “The system is trying to move the burden onto the people who benefit from higher education, while protecting low earners from making unaffordable payments or risk of loan default,” said Jack Britton of the Institute for Fiscal Studies.

ates don’t have to make any repayments, those who land jobs with salaries above a threshold, which starts at about \$34,000, have to pay back 9% of everything they earn above that level—an arrangement critics have dubbed the “graduate tax.” Although Britain’s capped tuition fees of roughly \$13,000 a year sound modest to Americans, added living costs and compounding interest push

total balances far higher. Six years after graduating from a four-year program with a chemistry degree, Alexander Chamberlain-Clay, a 28-year-old software engineer, owes about \$110,000. That is up from an original balance of \$74,000. His required monthly payment doesn’t cover the \$500 added in monthly interest, causing his balance to balloon over time. He said the debt influenced his decision to turn down a

higher-paying job offer that would have triggered even steeper loan deductions. When he told friends from outside England about his balance, they were stunned. “They think that Britain is European, and that ridiculous student debt numbers are something Americans have,” he said. Only about half of borrowers end up paying off their loans in full. Depending on when a student enrolled, the outstanding balance is forgiven after 25 to 40 years, leaving taxpayers to absorb the rest. A U.K. parliamentary inquiry, which was launched amid growing public concern over the issue, concluded last month that the government had mis-sold loans to students for more than a decade, understating how much they eventually would cost. More than half of borrowers surveyed said they hadn’t understood the terms and conditions of their loan before taking it out. One called the repayments “a tax on ambition.” While more than half of U.S. graduates hold student debt, in England, more than 95% of



Oxford students tossed their hats after graduating in July.

students take out loans. Unlike in the U.S. system, tuition fees are broadly the same at most English universities, so most students have no lower-cost option to avoid debt. Abbie Holmes graduated from the University of Bristol last year with more than \$74,000 in debt she never expects to pay off. But she said knowing more about the system wouldn’t have changed her decision. “It is basically a tax for the rest of my life. But I had to do it, because I was always going to go to university.” Critics say the burden on young professionals is particularly damaging because they

typically are the most prolific spenders. In London, roughly one in six of the city’s working-age population is estimated to be repaying a student loan. That drains about \$1 billion a year from the capital’s economy, according to an analysis by Oxford Economics. Repayments tend to hit graduates when they start making more money—and when they most need disposable income, said Gavan Conlon, a partner at London Economics. “You know, buying a house, or family formation—student loans are eating up a significant proportion of their post-tax income.”

FROM PAGE ONE

The Claw Machine Is Arcade King

Continued from Page One

That’s hooked Falcon and her boyfriend, Hiraël de Jesus. The pair like the plushies they win but return to the machines because of the fun they have playing together.

“If I, let’s say, I win one and I win another one and I feel like I’m on a winning streak, I’ll wage at least maybe \$70, at most like \$100 or more,” Falcon said.

Couple the gamification of everything from languages to health with Americans’ fasci-

nation with collectibles, and it was only a matter of time before claw-machine arcades took off in the U.S., retail experts say. Plus, arcade tokens tend to be cheaper than tickets for a concert or sports match.

“I don’t even care about the toys,” said Myooran Yokerathinam, better known as Clawmaster_30 to his hundreds of thousands of followers on social media, where he posts highlight reels of his winnings—and the tricks he uses to maximize them. “I do it for the love of the game.”

On a recent Tuesday at the Gatcha arcade in Manhattan’s Koreatown, Yokerathinam pointed out a machine stocked with Pikachu plushies. Looking through aviator shades, he explained that the Pokémon mascot is one of his preferred targets, not just because he

likes the character but because Pikachu’s long ears make the claw much more likely to hang onto the toy.

In two attempts, Yokerathinam snagged his Pikachu.

As he wove through the rows of machines, Yokerathinam pointed out more hacks: If you press the release button as the claw approaches a prize, you might manually force the claw to clamp around a toy, he said. Also, it’s best to go for something that’s close to the exit chute, in case the claw drops it prematurely.

After nabbing a plush hot dog and a red-and-white rabbit, Yokerathinam flashed his prizes into his phone’s camera, illuminated by the portable light he’d attached to a neighborhood machine. “There you go,” he said as he retrieved a prize from the chute.

Fantasy Claw’s Howard estimates there are roughly 300 to 400 “clawcades” across the U.S. The new storefronts have especially been a boon for malls, which flailed after the rise of online shopping.

“Someone can buy that collectible online, but they can’t recreate that excitement of playing the game or the anticipation of the huddle cheering when someone finally does win,” said Alison Krueger, a leasing manager at Mall of America, which operates a claw-machine arcade with more than 100 machines, plus bubble tea and Korean shaved ice.

The other draw for players: claw machines leverage some of the exact same cognitive hooks as slot machines, said Elliot Ludvig, a University of Warwick psychology professor

who studies rewards-based decision-making.

When a claw lifts a plushie and drops it inches from the chute, the brain doesn’t register a failure, Ludvig said. Instead, the psychological tease convinces the player that a win is imminent, spurring them to pay for another try.

Claw machines can be set to yield a prize after a certain number of attempts, and today’s operators are choosing more reasonable settings. Multiple clawcade operators said customers spend, on average, about \$30 a visit.

Alice Greene spent part of a recent Tuesday evening at a clawcade in Manhattan with two friends, trying to pick up “blind boxes” that contain miniature mystery figurines. Five minutes in, she hadn’t successfully grabbed one.

“It’s fun to see if you can do it or not and, like, you probably can’t. It’s kind of a scam,” said Greene. “It’s gambling, but it’s disguised by cuteness.”

On my first trip to a small storefront in Chinatown, I spent about \$20 to play nine times. Each attempt was a bust. Meanwhile, the little girl next to me picked up a plush pigeon keychain with ease.

But that was before I met Yokerathinam. Picking up some of his tricks, my luck turned during other visits.

After spending \$40 more, I eventually walked away with two cute plushies—a fuzzy chicken leg with a penguin face and a purple tea cup with a smiley face embroidered on its side—and my dignity intact.

Was it worth \$60? I’m not so sure...

Hawaii Warms to Startups

Continued from Page One

decades ago. Hawaii, once a premier destination for American and international visitors, has lost traffic to newly popular vacation spots. The number of visitors hasn’t rebounded to prepandemic levels, and no industry has replaced tourism, much less with higher-paying work.

Overall arrivals to the state in June were down 9% compared with the same month in 2019, diminished by a roughly 50% drop in international tourism during that period. Food and housing prices have climbed while incomes, adjusted for the cost of living, are among the lowest in the U.S. Only California has a higher median home price.

Economists say Hawaii needs to shift away from the service-based industry that propelled its explosive growth in the late 20th century. “If we don’t fix the problem, we’re going to face many more years of anemic growth and people voting with their feet,” said Carl Bonham, executive director of the University of Hawaii’s economic-research division.

Hawaii has reinvented its economy before. In the 19th and early 20th centuries, the islands depended first on sugar plantations and then the pineapple industry. Waikiki was mostly duck ponds and swampland. Local excitement was limited to “the activity of the insect tribes and the occasional fall of a coconut,” one early visitor wrote.

In 1936, Pan American Airways flew passengers from San Francisco to Honolulu for \$356, the equivalent of more than \$8,000 in today’s dollars.

After Hawaii became a state in 1959, Pan American began flying newer, larger aircraft that eventually cut airfares in half, putting Hawaii in reach of America’s middle class. In a decade, the number of visitors grew sevenfold. During the 1980s, the Japanese economy swelled, drawing legions of new visitors.

But by 2000, the volume of inflation-adjusted tourism dollars in Hawaii had peaked. By 2024, Hawaii’s economy remained highly dependent on a weakened tourism industry, according to a state report issued last fall.

The state needs only to cultivate a few successful enterprises to jump-start the economy, said Zack Hernandez, who left for college on the mainland and returned to run a talent-development startup on Oahu.

“If you bring 30 or 50 jobs with a \$100 billion company, you create 30 or 50 millionaires” who can then invest in more young startups, he said. One possibility is expanding the defense-tech sector, he said, taking advantage of Hawaii’s strategic position between the U.S. and Asia.

Glenn Wakai, a state senator, said new industries would help keep more residents on the islands where they grew up. “The people who are leaving Hawaii are the very people we need to stay to reinvent the economy,” he said. “As those people exit Hawaii, who’s going to be left?”

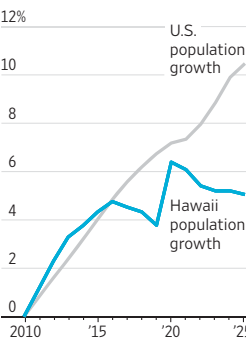
Greener pastures

Nearly every choice 18-year-old Ariana Thomas made while growing up on Oahu was geared to escape. She



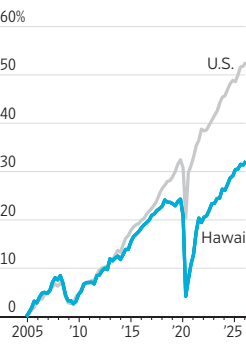
Visitors during a recent day at Waikiki Beach on Hawaii’s island of Oahu.

Population, cumulative growth since 2010



Sources: Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis

Real GDP, cumulative growth since 2005



California that has expressed interest in establishing a launch site on the island. That would be a significant step to building an aerospace industry, according to Nunes. “We miss this opportunity, and in two years it’s going to be too late,” he said.

If Hawaii’s dreams could be pinned on a single person, it might be Trung Lam. The 45-year-old grew up in Hawaii to Vietnamese immigrant parents who ran a Honolulu sandwich shop. Lam helped manage the business when he returned to the island after earning a mechanical engineering degree at the University of California, Davis.

While working at the family business, Lam joined a startup that built an app to help people at shopping malls find stores. During the pandemic, he stepped away from the family business to help his children with remote learning. Soon after, he helped start an organization to support local tech workers.

Lam applied to head the Hawaii Technology Development Corporation, a state agency struggling to diversify the local economy. He met

with venture capitalists, executives and lawmakers before aiming his focus on ocean- and space-based industries, convinced that Hawaii could attract founders and investors with its locale—close to the equator for easier space launches and surrounded by the Pacific Ocean.

The corporation is signing a lease worth more than \$1 million for manufacturing space at the Kapaa Industrial Park, a maze of steel buildings on the outskirts of Kailua. The state intends to sublet space to startups that might not have the wherewithal to commit to long-term leases.

The project is a test of whether state intervention can stimulate new manufacturing. In meetings of the corporation’s board, agency documents show, board members questioned the state’s acting as a landlord and the risk of losing public funds.

One past effort failed. In 2001, the state began offering 100% tax credits to investors in technology businesses. An audit after the program ended a decade later found the state had afforded nearly \$1 billion in tax credits with little to

show for it.

Keizo Gates, 41, knows firsthand the challenge of turning ideas into money. He runs an industrial canoe business that he started with high school friends who also grew up in Hawaii. Gates attended Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute in Troy, N.Y., before starting Kamanu Composites, which employs aerospace-grade machinery. The business is in debt, and he isn’t sure it will survive the year.

“We wanted to prove that you can do something different,” Gates said, pacing through his facility in the Kapaa Industrial Park. “And I feel like we failed.”

Seaworthy

Economists such as Steven Bond-Smith are leading the call to diversify Hawaii’s economy with businesses that take advantage of Hawaii’s geographic strengths. Bond-Smith has studied how the state can create higher-paying jobs that retain local talent and attract skilled workers from the mainland. “If your wage doesn’t keep up with the rest of the United States,” he said, “then the opportunity cost of staying in Hawaii becomes higher and higher.”

One option is Hawaii’s small but promising ocean-tech industry, which includes firms that repair cargo ships, make sensors to detect floods, breed commercial shellfish or make livestock supplements from seaweed.

Patrick Sullivan, chief executive of Oceanit, an industrial research and engineering company, has overseen plenty of marine-technology projects. His business, based in Honolulu, is one of the state’s largest tech companies. On a recent Friday, scientists cultivated living tissue, engi-

neers tested new flavors for an 80-gram protein bar for the U.S. military and interns modeled coastal erosion on Maui.

Sullivan’s company has trained 800 interns over the years and most leave for the mainland, he said—a sign Hawaii needs to change. But he is skeptical the state can establish an ocean-tech industry on its own. “People think we’re in the middle of the sea, so let’s focus on seawater,” he said. But the state shouldn’t try to predict which industries or businesses will succeed, he said.

Ashten Akemoto, 23, studied computer engineering and would have been one of the college students leaving Hawaii but for a meeting with a tech entrepreneur. He had tickets for a flight to Japan and a new job waiting there when he was introduced by Lam to Josh Leong, a 40-year-old former Google employee and an alumnus of the Silicon Valley startup incubator Y Combinator.

They met at a café in Waikiki where Leong, still wet from surfing, persuaded Akemoto to stay in Hawaii. Together, they launched Normal and recruited recent college graduates and experienced engineers to build energy-efficient heating, ventilation and air-conditioning machinery. The business has grown to roughly 20 employees.

To set up manufacturing space on a lot zoned for retail, Leong and his wife opened Ando Café on the premises. Akemoto recruited some of his NASA friends. “It was surprisingly easy to convince a bunch of 20-year-old tech guys to live on my couch and build robots with me in Hawaii,” he said.

Some state leaders believe entrepreneurs like Leong and Akemoto are the missing pieces of the economy’s diversification puzzle: local startup founders who team up with so-called Silicon Valley refugees lured by the weather and glamour of living in Hawaii, and who know how to tap venture capital.

On a recent day, Leong stepped into a Volkswagen microbus that he had retrofitted with Tesla batteries, a side project that expanded his interests from software to hardware engineering. “This is the fastest VW bus on the island,” he said.

Leong pulled out of Normal’s Kailua headquarters, where a flock of college-age kids were inside manufacturing and testing circuit boards. “It feels like we’re moving on a different timeline than the rest of Hawaii,” he said behind the wheel.

He turned onto Kapaa Quarry Road, en route to the Kapaa Industrial Park, where Normal has a second facility. He followed a winding road under low-hanging trees until the industrial neighborhood of Kailua came into view. To one side were the warehouses of the industrial park where Lam plans to foster a manufacturing oasis.

More traditional island businesses there—chocolate making, boat repair, welding and plumbing—operate alongside Leong’s HVAC operations, the struggling canoe builder and incoming ocean-tech startups. If all goes according to plan, this gritty pocket of Kailua will soon be roaring with new machinery.

“Hawaii needs one unicorn. We need one crazy success,” said Akemoto, who left Normal last week to launch his own robotics startup. “You can change a place, you can change perception, you can change everything with one crazy success.”



Left, Josh Leong at Normal headquarters in Kailua, Hawaii; Ashten Akemoto.



FROM LEFT: RICKY THOMAS SERIKAWA FOR WSJ; KAVYA CHANG

ARTS IN REVIEW



TELEVISION REVIEW | JOHN ANDERSON

Commemorating 9/11

Three specials mark the 25th anniversary of the 2001 terrorist attacks

The 25th anniversary of the events of Sept. 11, 2001, will be commemorated with solemn oratory, music, the reading of names and a moment of silence. Also, television specials.

On ABC, for instance, “9/11: United We Stand—25 Years Later” will feature Robin Roberts, Jon Stewart, Jimmy Fallon, Michael Strahan, George Stephanopoulos, Jon Bon Jovi, Pete Davidson, Joe Torre, Derek Jeter, Mark Messier, Billy Crystal and Matthew Broderick.

On National Geographic, the three-part “9/11 Reunited” will feature John Paczkowski, Jan Demczur, George Phoenix, Stefan Horlacher, Debbie St. John, John McLoughlin, Al Kim and Kevin Shea.

Who? People whose lives were saved on 9/11, and the people who saved them. The sentiments of celebrities regarding the attacks of 9/11 will be of interest to many. But first-person accounts—from inside and outside the towers on the day in question—surely make for more urgent viewing.

This is particularly true of “Reunited,” which brings together people who shared the most devastating moment of their lives and then were lost to each other, seemingly forever. The rescuers rode off in the literal dust and, as one might imagine, the effect of the reunions is emotional quicksand. Some of the survivors in this reviews weren’t aware of who their rescuers were; others simply hadn’t seen them in 25 years. But even if the meetings are orchestrated, and predictably awkward, the re-encounters possess a genuine sense of gratitude and camaraderie. And love. And guilt.

There aren’t many survivors interviewed for “9/11 Reunited”—or the moment-by-moment docu-thriller “102 Minutes Inside the

Towers”—who don’t express guilt for having survived. Mr. Horlacher, a bond trader, was below the South Tower watching a metal shard fall from the second plane just before it struck Ms. St. John and left her half eviscerated, lying in the street. “It should have been me,” he says, for no reason other than that he escaped death by inches. For her part, Ms. St. John—the first person hospitalized on 9/11, we are told, and the last discharged after 18 months and 50 operations—couldn’t be more grateful to her savior, the man who protected her devastated body from the “stampede” of the panicked. Their shared affection is strong enough to weather the intrusion of a camera.

There is a kind of “Schindler’s List” echo to “9/11 Reunited”—the mining of some good news out of a world-shaking calamity; the finding of something close to joy in the selfless acts of people who could easily have turned aside. They were almost always risking their lives—Scott Fox and John Busching, for instance, a retired fireman and a policeman whom Mr. McLoughlin, a Port Authority officer, credits with saving him after he was buried under 30 feet of rubble when the South Tower collapsed. Similarly, in the show’s one non-New York sequence, Navy officer Craig Powell is formally introduced to Marilyn Wills, whom he caught in his arms when she made a four-story leap from a window at the Pentagon.

There is overlap between “9/11 Reunited” and “102 Minutes,” with its ominous on-screen timeline. There had to be: The attack on the World Trade Center is one of the most-photographed disasters in history, thanks in part to New York being the media capital. But some redundancy is unavoidable. The one human featured in both shows is Mr. Demczur, who was a WTC window washer and tells the same

Clockwise from top left: memorial wall at the 9/11 Memorial and Museum; Debbie St. John and Stefan Horlacher; Jan Demczur, George Phoenix and John Paczkowski; Craig Powell and Marilyn Wills; and the smoking New York skyline after the attacks on Sept. 11, 2001.

story to both productions, with minor variations: how he entered the lobby of the North Tower early on Sept. 11, stopped the closing elevator doors to get on board (“I have to get to work, too,” he remembers saying to his fellow passengers) and how, after the plummeting car came to rest at the 50th floor, he used his squeegee handle to hack through several layers of sheet-rock. Which opened into a bathroom. Which led to a stairwell.

Mr. Demczur demonstrates his hacking technique in “Reunited.” In “102 Minutes,” it’s recreated, as is much of the show’s ornamentation. Rob Chess and Ray Bruening, who worked just a few floors below where the first plane hit the North Tower, remember watching, with growing horror, the approach of American Airlines Flight 11. It was too low, too unwavering in its path to be anything but a missile, and the two men relive the moments with anxiety. Viewers, too, will be made anxious by the simulated plane as well as the faux fire, smoke and collapsing architecture, though the actions being recalled by specific survivors remain the province of their memories. We have to imagine, for instance, Ron DiFrancesco riding a



American could? Even those too young to have any real-time memory of the terrorist attacks have received the trauma by osmosis. But observing 25th anniversaries is something we do. And perhaps, in this case, enough time has passed that the nation can look back at that horrific day in September 2001—when so many innocent people suffered, died and/or proved themselves courageous—with objectivity, clarity and sobriety. But don’t bet on it. Bet on tears.

9/11 Reunited
Friday, 8 p.m., National Geographic; next day, Disney+, Hulu

9/11: United We Stand—25 Years Later
Sept. 1, 9 p.m., ABC

102 Minutes Inside the Towers
Sept. 11, 8 p.m., History Channel

Mr. Anderson is the Journal’s TV critic.

FILM REVIEW | KYLE SMITH

Kafka, Captured In a Kaleidoscope

‘HE BELIEVED THAT he had failed as a son, a man, a writer,’ someone observes of the dark, brooding, recessive and incandescently weird Franz Kafka in “Franz.” “He decided to succeed as a victim.”

The moment is appropriately forlorn, off-key and mordant in the hands of the veteran Polish director Agnieszka Holland, who in this film seeks to revise the form of the biopic into something like a Kafkaesque excursion into the sinister and surreal. It’s not the first screen effort to intermingle fantasy and episodes from the writer’s life (see, for instance, Steven Soderbergh’s 1991 feature “Kafka”) in the service of a fractured hallucination, but then again a straightforward take would seem to miss the point.

Kafka was not just a writer, he was an adjective. And a sensibility. Today he’s even a brand. The movie depicts a restaurant called Kafka Burger in Prague. Does one even need to read him to understand him?

Jumping around in time, “Franz” frequently recasts straightforwardly staged scenes from his life into

twisted, surreal parables while occasionally checking in on contemporary Prague and its Kafka tributes. The film stars an appropriately stone-faced Idan Weiss as the author (1883-1924), who was born into a German-speaking family in the Kingdom of Bohemia, then ruled by Austria-Hungary.

Franz, a bird raised by a bear, is a constant disappointment to his manically hearty father, Hermann (Peter

Kurth), a small-business man with a large tummy who fully expects his only surviving son (two others died as small children, leaving Franz and three sisters) to follow him into the prosperous managerial class. Successfully corralled, Franz earns the degree of doctor

of law, and achieves success in the insurance industry. But that merely gives his deep-rooted oddness a patina of the normal. The mismatch—the strictures of the business world and a galloping imagination—launched Kafka and his innumerable artistic progeny, which continue all the way to today’s deadpan sitcoms detailing strange doings at the office.

Ms. Holland is best known in this country for her Oscar-nominated



World War II drama “Europa, Europa” (released here in 1991), and more recently made the riveting “Mr. Jones” (released here in 2020), about the coverup of Stalin’s 1930s Ukrainian famine. Here she playfully slings us in and out of reality while saluting various Kafka stories published in his lifetime, such as “The Judgment,” “In the Penal Colony,” and “Metamorphosis” (suggested by a cockroach crawling across a table at meal time).

Possibly my favorite vignette in Ms. Holland’s rangy, sometimes frustrating but mostly appealing film is a scene in which a guide at one of Prague’s leading tourist attractions today, the Kafka Museum, gestures toward a massive wall of books about the writer (with their spines turned inward, naturally, for maximum bafflement) next to a suitcase that contains a copy of everything he ever published. The ratio of words written about Kafka to words written by him, we are told, is something like 10 million to one. There is a

Idan Weiss in ‘Franz,’ an unconventional biopic directed by Agnieszka Holland.

massive kinetic metal bust of the man on a Prague street that is larger than the head of the Statue of Liberty. Its pieces stir and whirl, suggesting a madcap puzzle machine.

Where did Kafka’s fear-tinted alienation come from? Was it a reaction to the aggressive machismo of his father, seen tossing him into a river when he could barely swim? His tuberculosis, which before it killed him at age 40 led to rest “cures” at sanatoriums notable chiefly for their ineffectiveness? (A fellow patient he meets is sticking a dental mirror deep into his mouth in an attempt to reduce tumors by reflecting light on them.) His turbulent romantic liaisons? (His relationships with women tended to overlap.) How about, as his mother suggests, his lack of male companionship because his brothers died so young?

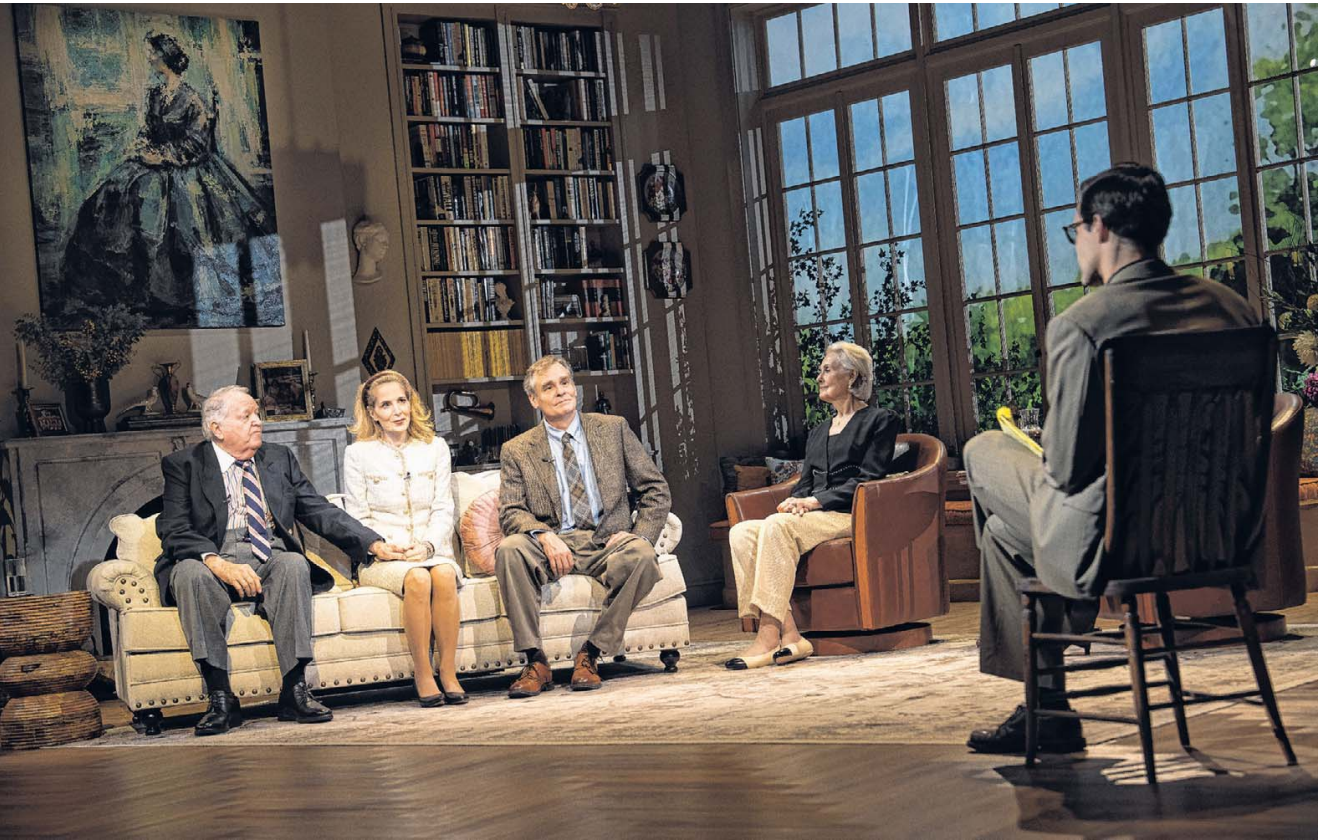
All such explanations risk being superficial (and a scene of Franz making a roomful of people laugh loudly while he reads from one of his books seems off-base, as though he were a potential standup comic). But Ms. Holland doesn’t push them. Better are her more oblique turns—realistic scenes with strange underpinnings. Did groups of men really treat tuberculosis by exercising nude? Did Kafka really order his friend Max Brod (Sebastian Schwarz) to burn all of his unpublished work upon his death? Did World War I actually happen? (Yes, yes and yes; Hermann Kafka saved his son from the battlefield, arguing that he could best serve the Empire with office work.)

Featuring more and more scenes of contemporary Prague as it goes along, the film is content to leave all mysteries unsolved, and to serve as an introduction to the man and the shadowy labyrinths of his mind. “To dream and to live,” Franz is told, “There’s a difference.” His work suggests it’s not as simple as that.

FROM TOP: NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC/VIRGINIA SHERWOOD (4); AP/CHAD RACHMAN

COHEN MEDIA GROUP

ARTS IN REVIEW



A scene from the play, which follows a female surgeon-general nominee.

cious destructiveness of the media; and undersudsed soap opera. When most of the characters are shuffled offstage, for instance, Quincy unsurprisingly makes a move on Walter—most unfeminist behavior!—that is, also unsurprisingly, witnessed by Lyssa.

The turning point arrives when Walter mentions that Lyssa has always been cavalier about responding to jury summonses. Lightbulbs will go off in the minds of those old enough to remember the “nannygate” drama of the Clinton administration—briefly alluded to—when two of the president’s female nominees were derailed for (by today’s standards) picayune offenses. Wasserstein piles on another then-topical controversy when Lyssa speaks dismissively of her mother as a maker of icebox cakes (see: Hillary Clinton, cookies), a gaffe that garners outrage from icebox-cake lovers everywhere.

But the play’s aims and ideas are so muddled that little of what follows these developments makes any sense. Ms. Lichty’s awkward performance leaves a void at the play’s center, true, but even the actors of note, fine as they are, cannot bring unwritten depths to their shallow characters.

The play’s nadir comes at the close of the first act, when Judith suddenly returns, looking as if she has just crawled out of the Poto-mac, as indeed she has. Honoring the Jewish “festival of regrets” during Rosh Hashana, Judith became a mite too regretful—she’s desperate to have a child, among other woes—and tried to drown herself. The bizarre monologue in which she explains how she dragged herself back from the brink under the inspiration of a donut shop’s slogan, “Keep your eye upon the doughnut, and not upon the hole,” is too ludicrous to be either funny or moving. Which sums up the play itself. By the time it ended I was ready to join a festival of regrets myself.

THEATER REVIEW | CHARLES ISHERWOOD

An Off-Broadway Fiasco

Wendy Wasserstein’s dated, creaky ‘An American Daughter’ returns with a stiff lead performance

New York f Wendy Wasserstein wrote a worse play than “An American Daughter,” I hope I never have the misfortune of seeing it. Not that the misbegotten current off-Broadway staging of Wasserstein’s comedy-drama does the writing any favors. In the central role of Lyssa Dent Hughes, a doctor and prominent Washington health administrator who has just been nominated by the president to become surgeon general, Jean Lichty gives one of the most inept performances I have ever seen in an ostensibly professional production. Perhaps here is the place to note that Ms. Lichty is also the executive director of the company that produced the show.

Going down with the ship, sadly, are a handful of first-rate stage actors, most notably Robert Sean Leonard, a Tony winner for “The Invention of Love,” who plays Lyssa’s rumpled professor husband, Walter, and looks more sheepish and miserable than the character’s low-grade unhappiness might account for—and who can blame him? Also having their considerable talents and experience wasted are the veterans Dakin Matthews, as Lyssa’s good ol’ boy father, a Republican senator from Indiana (do they make good ol’ boys there?); Mary Beth Peil as his fourth wife, nicknamed

Chubby because she’s rail-thin (the play is notable for its cutely named characters); and Montego Glover (Tony-nominated for “Memphis”) as Lyssa’s longtime friend Judith, an oncologist who is black and Jewish. “You’re a walking Crown Heights,” quips a character, unfunnily.

The play takes place in 1997, the year it was first produced in New York, and is set in the plush Georgetown home of Lyssa and her family. The airy set, by Mikiko Suzuki MacAdams, evokes the mouth-watering, gauzy splendor of the houses in Nancy Meyers movies. Unhappily what takes place onstage has little more dramatic heft and is almost as untethered to plausibility as the plot of a Meyers rom-com.

It’s shortly after the announcement of Lyssa’s nomination, and she is preparing for a “televised brunch” interview on the following day with Timber Tucker, played by the chisel-jawed and chisel-chested Chris Gaffari, looking like a model who’s sprung to life from the pages of GQ. As Lyssa is watching coverage of her nomination announcement, in wanders Quincy Quince (Carmen Zilles), a former student of Walter’s who is now a pseudo-celebrity as the author of a bestseller about “the rebirth of feminism.” Why she’s looking for Walter is unclear, but as she and Lyssa chat, another wanderer enters, Judith, who exchanges barbed dialogue with Quincy—and then invites her to join the brunch. Inexplicably,

Also inexplicably invited, by Walter, to this fateful brunch is Morrow McCarthy (Ryan Spahn), a gay man who wrote for the Washington Post but has recently sold a screenplay for seven figures (a famous hazard of the journalism business). Lyssa bristles at his inclusion because he’s recently come out as anti-abortion—not a good look for a friend of the liberal doctor, although it allows for much dated gabble about the issue.

As it lumbers forward in scenes that are labored and overwritten—there’s little the director Sarna Lapine can do to juice its momentum—“An American Daughter” unfolds as an unwieldy blend of ripped-from-yellow-headlines political commentary; pointed preaching about the higher standards faced by women in public positions (“Maybe one day every woman who comes into national focus won’t be forced to stand for the women of America”); hand-wringing about the vora-

The WSJ Daily Crossword | Edited by Mike Shenk

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- 34 1974 role for Marty
- 35 Heap
- 36 Roddick with a racket
- 38 Infamous emperor
- 39 Foolhardy
- 40 Road trip pastime
- 44 They're circled for protection
- 45 ___ before (not later than)
- 46 Crude group
- 47 "Stand and Deliver" Oscar nominee
- 48 Mutinee-beset movie minesweeper
- 49 Hudson of "Boston Blue"
- 50 Hyderabad's ___ Gandhi

YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS NOW | By Matt Gaffney

- The answer to this week's contest crossword is something people undertake for knowledge.
- Across**
- 1 Backyard fun
- 6 Lower, like lighting
- 10 Russian river
- 14 "Until we meet again!"
- 15 That single time
- 16 Zip
- 17 Seemed to go on forever
- 20 Yeoman's "you betcha!"
- 21 It may be dedicated
- 22 On ___ (carousing)
- 23 Failure to be
- 27 Superior squads
- 30 Broadway signals
- 31 Elk stalkers
- 32 Fearsome fate
- 34 Bitter brew
- 37 Appearing mysteriously, maybe
- 41 Scoreboard abbr.
- 42 One, in Austria
- 43 Comparable to the hills?
- 44 Threadbare
- 46 Fish-catching flier
- 47 Field with many boats
- 52 Key of Florida
- 53 Candle count
- 54 Bit of advice
- 57 Quibbles
- 62 "What's going ___ there?"
- 63 Longest street in town, maybe
- 64 Starr and Simpson, say
- 65 Catches a glimpse of
- 66 Poli sci study
- 67 Haughty type
- Down**
- 1 "Who Let the Dogs Out" group ___ Men
- 2 One-___ vitamins
- 3 Theme park fun
- 4 Golfer Crenshaw
- 5 Status follower
- 6 Where, to Juanita
- 7 Market measure
- 8 Former telecom giant
- 9 Rep.'s counterpart
- 10 Joins together
- 11 Tease relentlessly
- 12 Committee type
- 13 Barista's creation
- 18 Long stretches
- 19 Fully fill
- 23 Curry accompanier
- 24 City on the Trans-Siberian Railway
- 25 Pics that get clicks
- 26 Battle of the bulgy?
- 27 Each
- 28 Bit of hair
- 29 Outback runners
- 32 Up to, so to speak
- 33 Dominate during play
- 51 Deal pro
- 54 Mower brand
- 55 Really enthused about
- 56 Subtle hiss
- 58 "r u kidding me?"
- 59 Chinese steamed bun
- 60 Station begun in Atlanta
- 61 McKellen of "X-Men"

Previous Puzzle's Solution									
SWIG	SHAH	SAPS							
ELENA	LUXE	LUAU							
VOLKSWAGEN	ODIN								
EEL	CAVED	DRAWING							
FIT	LAX	YSL							
ARC	SYNTH								
AGUA	IMHOME	TRA							
ULTRA	VIOLLE	TRAYS							
LOO	LYNDON	ELMO							
TORSO	OAR	GALEN							
PEA	TOP								
ROT	ISSERIES	JOB							
AMOK	OPERA	HOUSE							
KALE	NINO	ERNST							
ENDS	ECON	NOGO							

Jean Lichty and Robert Sean Leonard, right; Ms. Lichty and Montego Glover, below.



► Email your answer—in the subject line—to crosswordcontest@wsj.com by 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time Sunday, August 23. A solver selected at random will win a WSJ mug. Last week’s winner: Kelley Ulrich, Wake Forest, NC. Complete contest rules at [WSJ.com/Puzzles](https://www.wsj.com/puzzles). (No purchase necessary. Void where prohibited. U.S. residents 18 and over only.)

OPINION

Alaska’s Ranked-Choice Travesty



POTOMAC WATCH
By *Kimberley A. Strassel*

Alaska’s first two ranked-choice elections were embarrassments, marked by complexity, confusion and delay. But, oh, for the good old days of mere humiliation. This year operatives finally cracked the many devious ways the system can be outright gamed. Alaska is now the poster child for dirty-pool politics.

Alaskans won’t know until the end of August which “final four” candidates for each office will be on their ranked-choice November ballot after this week’s jungle primary. Residents will need that time to recover from the trauma of a monthslong campaign in which they were not valued as “we the people,” but duped and confused, treated as pawns in a seedy game.

Alaska conducts elections in two stages under completely different rules. First, all candidates, regardless of party, face off in a primary, in which each voter casts a single vote. The top four finishers advance to the general election, in which voters can rank all four and their votes shift in multiple rounds of counting in which the bottom finisher is eliminated and his votes reassigned.

As with Alaska’s past races under this system, which began in 2022, there was the usual insane complexity: 17 candidates for governor, 16 for the U.S. Senate, 15 for the state’s lone House seat. This is in part a function of Alaska’s silly filing require-

ments, the loosest in the country. Anyone can run for office for a fee of \$100—no need to gather petition signatures. That encourages frivolous candidacies in Alaska’s system, allowing attention seekers the guarantee of having their name listed next to prominent people—and free media.

Alaska’s House contest featured, again, Eric Hafner, who is serving a federal prison term in New York after pleading guilty in connection with a string of threats against government officials. He made the final ballot in 2024, and may do so this year, too. The Senate race featured his mother, Carol Hafner, and Green candidate Richard Grayson—neither of whom lives in the state. Of more than 30 candidates running for the Senate and House, few outside the incumbents or the main Democratic challenger even tried to raise money. Mr. Grayson recently explained that he was running “for fun,” that he actually supports Democrat Mary Peltola, and that if he makes the final four, he’ll quit. This is the contempt RCV encourages candidates to show Alaska voters.

At least the felon and the out-of-staters weren’t deceiving voters. The Senate race featured the last-minute entry of a retired elementary school teacher with a history of supporting Democrats, including Mrs. Peltola. He happens to be named Daniel Sullivan—the same name as the Republican incumbent—and filed, just before the deadline, to run as a Republican. The decoy insists he isn’t trying to confuse voters, and isn’t

working with Mrs. Peltola or her supporters. Yet his filing documents were handled by an Anchorage Democratic consultant, and his campaign logo is a near replica of Sen. Sullivan’s.

Doppelgangers have run in other elections but, again, Alaska’s system dramatically increases the spoiler potential. In a jungle primary team-

The system isn’t merely confusing. It is a game in which voters are the losers.

ing with candidates, voters struggle to focus on individuals or disputes. Every name is dropped on one big ballot. The Sullivans were adjacent this year, with the decoy candidate listed first. How many Alaskans ticked the first box, unaware they were voting for someone other than whom they intended?

With 80% of the vote counted, Mrs. Peltola has 64,000 votes and Sen. Sullivan has 57,000. No. 3? Decoy Dan, with 3,200 votes, who didn’t campaign and has only 12 donors (not including himself). Alaskans will be even more confused when they have to “rank” the two Dans in November.

While fringe candidates didn’t bother raising money, “pop-up” partisan groups poured more than \$3 million into Alaska’s tiny media market to game the primary. A group called Right for Alaska spent \$2.2 million in ads supporting little-known conservatives to skim voters from Sen.

Sullivan. Another mystery organization, Fair Deal Alaska, ran more than \$750,000 to help the Carol Hafner and Grayson campaigns draw votes from Mrs. Peltola. The American Democracy Project blew \$300,000, in part to boost David Leslie, a Democrat, also to undermine Mrs. Peltola. Mr. Leslie said he was “surprised” when people starting praising his video ads, since his campaign never ran any. Alaska mailboxes were flooded with flyers encouraging them to vote for spoiler candidates. While some manipulation happened in prior elections, this year there was little but manipulation. Gaming Alaska’s system is now a feature—not a bug.

Alaskans won’t even decide who is on the final ballot. Politicians are now wise to Alaska’s RCV game, including a provision that automatically moves candidates up if any of the official “four” drop out. Candidates are in active back-room discussions about who will withdraw, under what circumstances, to juke the ballot. Democrats want one Democrat in the final four, against three Republicans (to split that vote). Republicans want the opposite. Voters may ask why they bother going to the polls when politicians set the final field.

There will be at least one clear choice on November’s ballot. Alaskans will vote on a ballot initiative that would ditch ranked-choice voting. A similar attempt failed by 700 votes in 2024, after outside groups invested heavily to retain the failing system. After this election season, Alaskans would be crazy to vote no.

Write to *kim@wsj.com*.

BOOKSHELF | By Barbara Spindel

The Rescuer Needed Rescue

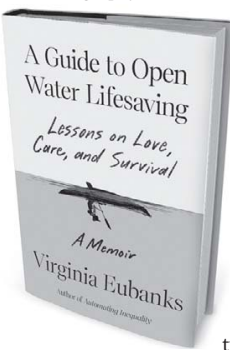
A Guide to Open Water Lifesaving

By Virginia Eubanks
FSG, 384 pages, \$32

The training manual of the U.S. Lifesaving Association warns prospective lifeguards that “a panicked victim, desperate for buoyant support, is a very real threat to an approaching rescuer.” Virginia Eubanks, an investigative journalist and political-science professor living in Troy, N.Y., faced a similar situation in 2015—though it involved a crisis on dry land.

In this case, the panicked victim was her partner, who was violently assaulted, steps from their shared home. In the aftermath he developed post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), which was marked by nightmares, volatility, agoraphobia and other symptoms. Ms. Eubanks was compelled to assume the role of rescuer, both because she loved him and because there was nobody else to fill the position. The task, she found, carried risks of its own.

In her memoir, “A Guide to Open Water Lifesaving,” Ms. Eubanks recalls that in the years after the attack, she scoured the literature on PTSD, from clinical studies and self-help texts to autobiography and fiction. She was desperate for instruction on how best to support



her partner, whom she calls J. in the book. But she also needed help coping with her own mounting feelings of anxiety and loss.

Most of the advice, Ms. Eubanks found, was centered strictly on the PTSD sufferer. Absent was any acknowledgment of the strain placed on those trying to help. Some materials suggested that caregivers ought to selflessly put their own needs aside. It was only when she came across the aquatic-rescue training resource titled “Open

Water Lifesaving” that she felt her difficulties were recognized. She marvels that “this lifeguarding manual was, absurdly, the first book I had found that offered practical advice pertinent to my circumstance.” Its warnings about the risks a flailing drowning victim poses to a would-be rescuer—who might be pulled under while trying to offer aid—also spoke to “the dangers of supporting a distressed loved one in an environment I couldn’t control.”

The attack immediately overturned life for both Ms. Eubanks and her partner. The assailants who beat J. unconscious were strangers to him, and no arrests were ever made. He endured a six-hour surgery to repair his broken jaw and was discharged from the hospital the same day. “The nurses had given me a small set of wire cutters,” the author recalls, “and told me that if the anesthesia or the pain made him sick, I should cut the wires holding his jaws together so that he wouldn’t aspirate on his own vomit.” Alarmed, she sat up with J. all night. Her watchfulness soon shifted to J.’s behavior, as he became paranoid, irritable and withdrawn.

Eager for insights similar to those she had found in the lifeguarding manual, Ms. Eubanks searched for courses on rescue and survival, around Troy and farther afield. At a local pool she joined a group of teenagers and received her lifeguard certification. She enrolled in classes on kayak rescue and wilderness survival. A textbook from the latter warned rescuers not to “rush to the aid of a person in trouble” but first to “stop, look around, and assess the risk to yourself and your team.” Her lifeguarding class emphasized that “communication is a lifeguard’s most important skill” and that “none of us works alone.” Such practical guidance for life-or-death emergencies gave her principles for handling an unpredictable situation at home. (Her attempts to make such connections are sometimes overwrought: A course on the use of maps and compasses prompts the author to reflect that she and J. “tried to keep moving through the wilderness of PTSD in what we hoped was the direction of safety.”)

The author scoured the literature on PTSD in a quest to help her partner. She found that becoming a caregiver held its own perils.

This is the first memoir by Ms. Eubanks, whose earlier books include “Automating Inequality” (2018). She tackles an often-neglected side of caregiving with clarity and meticulousness. She is candid about how the attack and its aftermath left her household in perilous financial shape: J., an artist, musician and teacher, was largely unable to work afterward, while Ms. Eubanks cut her teaching load in half to care for him. She details the exhausting effort of disputing her partner’s medical claims with insurance companies, which required her to navigate, in her words, “a stingy and Kafkaesque system of financial and social support.” At a low point several years after the attack, she and J. looked to get him treatment at an inpatient psychiatric facility. He was turned away because of a lack of beds.

After years of managing J.’s practical needs and mercurial moods, Ms. Eubanks saw a therapist who diagnosed her with a moderate form of PTSD. The author notes that the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders recognizes that those close to PTSD sufferers can develop secondary traumatic stress. She cites the difficulty of finding consistent medical care for J, the “threat of debt” that hung over their lives and the “impenetrable mazes of paperwork” in which she wandered.

In addition to being a memoir, “A Guide to Open Water Lifesaving” is intended as a resource for caregivers. Two appendices provide advice and suggestions for further reading. The National Institute of Mental Health estimates that more than 12 million Americans suffer from PTSD. Ms. Eubanks marshals statistics to show the physical, emotional and financial toll on those who love them. She advocates for a variety of remedies—from training to financial support—as well as “opportunities for respite and social connection” to address burnout and isolation.

Ms. Eubanks calls her failure to remain mentally healthy while giving J. the help he needed “the single greatest disappointment of my life.” Her revealing, sometimes seething account makes clear that, rather than being solo affairs, the safest rescues are accomplished by teams.

Ms. Spindel reviews books frequently for the Journal.

Coming in BOOKS this weekend

Adam Smith’s ‘The Wealth of Nations’ at 250 • Slavery in ancient Rome • What to make of offensive art • Three rivers and the destiny of Europe • Marilyn Monroe’s library • The style of the tennis court • & much more

New York Isn’t the Same for Jews

HOUSES OF WORSHIP
By *Tevi Troy*

Many people know that Jews blow the shofar, or ram’s horn, on the holy days of Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur. Less well-known is the custom of blowing the shofar at the end of the daily morning prayer service for the month preceding the High Holy Days to provide a warning that the days of judgment are coming. These days New York Jews sense a different kind of warning.

When I was growing up in Queens in the 1970s, about 2,000 Jews would worship on Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur at my synagogue, the Hollis Hills Jewish Center. The back doors to the main sanctuary would be open, and the banquet hall behind it would be filled with seats, going all the way up to the stage at the end of the room. If there were police outside, they were there only to direct traffic, not to provide protection from any kind of “hate crime,” a term that didn’t exist yet.

This year, as the High Holidays approach, the Jewish community in New York is thinking about holiday services differently. Every synagogue has a security committee; police presence is a necessity—not because of traffic—and in many syna-

gogues the process of passing through security at the entrance reminds me of my time working in the White House.

In the New York of my youth, the annual Israel Day parade was a great celebration, nearly always attended by a mayor, who stood in solidarity with Israel. This year, there was no mayor in attendance, and Jessica Tisch, commissioner of the New York City Police Department, said that the parade required “the most extensive security plan that the NYPD has ever put together.”

While Jews once felt safe walking the streets of the city—or at least only as threatened as everybody else—now they feel, with good reason, as if they have targets on their backs. Most hate crimes in New York are directed at Jews, even though they’re nowhere near a majority of the population. In July, 70% of hate crimes targeted Jews in the city. Last week an antisemite disrupted a synagogue service and assaulted a congregant. Last month, a Jew was stabbed leaving prayer services on a fast day.

The pervasive threat is a constant topic of conversation in a way that crime was when I was growing up: who had been mugged, whose apartment had been robbed, whose car had been stolen. With the

anticrime policies of Mayors Rudy Giuliani and Michael Bloomberg, crime receded, but now discussions with Jewish New Yorkers are about the latest hate crime, or about new communal or personal security measures, or about who is no longer comfortable taking the subway.

The term ‘hate crime’ didn’t exist when I was growing up in Queens in the 1970s.

The pervasive nature of the threat has Jews continually thinking about it. Before going out to a kosher restaurant, do you want to become a target just to get a burger or a slice of pizza? When going to synagogue, can you focus on contemplative prayer knowing that just being there makes you vulnerable? When you visit a Jewish institution, why don’t comparable non-Jewish institutions need the same layers of security?

In my weekly teaching visits to New York from Maryland, I choose—for now—to continue taking the subway, going to synagogue, eating at kosher restaurants. But other Jews may make different choices. They may stop being

observant, or may stop doing things that identify them as Jewish. They may move to Florida or Texas or out of a Jewish neighborhood. Put all those individual choices together and we lose the things that for more than a century made New York such a Jewish city.

What’s happening in New York is about more than one mayor running an administration oddly focused on demonizing Israel. The atmosphere is changing the character of what was once America’s most Jewish city and making it simply another place. It feels to many New York Jews as if something is being taken away, an atypical feeling in the American Jewish experience.

In this period before Rosh Hashana, the daily shofar blasts are supposed to get Jews thinking about what they have done wrong in the past year and how they could be better in the next. This year that sound is also having them look to the city that has long been the center of American Jewish life and hoping against hope that it too can be better in the year ahead.

Mr. Troy is a senior fellow at the Ronald Reagan Institute and a senior scholar at Yeshiva University’s Straus Center.

The ‘Medicare for All’ Math Doesn’t Add Up

By Thomas Beck

The notion of a “Medicare for All” system is enjoying a revival. Democratic primary victories by candidates who champion single-payer healthcare, most notably U.S. Senate candidates Abdul El-Sayed in Michigan and Peggy Flanagan in Minnesota, have pushed the proposal back into the healthcare debate.

What these candidates fail to understand—or refuse to acknowledge—is that applying Medicare payment rates to all services provided to all patients would destroy the American healthcare system.

The debate usually centers on taxes and the role of government. But there is a more fundamental question: Could America’s hospitals survive if every patient were reimbursed at Medicare rates?

The answer is no. This isn’t ideology; it’s math.

Congress’s Medicare Payment Advisory Commission estimates that hospitals lost about 12 cents on every Medi-

care dollar they received in 2024 and projects Medicare margins will remain roughly 10% below the break-even point in 2026. Those losses are sustainable only because Medicare is one part of a mixed-payer system.

The other main part is commercial insurance. A 2024 Rand study found that private insurers paid hospitals, on average, more than 2.5 times

Care for the elderly is subsidized by private insurance payments.

Medicare rates. Those much higher payments help support emergency departments, trauma centers, neonatal intensive-care units, behavioral health programs, teaching hospitals and rural facilities, as well as investment in technology, cybersecurity and emergency preparedness.

In effect, America’s hospitals are financed by a combi-

nation of public underpayment and private overpayment. The arrangement may not be elegant or even rational, but it keeps hospitals operating. Medicare for All would destroy that balance.

Supporters respond that hospitals could simply become more efficient. Greater efficiency is desirable, but it can’t bridge a reimbursement gap of this magnitude. Hospitals aren’t ordinary businesses. They can’t close the emergency department on a slow day or staff an intensive-care unit only when demand is high. They must maintain nurses, physicians, technicians, operating rooms, diagnostic equipment and emergency readiness around the clock.

If Congress imposed a regime that paid Medicare rates for every patient, hospitals would first freeze hiring, delay capital projects and postpone equipment purchases. Then would come staffing reductions and closing of money-losing services such as obstetrics and behavioral health.

OPINION

REVIEW & OUTLOOK

Ro Khanna Gets a Wealth Tax Education

Silicon Valley Rep. Ro Khanna is trying to reconcile his purported support for innovation with his endorsement of a wealth tax in California. He's pitching a way to ameliorate its impact on entrepreneurs, but his plan underscores the problem with wealth taxes.

The progressive from Silicon Valley has a not-so-bright idea.

Mr. Khanna upset his Silicon Valley donors last December when he came out for a ballot initiative that would impose a one-time (supposedly) 5% tax on the net worth of state residents with more than \$1 billion in wealth. "It's a matter of values," he said. "We believe billionaires can pay a modest wealth tax so working-class Californians have the Medicaid."

His endorsement did reveal his political values. But there's nothing modest about the measure—championed by the SEIU-United Healthcare Workers West—to confiscate wealth from California's top job creators.

The tax will punish private startup founders whose assets mostly consist of illiquid shares in their companies. They may lack cash and liquid assets to pay the tax bill. What are they supposed to do? The initiative would let them spread the payment over five years, though at a hefty interest charge.

They would also be allowed to defer payment until they are able to monetize their startup stake. As the Tax Foundation explains, the state would then become "a co-investor in the assets." If they appreciate over time, "California can tax the additional accumulated wealth even if the taxpayer has long since left the state." Neither option is appealing.

Last weekend on social media Mr. Khanna floated another idea. "Allow illiquid founders to pledge shares with a loan from the government to pay tax," he wrote. "The loan period is long but not infinite (e.g. 10 years)" and "at the end of the period, the loan is either paid back in cash, or the government assumes the shares."

"The government would make out if the company succeeds in terms of collection but founders would not be personally liable if the company somehow failed," he wrote. The latter isn't true, as others quickly corrected. Hedge fund manager Bill Ackman wrote that a founder could still owe

tax if he takes out a loan against his shares from the state and if the company fails.

Mr. Khanna later acknowledged as much. "If the shares go to zero the founder can still face capital gains tax on the deemed sale (basis is often near zero)," he said. "That's a real issue." Yes, it is.

A more obvious problem: The state would be lending money to billionaires to pay itself. As Mark Cuban mused, if the state doesn't receive any incremental revenue, "what's the point of that?" Also, what happens if a founder can't pay back the loan in 10 years? The government could then seize the shares.

"I'm sure the investors in those companies will be thrilled about their new partners," Mr. Cuban wryly noted. His point is that the prospect of government taking partial ownership and control of a startup would chill venture investment.

Palmer Luckey, who co-founded the defense tech startup Anduril Industries, shrewdly noted founders would have a 10-year "speedrun" to pay back their loans—or else surrender their shares to the government—which could warp a business's incentive to create long-term value for investors. "The behavioral incentives are so obviously horrible," he wrote.

Mr. Khanna apparently didn't think any of this through or, for that matter, what will happen if top earners who pay a large share of California's bills flee as a result of the wealth tax. "We only need this money because the Trump administration cut \$30 billion to our Medicaid program," he wrote. "If folks hadn't supported Trump and his medicaid cuts, maybe we wouldn't need this."

The state doesn't need the money. California's federal Medicaid payments have increased 14% (\$16.4 billion) over the last year. The left wants a wealth tax for its own punishing sake.

Ditto a tax on unrealized capital gains, which could be even more punitive for startup founders who would have to pay an annual federal tax of 23.8% on the paper gains of their shares. If nothing else, Mr. Khanna is doing a public service by exposing the left's wealth-tax follies.

worried about making ends meet, they're concerned about boys in girls' sports."

Taiwan confusion isn't limited to one party.

Recall Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez's unintelligible remarks this year in Munich. Asked about defending Taiwan, she rambled about making sure "we are moving in all of our economic research and our global positions to avoid any such confrontation." And AOC may run for President.

The free people of Taiwan are on the front lines against a Chinese Communist Party that wants to dominate the 21st century. If Beijing tries to blockade or invade the island, Americans will notice the economic and strategic damage that would go far beyond chip fabrication. And the idea that voters can't care about both women's sports and the fate of the free world is giving them too little credit.

"If America abandons Taiwan, it will change the world fundamentally for the worse," a notable GOP Senator said in 2022. "To abandon Taiwan is to give in to the rule of gun versus the rule of law." The late Lindsey Graham wouldn't mind if his sister—or AOC—borrowed that line.

they fired off another round in March 2021, even though the economy had mostly recovered. Then came the bipartisan infrastructure bonanza, followed by a pork-laden bill to subsidize computer chips and, to top it off, a climate extravaganza that Democrats hilariously named the Inflation Reduction Act.

This largess has cost more than the Congressional Budget Office originally estimated. Even so, the biggest contributors to soaring deficits fall under the category of "mandatory spending," including Medicaid, Medicare, Social Security, veteran benefits, and ObamaCare subsidies.

All of this is finally getting noticed now that the government has to pay higher interest rates. U.S. debt service payments totaled \$963 billion during the first 10 months of this fiscal year. That's \$200 billion more than spending on defense, and it's even slightly more than Medicare.

Republicans in last year's tax bill made modest reforms to Medicaid, food stamps and student loans, and they also rolled back some green-energy subsidies. Alas, these changes don't go far enough, and the GOP has shrunk from making bigger reforms.

The press is playing up the \$40 trillion milestone and rising interest rates to scare Republicans off further tax cuts to give the economy a supply-side boost. And to justify tax increases when Democrats next control Congress.

President Trump's advisers are reportedly noodling the good idea of adjusting capital gains for inflation. But the policy answer on the debt is spending restraint, and one reason yields on long-term Treasurys might be going up is that investors have concluded that neither party intends to quit the double cheeseburgers.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

What ObamaCare Was Meant to Accomplish

Thank you, Allysia Finley, for pointing out the clever ruse behind the Affordable Care Act ("Luigi Mangione and Democrats' ObamaCare Deflection," Life Science, Aug. 17). Many well-meaning people mistook ObamaCare as a means of providing medical care to the poor and uninsured. The real objective was the establishment of national health insurance through the backdoor.

In eliminating the antitrust exemptions, large hospitals were now allowed to purchase smaller ones, as well as primary-care practices, pharmacies, etc. The 340B federal drug program provided the cash to accomplish this.

These powerful, vertically integrated systems were able to squeeze private specialty practices out of business by gobbling up all the local primary-care practices and prohibiting referrals to physicians outside their system.

Once American healthcare is dominated by a handful of powerful regional medical systems, all that would be needed to enact a national healthcare system would be a congressional law nationalizing these systems and signed by a Democratic

president. Private health insurance would similarly be outlawed. Voila, national health insurance.

PETER V. PICKENS, M.D.
Wayne, Pa.

I agree with Ms. Finley. ObamaCare and Democratic minds created destruction of the superior medical care that once existed. These policies led to sicker patients, higher risks and raised premiums. Essential health benefits—mental health, addiction, maternity, etc.—forced all comprehensive plans and healthy people to pay more, with higher deductibles to prevent more expensive medications and healthcare shortages.

In addition to the corporatization of medicine—which interfered with physicians' ability to uphold their Hippocratic oath, imposed strict limits on the time they could devote to patient care and increased reliance on non-physician providers—the administrative control over essential equipment, resources and innovation was part of a deeply troubling and diabolical scheme.

ALAN C. GEISS, M.D.
Glen Cove, N.Y.

Why Get Three MMR Vaccines Instead of One?

Michael Segal advises that the MMR vaccine should be split into three shots ("3 Vaccines Are Better Than 1," op-ed, Aug. 18). He reasons this would reduce inflammatory triggers in children with variants of the SCN1A gene that make them susceptible to seizures and neurological deterioration. Mr. Segal cites his 2019 op-ed, "The Complicated Truth About Vaccines" but then ignores its lessons and practical difficulties with his prescription.

As Mr. Segal noted in 2019, children with "SCN1A mutations are destined to develop seizures and regress neurologically," regardless of vaccination. Vaccination could trigger a neurologic deterioration, "but had the children not been vaccinated, the same deteriora-

tion would have occurred anyway the next time they had a cold." In fact, in Dravet syndrome—the most common disorder associated with pathological SCN1A mutations—seizures are triggered by low-grade fevers or hot baths.

Moreover, Dravet syndrome is relatively rare. Why advise separate vaccines for all children when the combination MMR is safe for the overwhelming majority, particularly when subjecting parents and children to three separate shot appointments will likely decrease the number of children vaccinated?

Three separate shots may triple the number of complications over a single combination shot.

JOEL ZINBERG, M.D.
New York

How the Fed Can Make Capital Countercyclical

James Mackintosh is right that central banks are caught in a cycle of rescues that breed the leverage requiring the next rescue ("Streetwise: Central Banks Are Stuck in Cycle of Crises," Business & Finance, Aug. 17). One solution has been sitting unused for a decade.

The countercyclical capital buffer was designed precisely for this problem. Raise bank capital requirements during calm periods, when building the buffer is cheap and seems unnecessary, and release them during a downturn. The Federal Reserve adopted the framework in 2016 and has never once set the buffer above zero. The Bank of England holds its buffer at 2% in normal times, so it has something to release when the weather turns. Ours is a fire extinguisher that has never been filled.

I sat on the Federal Open Market Committee for a decade and supported facilities that did what Mr. Mackintosh describes. I would support most of them again. The lesson of the past 20 years isn't that we lack tools. It is that we reach for them only after the fact, because acting in a calm manner requires tightening when

nothing appears to be wrong.

The remedy isn't another emergency facility. It is the discipline to build margin while the sun is out.

PATRICK T. HARKER
Haddonfield, N.J.

Mr. Harker was president of the Philadelphia Fed from 2015 to 2025.

The Fed and the others became not market makers of last resort, but leveraged buy-and-hold investors of last resort, a completely different thing. A market maker is constantly buying and selling. The Fed was only buying, not selling, in order to push up the price of the securities and to drive down their yields. A market maker is in it to make money on the bid-asked spread; the Fed created giant leveraged naked long positions that might, and then did, lose vast amounts of money.

ALEX J. POLLOCK
Mises Institute
Lake Forest, Ill.

Who's Teaching Capitalism?

Kimberlee Josephson is right that the collegiate experience often inculcates socialism in students. Beyond the cost, there's at least one other driving factor ("How Colleges Produce Socialists," op-ed, Aug. 15).

Elite institutions are increasingly biased against practitioners, leading to a professional class that mostly has never worked anywhere else. Too many well-intended faculty members are ill-equipped to prepare their students for capitalism, having never experienced its opportunities and obligations. And too many trustees and administrators don't fight the incentives against hiring practitioners, not just career academics.

As Jesse Jackson said, "You can't teach what you don't know, and you can't lead where you don't go."

CHARLES MITCHELL
Open Discourse Coalition
Lewisburg, Pa.

Pepper ... And Salt

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL



"I think it's lovely, but I can't be sure without any comments to read."

Letters intended for publication should be emailed to wsj.letters@wsj.com. Please include your city, state and telephone number. All letters are subject to editing, and unpublished letters cannot be acknowledged.

OPINION

Americans Are Getting Caught in the Safety Net

By Paul Ryan
And Les Ford

Saturday marks the 30th anniversary of the 1996 welfare reform law, the Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Reconciliation Act. A rare bipartisan domestic-policy achievement, it began with a simple insight: Government assistance should help people move toward work and independence, not make poverty a permanent condition.

With labor-force participation declining, anxiety over job displacement by artificial intelligence, and millions of families seemingly stuck in poverty, the principle that guided

The 1996 welfare reform helped move people from dependency to work. We need to do that again.

the 1996 reform is in danger of being discarded. States should design a simpler safety net that rewards work, using 21st-century technology to do so.

Instead, technology leaders and politicians are endorsing universal basic income—regular cash payments regardless of work. Local governments have already launched at least 122 guaranteed-income pilots, which apply income limits but retain UBI’s defining feature: unconditional cash.

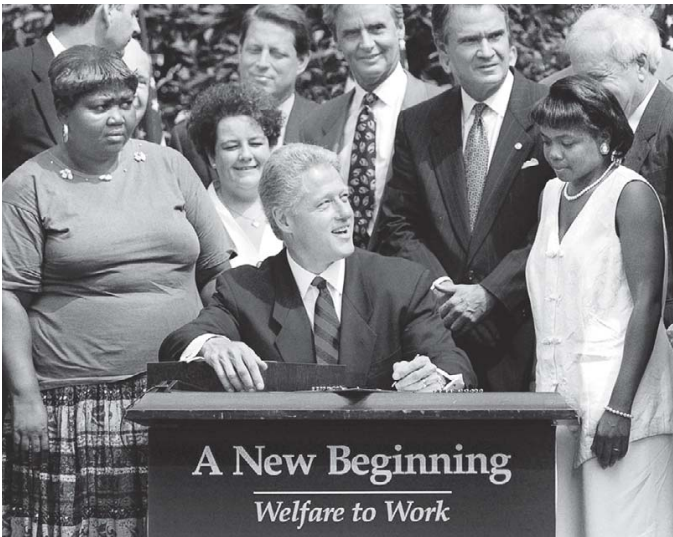
The appeal is understandable. America’s safety net is badly broken. It often punishes families who make progress toward financial stability. Parents who work more hours

or increase their salaries can lose more in benefits than they gain in income. In Illinois, a family earning an additional \$1,000, at a certain threshold, loses more than \$25,000 in net resources. Researchers at the Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta found that a hypothetical single parent in the District of Columbia gains nothing financially as earnings rise from \$11,000 to \$65,000. When these “benefit cliffs” punish parents for earning more or getting married, they weaken the foundations of self-sufficiency and help transmit poverty from one generation to the next.

Despite federal welfare spending reaching \$1.6 trillion annually—1 of every 5 dollars in the \$7.4 trillion federal budget—the dozens of disconnected programs remain a web. Families must navigate these complex programs with conflicting eligibility and reporting requirements for food, cash, health, child care and energy assistance. The result is a wasteful, siloed system that penalizes families for taking steps toward independence.

UBI doesn’t solve any of this and creates another benefit cliff. Rather than reforming the safety net that discourages work and marriage, UBI would make unconditional assistance a permanent feature.

The record shows that unconditional cash reduces work. Experiments with a negative income tax in the 1970s consistently produced employment and earnings losses. More recently, an OpenResearch randomized trial in Illinois and Texas found that guaranteed income reduced labor-force participation by 4.1 percentage points and annual earnings by roughly \$1,800.



President Clinton signs the welfare reform act, Aug. 22, 1996.

An American Enterprise Institute review of the few robust U.S. guaranteed-income experiments likewise found lower employment.

UBI would also be enormously expensive. Making the 2021 expanded child tax credit permanent would have cost about \$1.6 trillion over a decade. Providing every adult \$10,000 annually would cost roughly \$2.5 trillion a year.

Work is more than income—it’s a source of meaning, and it is central to family well-being. When parents don’t work and families are dependent on the safety net, they face higher rates of intergenerational poverty, worse physical and mental health, and shorter life expectancies. When parents gain employment, their well-being improves and their

children see better health, behavioral and education outcomes.

The better response to a broken safety net is to transform it. The path to the 1996 reform offers the model. Before Congress acted, governors in Iowa, Michigan, Minnesota and Wisconsin tested work-focused policies and proved that better results were possible for low-income families. After reform, employment among single mothers rose from about 51% in 1992 to 76% in 2000, while child poverty fell substantially.

Channeling the bipartisan spirit of 1996 welfare reform, we are teaming up with states, technologists and nonprofits to launch Resources for Independence, Stability and Employment pilot programs.

Through RISE pilots, states can attempt to address the deepest flaws of the current system. A RISE pilot will combine current benefits into one trackable, flexible benefit; phase that benefit down gradually as earnings rise; pair families with case management to tackle core issues; and require work, education or training. RISE pilots won’t assume success. Results will be assessed using randomized controlled trial standards.

States once lacked the technology to modernize benefits. Today, innovative, privacy-protected platforms can replace the patchwork of cards, vouchers and payments with one system that distributes benefits, applies requirements, audits spending and adjusts assistance continuously as incomes rise—ensuring that every earned dollar leaves a family better off. This removes the benefit cliffs and delivers a safety net designed to help parents move toward lasting independence.

Thirty years after welfare reform, America can build on its legacy by changing the incentives that trap families in poverty. Or we can abandon the work-first principle and layer unconditional cash onto an already failing system.

Our safety net should catch people when they fall. It shouldn’t hold them down or pay them to remain there.

Mr. Ryan is a partner at Solamere Capital and a visiting fellow at the American Enterprise Institute. He served as House speaker, 2015-19. Ms. Ford is president of Ford Policy Solutions. She served on the White House Domestic Policy Council, 2018-20.



POLITICAL ECONOMICS
By Joseph C. Sternberg

“What an exciting week for bond markets” isn’t generally a phrase one wants to hear, but here we are. Yields on U.S. Treasuries surged on Monday and Tuesday, especially at the longer end, with the 30-year briefly hitting a level last seen in 2007. Yields fell back down again on Wednesday after Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent announced an intervention: Starting next month, Treasury will accelerate its buyback of longer-dated bonds and issue shorter-term debt instead.

One of the sillier interpretations of these events is that somehow Federal Reserve Chairman Kevin Warsh is failing at his new job. In this telling, an excess of dovishness is causing long yields to rise in expectation of future inflation. Meanwhile, Mr. Bessent’s intervention supposedly is a repudiation of Mr. Warsh’s determination to keep government hands off the bond market.

Something much more interesting is afoot.

The most convincing explanation for the surge in yields is an uptick in expectations for future economic growth. This is manifested by the willingness of tech companies to bid up interest rates as they borrow to invest in artificial intelligence.

It’s the latest sign that “financial repression” is unwinding, and not a moment too soon. The term refers to a suite of economic policies (the details vary at different times and places) designed to allow the government to borrow at below-market rates, at the expense of savers and with woeful distortions throughout the economy. This has been the dominant policy mode across the West since the 2008 financial panic.

Financial repression in the U.S. is enforced primarily by the Federal Reserve, via the expansion of its balance sheet under quantitative easing. The central bank bought Treasuries and mortgage-backed securities, which it then held as assets on its balance sheet. In exchange, it created large new liabilities in the form of commercial banks’ reserve deposits at the central bank. Banks were encouraged to hoard these reserves both by black-letter liquidity regulations and by

strenuous winking and nodding by their supervisors at the Fed. The central bank also released a constant stream of forward guidance hinting at low rates in the future to deter markets from bidding up yields.

The effect of this on the government’s consolidated balance sheet was to exchange more expensive debt (Treasuries held by the public) for much cheaper debt (reserve balances

The Fed is becoming less willing to subsidize spendthrift lawmakers. This is a good turn.

on which the Fed paid lower interest). The net reduction in effective borrowing costs was achieved by the central bank’s remittances to the Treasury of its profits from this arrangement, which can be understood as a rebate of some of the interest Treasury paid to the Fed on the bonds the Fed now owned.

It was a great deal for spendthrifts in Congress, facilitating a runup in federal debt at interest

rates that hardly seem to represent the true risks of this situation. And it may be ending now. Despite the obvious ways this arrangement entangled the central bank with the Treasury, the Fed retained enough independence to raise policy rates after inflation took hold in 2021 and 2022. By late 2022, the interest rate paid on reserves started to exceed the yield on the Fed’s holdings of Treasury debt, a necessary if not sufficient condition for ending this form of financial repression.

Now, perhaps, we’re entering a new phase. Mr. Warsh is adamant about shrinking the Fed’s balance sheet. This would disable the primary mechanism by which the Fed-Treasury complex has suppressed government borrowing costs. And under his no-forward-guidance rubric, he isn’t delivering the central bank’s usual vague reassurances that rates probably will fall in the future. This has kicked out another crutch on which Treasury once could lean.

The result is a world where companies and investors are newly able to price risk in line with expected economic growth. For now, that means interest rates returning to their level before financial repression

began in earnest in 2008.

The big losers are lawmakers, who must pay market rates for debt. Interest payments are on track to be either the second- or third-largest federal expenditure in this fiscal year, behind Social Security and maybe Medicare. Expect that cost to grow as investors internalize the notion that the Fed may not always allow itself to become a backstop.

Whether or when this might become a financial crisis is a matter of debate. But it will become a political crisis soon, once Congress starts confronting some awkward realities about what constitutes “affordable” fiscal policy if the Fed no longer is subsidizing lawmakers’ bad decisions.

Seen in this light, Mr. Bessent’s bond intervention isn’t a challenge to Mr. Warsh’s hands-off approach to the government debt market, but rather a sign that Mr. Warsh’s approach is starting to work. Mr. Bessent’s move is the first—clumsy and likely ineffective—attempt by a politician to grapple with the implications of interest rates that are allowed to rise in line with economic growth. There will have to be more adjustments. Brace yourselves.

Dissent Grows Among Russia’s Political Elites

By Amy Knight

It is hardly surprising that Russia’s Supreme Court on Monday upheld the decision to disqualify the antiwar party Yabloko from September’s parliamentary elections. Although Yabloko wasn’t posed to challenge the overwhelming dominance of the pro-Kremlin United Russia Party, the Kremlin didn’t want votes for Yabloko to draw further attention to the Russian public’s growing discontent with the Ukraine conflict. Vladimir Putin is also concerned about dissent from members of his elite—with good cause—as the dismissal on Sunday of Andrei Klepach, chief economist at the Russian state-owned development bank VEB, demonstrates.

Mr. Klepach is one of Russia’s most prominent macroeconomists. He served from 2008 to 2014 as Mr. Putin’s deputy minister of economic

development, overseeing forecasting, strategic planning and budgeting. Then he took the position at VEB, which finances the state’s national projects. Reacting to news of his dismissal, Russian journalist Elizaveta Osetinskaya wrote: “The name Andrei Klepach is familiar to anyone who has followed the Russian economy over the past 30 years. ‘Call Klepach’ was the mantra of any economic journalist trying to make sense of budget news.” Russian economist Igor Lipsits observed that Mr. Klepach was “distinguished by the fact that he was very careful, but very honest in his assessments.”

Mr. Klepach’s honesty led him to cross a red line with the Kremlin in late May, when he spoke at the Nikitsky Club, an exclusive group of academics and entrepreneurs who meet monthly to discuss Russia’s critical issues. The repercussions came after a transcript of the meet-

ing, as per the club’s protocol, was recently published on the club’s website and sent to government bodies, business organizations and media outlets.

In his presentation, Mr. Klepach painted a discouraging picture of the Russian economy, which he said was on the brink of stagnation. He predicted that, given the continuation of the “special military operation” (a Kremlin euphemism for the war), a possible new wave of sanctions, and mounting losses from Ukrainian strikes on industrial facilities and transport infrastructure, gross domestic product growth in 2027 might not exceed 1% to 1.5%.

During the discussion that followed, Mr. Klepach went further, committing heresy in the eyes of Mr. Putin, who insists that Russia’s war against Ukraine is going splendidly. “We are losing the global race, both technologically and economically,” Mr. Klepach said. “We aren’t just losing to China and the U.S. In some respects, we are losing to Ukraine—however unpleasant that may be for me to admit.” The Ukrainian economy was surviving, he went on, because of massive amounts of Western aid. Thus Russia wouldn’t win “the competitive race in this war of attrition.” Mr. Klepach warned that in Russia “a social crisis could erupt at a time when no one is really expecting it” and noted ominously that in 1917, “no one expected the February Revolution either.”

Mr. Klepach said that the quality of the government’s administration is “in a state of almost constant degradation” and that state enterprises often falsify data. The economist even took a jab at the Federal

Security Service’s effort against corruption, Mr. Putin’s main tool for going after opponents: “The only thing worse than corruption is the fight against it. When the process reaches a point where you can’t take a single step without investigators or prosecutors showing up—so everyone is terrified and refuses to make any decisions—it leads to a state of semiparalysis across many organizations.”

The firing of a high-profile economist reveals Putin’s anxiety over insiders’ opposition to the war.

Dissent from Russian elites won’t go away with Mr. Klepach’s dismissal. Several participants in the May discussion—prominent experts at Russia’s leading academic institutions—congratulated Mr. Klepach for his “brilliant” presentation and agreed with what he said.

Mr. Klepach’s boss at VEB, Igor Shuvalov, a former deputy prime minister who reportedly was ordered by the Kremlin to fire Mr. Klepach, also has reservations about Mr. Putin’s war. At the St. Petersburg Economic Forum in June, Mr. Shuvalov pushed back against hawkish speakers who advocated putting the country on a war footing with state management of the economy. He said that technological leadership is “based on freedom, not on total state direction.”

Sberbank CEO German Gref, a former minister of economic development who supervised Mr. Klepach

for several years, had the temerity to say at a June shareholders meeting: “I think we all care about the same thing. I do not think that there is a person in the country who has any other worries, except for the speedy completion of hostilities, it is obvious.”

More recently, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin—frequently touted as a possible successor to Mr. Putin—expressed strong opposition to a war economy in an interview with the Russian state-owned news agency TASS: “We constantly hear talk about the need to mobilize the entire economy, to gear it toward the war effort. . . . But if there is no civilian economy . . . then we won’t achieve success in the war either. And to kill off normal life and the normal economy is to kill the country itself.” These unusually outspoken public comments reflect the strain on Russian officials and businessmen who have to navigate the damage to Russia’s economy caused by the war.

Mr. Putin’s Federal Security Service arrests and imprisons ordinary Russians for expressing even small signs of opposition to the war. A Russian court on Monday sentenced Yabloko leader Lev Shlosberg to 11 years in prison for speaking out against the war. But similar reprisals against high-level officials close to the Kremlin could backfire and arouse even more elite discontent. While Mr. Klepach will doubtless accept his resignation quietly, he has spread his bold message to those who matter.

Ms. Knight is author, most recently, of “The Kremlin’s Noose: Putin’s Bitter Feud With the Oligarch Who Made Him Ruler of Russia.”

SPORTS



Walter Matthau, center, as Coach Morris Buttermaker in ‘The Bad News Bears.’

JASON GAY

Youth Sports Are Really Bonkers. How to Survive Another Season.

We all just want the kids to have fun. And maybe play one less game per weekend.



When I watch the Little League World Series, I don't pay much attention to the players. Don't get me wrong—the kids are impressive. I say this as a former backup right fielder who spent most of his Little League career batting ninth and praying to the tormented ghost of Shoeless Joe that the ball wouldn't be hit his way.

Today, I'm more interested in the parents, the journeys, sacrifices and terrible fast food breakfasts that got them there. I'm a floundering sports parent myself, and though I know these Little League parents are proud, I suspect they're going to be secretly thrilled when the season is mercifully over, and they don't have to sleep in another highway motel with an overchlorinated pool and an ancient vending machine that sells only Twix and Pall Malls.

These are tricky days for the American sports parent. We're getting ugly press. We're getting clobbered on social media. Bill Sim-

mons is ranking them sport-by-sport on his podcast. We're presumed to be coldhearted tyrants who spend too much money on gear and private coaches and daydream about DI scholarships that will never come. I won't lie: there's a bunch of that. But there are a lot of parents, and coaches, who try to stay sane and do it the right way, without screaming at teenaged referees or kickboxing another parent in the parking lot. This column is for them.

■ **The system is broken.** You may have learned this the first time you walked into a sporting goods store and laughed at a \$300 bat, and I know there are a bunch of you saying: *That's not even that bad a price for a bat, buddy.* The professionalization of youth sports—the incursion of for-profit companies strip-mining American childhood—hasn't only wiped out recreational

sports, it's created a pernicious money culture. Whenever there's money culture, there's going to be extra pressure. Your kid is no longer striking out with the bases loaded. That kid is striking out with a bat and assorted gear that cost more than a Cape Cod weekend.

■ **We need to bring back the ugly canvas bag.** This applies to baseball especially, but can be deployed in other sports. My Little League coach used to arrive at the field carrying an Army-olive canvas bag that contained bats in various states of decay, four ill-fitting batting helmets, and an ancient set of catcher's equipment that looked like it had been stolen from a yard sale at Yogi Berra's house. There was the bat that everyone thought was a thumper and the bat that made you feel electrocuted if you hit the ball in weather below 70 degrees. There was the helmet with a

safe amount of padding and the padding-deprived helmet that may have been obtained with a vanilla sundae at Dairy Queen. Somehow, our "Bad News Bears" style outfit played 20 or so Little League games with this cruddy communal gear, scored a fair number of runs, and nobody's parents had to go into credit card debt or get a second job to pay for a sliding glove.

■ **You're not a true sports parent until** you've woken up in the darkness to the magical patter of rain, and felt a joy you haven't felt since your young athlete was born. No one will admit it on the parent chat, but by a certain point of the season, there is no more beloved tournament than the canceled tournament.

■ **We are awash in "sports expert" culture.** I don't know if there's a worse creature on social media than the self-appointed sports parent guru who delivers unsolicited advice about how to game the system and get your hopeful athlete in the eye line of a college coach. They

have mastered the racket: The business of youth sports isn't creating memories for kids, it's farmmongering, and preying on the emotional and financial insecurities of the parents. There's not a sports parent who hasn't asked him or herself: *am I doing this correctly*, and the system is set up to capitalize on that anxiety. We're being conditioned to think there's always a better team, situation, schedule, stick. Spoiler alert: there's really not. It's all kind of the same deal, with different colors of poly-fiber laundry. The only thing that really matters is whether the kid runs out the door to play, or has to be pried off the bed like a cat that hears the bathtub running.

■ **Coaching.** I am shocked by how casually parents of very young athletes talk about the need for quality, professionalized coaching, as if they've dropped their child off at FC Barcelona and not the Under 8 Little Kickers D Team. I don't think our parents thought this way. I don't think they expected youth sports to be a laboratory of athletic development. I think our parents dropped us off at practice thinking: *Sweet! Ninety minutes where my kid is someone else's problem. Now where is that Twix and Pall Mall vending machine?*

■ **Please know: I am terrible at this.** Really terrible. Parents like to act like they're cool and above it all, but nobody's that cool or above it all. No matter how ridiculous it all is, when I hear other parents talk about competing clubs and leagues, I get paranoid that I'm doing it all wrong. When I dropped my daughter off at a three-day, two-night sports camp this summer, I was stunned to see other parents—one with a ladder—elaborately decorating the front doors of their campers' rooms. These kids had fancy snacks, posters and portable speakers, while my kid was in a gray cell block staring at four concrete walls like she was about to do hard time for grand larceny. I felt awful, like I had failed her. She survived two nights, but make no mistake: I am totally coming back next year with a ladder and decorations.

■ **I know I'm going to miss it.** My kids are young enough to be in the thick of it but old enough that I am starting to see the end of the road. I complain about the time commitments and travel and I'm never going to be interested in the tub of lukewarm scrambled eggs at the tournament hotel. But I can already feel the pit in my stomach, counting down these car trips and moments where it is just me and my child, and I ask them to take off their headphones and listen, because Daddy wants to lecture them for the 30th time about why Van Halen's "1984" was a really important album. Then I watch them roll their eyes, mutter "You already told me this, Dad" and put their headphones back on. I don't know about the weekend double-headers, but I'm going to miss that, for sure.

His Name Is Tugboat. He Throws an 'Invisiball.' He's Now a Major-Leaguer.

By JARED DIAMOND

BY ALL ACCOUNTS, Matt Wilkinson shouldn't be able to get professional hitters out.

The pitcher better known as "Tugboat" is a 250-pound left-hander with a 90 mph fastball, an unremarkable slider and not much else to speak of. On paper, the one thing he has going for him is a nickname so retro that it's practically covered in pine tar and has transformed an otherwise ordinary prospect into an unlikely cult hero.

But here's the crazy part: Wilkinson has thrived in the minors, even though his own coaches can't always explain it. He has posted a 3.10 ERA and struck out 11 batters per nine innings since being drafted in the 10th round in 2023. And now, against all conventional wisdom, Tugboat has docked in the big leagues.

Wilkinson made his debut for the San Francisco Giants on Wednesday, completing his improbable journey from suburban Vancouver to the highest level of the sport. He started against the Cleveland Guardians, never topped 91 mph and worked two shutout innings.

In other words, he was Tugboat.

"When you realize that velocity isn't everything, you know that different things can work," Giants Triple-A pitching coach Alain Quijano said. "And this is something that can work."

The sophisticated computer models and advanced metrics that

rule the modern game largely suggest otherwise. Little about Wilkinson's repertoire or his physique indicated that he'd reach this point. This is a player who inherited the Tugboat moniker in his youth because he supposedly looked like a small, seafaring vessel while lumbering around the bases.

Except the 23-year-old Tugboat has a secret weapon. It's called the "Invisiball"—baseball jargon for a pitch that batters inexplicably can't hit, as if it simply disappears on its way to the plate. So far, almost no one has been able to figure it out.

Tugboat's seemingly unimpressive heater might not light up the radar gun, but batters insist it feels much faster than it actually is. It even gives the illusion of rising.

That's because Tugboat throws from an unusually low angle that opponents aren't accustomed to seeing, with mechanics that allow him to effectively hide the ball. Paul Quantrill, Tugboat's pitching coach with Team Canada at the World Baseball Classic earlier this year, said the pitch looks like it "comes out of his jersey."

The result is a fastball that Quijano describes as "a short little bazooka at 90 miles an hour." Jeff Duda, Tugboat's longtime coach at the Okotoks Dawgs Academy in Alberta, said his fastball feels more like 94. He turns to the "Invisiball" about 60% of the time.

"Maybe our algorithms say this isn't going to play," Quantrill said. "But apparently that f—ing hitter



Matt Wilkinson worked two shutout innings in his debut for the San Francisco Giants on Wednesday

didn't get the memo, because he's not hitting it very good."

At the lower levels of the minors, Tugboat was practically untouchable. His first major test came in March, when he had the opportunity to pitch for Canada in the WBC. He worked two innings against Team USA's star-studded lineup without surrendering a hit, retiring the likes of Alex Bregman, Cal Raleigh and Pete Crow-Armstrong. Tugboat finished his outing by striking out two-time MVP Bryce Harper.

It was just one game, but it was meaningful. At every turn, from his appearance in the Little League World Series to junior college to the minors, Tugboat was

told his magic trick wouldn't work at the next level. He has proved his doubters wrong at every step.

"Tug's heard that more than he cares to hear it," Quantrill said. "But it does play."

Back in May, the Giants acquired Tugboat in a trade with the Guardians, the organization that drafted him. It cost them catcher Patrick Bailey, a two-time Gold Glove winner.

With the Giants far out of the playoff race and in danger of losing Tugboat if they didn't add him to their 40-man roster soon, they decided to promote him. Duda learned the news directly from Tugboat in a late-night phone call on Sunday.

And he isn't the only one rooting for Tugboat to succeed. He has emerged as such a popular figure because it seems like he belongs to a previous generation of baseball.

Tugboat doesn't throw hard at a time when pitchers throw harder than ever before. His nickname harkens back to an era of Docs, Lefties and Pee Wees. He also has the body of exactly the sort of person who would be called Tugboat.

Of course, that doesn't make facing him any easier.

"You see them take swings on his fastball," Quijano said. "And you just go, 'Yeah, that is different.'"

PARAMOUNT PICTURES/EVERETT COLLECTION

KEN BLAZER/MAGN IMAGES/REUTERS

Walmart's Sales Gain Hits 6-Year Low

New pharmacy pricing requirement eats into consumer spending growth

By Sarah Nassauer

Walmart reported its smallest sales growth in more than six years as some Americans continue to spend cautiously—especially when shopping at the retailer's physical stores.

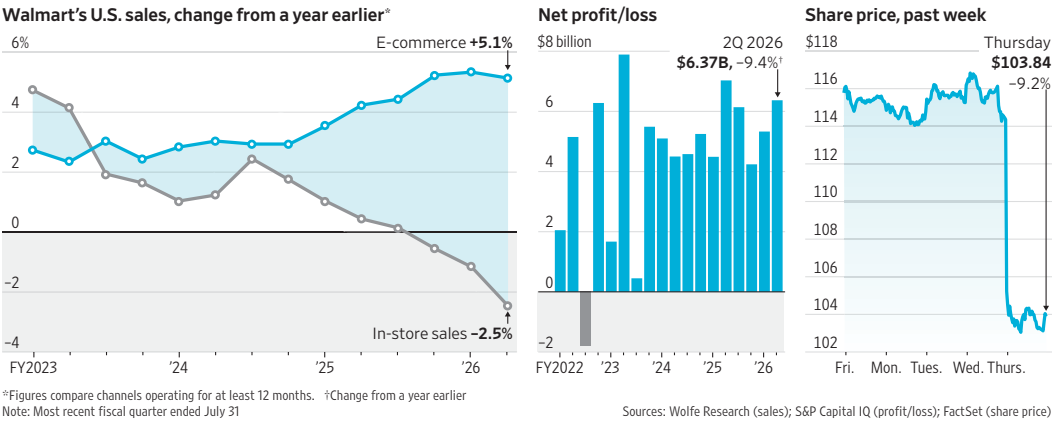
On Thursday, Walmart said U.S. comparable sales, those from store and digital channels operating for the past 12 months, rose 2.6%. That is the smallest quarterly increase the retailer has reported since 2020. The number was hurt by new pharmacy-pricing regulations, without which Walmart would have had a 3.4% lift, the company said. That is below analysts' estimates of a 3.8% gain, according to FactSet.

Shares of Walmart fell \$10.46, or 9.2% to \$103.84. It was their largest percent decrease since May 17, 2022.

Walmart's slower growth came as some consumers continue to watch their wallets amid higher gasoline prices and the company navigates a shift to sales growth driven by new channels—increasingly e-commerce, membership and advertising sales, not its core big-box base. It is a marked transition for the Bentonville, Ark.-based retailer that still earns the bulk of its sales and profits from sprawling supercenters.

Much of the growth came from a 24% increase in U.S. e-commerce sales, a figure that includes Walmart's increas-

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The retailer says some consumers watch their wallets amid higher gasoline prices. A store in Teterboro, N.J.

Weil Stars In Talks To Leave Amid Wave Of Exits

Departures come as law firm prepares to navigate a transition in its leadership

By Cara Lombardo
And Erin Mulvaney

Weil, Gotshal & Manges, a Wall Street law firm known for shepherding companies through bankruptcies and advising top private-equity firms, is facing a wave of partner defections.

Two groups that include star lawyers are in discussions to leave for rivals, said people familiar with the matter, including some of the firm's highest revenue producers.

One group, which includes Christopher Machera, co-head of Weil's private-equity group and a member of its management committee, is headed to Paul Weiss, they said.

Other lawyers, including Brian Parness, a partner in Weil's private-equity practice whose clients have included Brookfield and TPG, are exploring a move to Simpson Thacher & Bartlett, the people said, with some cautioning the plan isn't final.

It is the latest tremor in the world of Big Law, which is being disrupted by aggressive poaching of rainmakers, the pressure of artificial intelligence and less-loyal clients. Earlier this summer, a team of six litigation partners, including a firm leader, left Wachtell in an almost-unheard-of defection from the marquee firm.

Hundreds of partners have made lateral moves this year across the industry. Rivals are luring top talent with pay packages that can stretch to \$20 million a year or more.

Weil, which has 1,200 lawyers, has also hired partners away from its competitors. The firm said it has added more than 50 lateral partners since the start of 2025.

"Weil is on track to achieve both record revenue and profitability in 2026 that will result in a very significant increase in profits per equity partner," the firm said. "This is a direct result of the firm's deliberate growth strategy focused on the practices and markets where it has long been a leader."

Founded in 1931 as a Jewish law firm outside the white-shoe elite, Weil built its reputation handling bankrupt-

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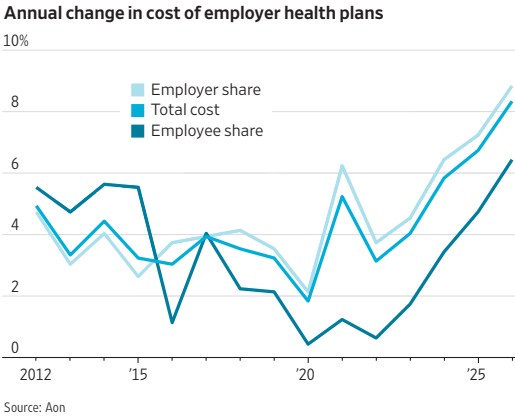
Employers, Workers Face Rise in Healthcare Costs

By Anna Wilde Mathews
And Peter Loftus

Healthcare costs are wallowing U.S. workers, and they will only worsen next year. For 2027, employers may be facing the biggest health-insurance increase in at least two decades.

Americans with workplace coverage are expected to spend an average \$5,297 this year on healthcare, \$388 more than 2025, according to a new estimate from benefits-consulting firm Aon. The spending represents a combination of payroll deductions for premiums and out-of-pocket charges like deductibles and copays.

The burden is likely to grow significantly next year, when U.S. employers expect their healthcare costs to go up by 11%, according to a new survey from WTW, another big bene-



fits consultant—the steepest rise in more than 20 years.

That would represent the fifth year of escalating increases, according to WTW. "Employers are telling us that this is utterly unsustainable,"

said Jeff Levin-Scherz, population-health leader at WTW. Expensive cancer treatments and wide adoption of weight-loss drugs are among the factors pushing up spending.

At larger companies, the

rapid rise has moved decisions around health benefits from the domain of human-resources executives into the C-suite, said Mike Pasterick, North America health-solutions leader at Aon. "We're seeing a lot of interest now from the finance organization and even the CEO and the board."

As companies are forced to pay more for insurance, their workers, who typically pay a share of the premium, are seeing their own costs rise roughly in tandem. That means more dollars are held out of their paychecks each month.

At Paul Wissmach Glass Co., which employs 35 people in Paden City, W.Va., co-owner Jason Wilburn said he has been hit by double-digit premium increases each year since his family bought the company in 2021. Health-in-

surance expenses now consume about 5% of the firm's revenue—more than its profit margin.

This year, the company raised the biweekly payroll deduction for a single worker to \$50, from \$40. Though the employer is still paying about 90% of the total premium, a few workers decided to drop their coverage when their costs went up.

"It's frustrating and sad," Wilburn said. "Something's got to change."

Americans are paying more out of pocket for healthcare in the form of deductibles, copayments and coinsurance, as well as expenses not covered by their insurance, according to federal data.

"Healthcare spending recently has risen more quickly than income," said Michael Chernew, a healthcare-policy

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Private Credit Looks To British Pensions

By Joe Wallace

LONDON—Private credit giants have found a \$1 trillion-plus source of capital to invest: dowdy old British pensions.

London's Standard Life said on Thursday it struck a deal to invest in private-market assets supplied by buyout company CVC Capital Partners, Goldman Sachs and PGIM's asset-management business. The U.K. insurer said the partnership would help boost its business taking over the management of defined pension plans from companies.

The deal, in which investors will earmark \$2 billion, is the latest example where U.K. life insurers managing pensions are turned into a source of funding for private credit.

Apollo, Brookfield and Blackstone did their own deals over the past year, muscling in on a booming market for legacy pension plans that life insurers are competing to take over from the companies that first sponsored them.

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Starbucks will lay off more than 200 corporate staff as part of turnaround effort. **B3**



HEARD ON THE STREET
Off-grid energy systems tested by demand for power. **B10**

Stripe Sets Stronger AI Footing In \$7 Billion OpenRouter Deal

By Kate Clark

When Stripe co-founder Patrick Collison took the stage at the payment company's annual conference in April, he declared it "Day 119 of the singularity."

Collison, among the more well-known billionaire entrepreneurs in Silicon Valley, had long been a prominent voice about the transformational potential of AI.

But his payments company, which had aggressively sought to embrace and adopt AI, wasn't as close to the action as foundational startups like OpenAI and Anthropic.

That changed with Stripe's purchase of OpenRouter, a company with 90 employees that helps developers cut costs by steering their requests to a variety of AI models. Stripe paid more than \$7 billion for the company, which had been valued at \$1.3 billion earlier this year.

On Wednesday, the two companies announced the deal.



Stripe CEO Patrick Collison.

In a statement, Collison said that "tokens are the central currency for companies building with AI, and it's clear that the real-world economic potential will depend on making good use of scarce compute resources."

It is the largest-ever acquisition for Stripe, which was founded in 2010 and has remained a private company. In a letter to investors, Collison suggested Stripe is better off as

a private company because of the "singularity," tech speak for the moment when AI becomes more capable than humans.

The deal will expand Stripe's AI business, giving the payments company a bigger role in the rapidly growing market for AI tokens, the central unit of measurement for processing AI queries.

Owning OpenRouter gives Stripe—which provides payment-processing software, helping companies accept internet payments—a way to profit directly as businesses spend more on AI models, on top of the revenue it generates from processing their payments.

It also represents the successful second act for New York-based OpenRouter founder Alex Atallah, who previously co-founded a marketplace for nonfungible tokens, OpenSea, during the cryptocurrency craze. OpenSea earned a peak valuation of \$13.3 billion before its business plummeted

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Private Credit Woos Pensions

Continued from page B1 housing, energy systems and infrastructure, possibly giving Britain's sluggish economy a boost.

But regulators and analysts worry insurers are chasing complex offshore investments that introduce new risks into the industry as part of the pensions boom.

About 40% of the assets backing U.K. insurers' fast-growing retirement books come from private-markets and other sources, where assets don't trade frequently or on exchanges, analysts at S&P Global estimate. Of that, around one-third are private-credit investments such as loans to midsize companies, more than in other European countries.

The caveat, the ratings agency said in July: Lack of standardized data made it hard to calculate insurers' exposures to different types of assets.

Transfers of U.K. pension plans to insurers aren't new. But they have proliferated since rising rates pulled down pension plans' obligations faster than their assets. Many plans flipped to a surplus for the first time in over a decade.

All of a sudden, they could afford to pay insurers to take on their obligations through a contract known as a bulk annuity. The first step is to hand a plan's assets over to an insurer, which starts to manage them. Eventually, it administers the whole thing.

Insurers like private-market assets because they are a good match for long-dated liabilities.

Gareth Truran, the Bank of England official who supervises insurers, said this spring pressure to secure profit mar-

gins is encouraging some insurers to take risks without sufficient compensation, though he added that their assets are overwhelmingly investment grade.

Brookfield recently bought life insurer Just Group, which it plans to feed with infrastructure, energy and real-estate investments.

Instead of buying an insurer, Blackstone agreed to supply private-credit assets for Legal & General to buy against its huge book of retirement obligations. One early deal: lending to a grocery-distribution center in North Carolina.

"The U.K. is one of our most important markets," said Phil Sherrill, an insurance executive at Blackstone.

Blackstone also is tapping in to Britain's booming pensions market indirectly through a Bermudan reinsurer it provides with private-credit investments.

The Bank of England, however, says U.K. insurers don't hold enough loss-absorbing capital against this kind of off-shore arrangement and plans to make them hold more.

Of the North American players in the U.K., Apollo is taking the biggest swing.

Athora, a European insurer in which it owns a minority stake, recently bought Britain's Pension Insurance Corp., which specializes in taking pension plans over from companies. Combined, the pair form one of Europe's biggest life-insurance groups with £118 billion in assets for 3.1 million savers and retirees.

They include current and future pensioners from **Rolls-Royce** and **British American Tobacco**, which Pension Insurance Corp. took over before Athora swooped in. Among its latest deals: to take on all 253 members of the pension plan for the Associated Board of the Royal Schools of Music.

"It's one of the largest and most vibrant in Europe," Athora CEO Todd Solash said of Britain's market for pension transfers.

and insurers. Hospitals have been able to win price increases and are increasingly using artificial-intelligence tools to boost their billing, leading to higher payments.

Workers are also using more medical services and taking high-cost drugs for an array of conditions. Among the major causes for rising costs are cancer treatments and the popular diabetes and weight-loss drugs known as GLP-1s. Employee utilization of GLP-1 drugs for weight loss grew 75% in 2025 across Aon's clients, the firm said.

BUSINESS & FINANCE



BRIAN KAISER/REUTERS

Sales of groceries, toys, fashion and private brands were strong in the most recent quarter.

Walmart Sales Grow Slower

Continued from page B1 ingly prominent advertising-revenue business. Walmart sells ads that run in its digital channels and stores.

In-store comparable sales, meanwhile, declined in the "low single digits," following a trend of the previous two quarters, Walmart Chief Financial Officer John David Rainey said on a conference call Thursday. Many pharmacy purchases are made in stores, so the weakness of that business had an impact, he said.

But, more broadly, "the relevance of store comps, I think, is not as pertinent as it was a decade ago," said Rainey in a separate interview. For example, items ordered online and picked up in store parking lots are counted as e-commerce sales, he said, so increasingly stores are a digital-fulfillment node that enable speedy delivery. "It's a legacy fixation," he said. "We are not the Walmart of a decade ago."

Top executives are discussing if they should report those store-fulfilled sales differently

to better reflect Walmart's current business model, he said. E-commerce accounts for nearly a quarter of overall sales, and 80% of those orders are fulfilled from its stores.

The online and offline channels "are blurring, but slowdown in in-store comps is going to be important to watch," said Spencer Hanus, retail analyst at Wolfe Research. Overall Walmart's quarterly results are solid, even with slightly weaker sales, he said, but that weakness means "results will be more scrutinized going forward."

Sales of groceries, toys, fashion and private brands were strong in the most recent quarter, and Walmart said it is gaining market share broadly, but especially among higher-income households, a term the retailer uses to describe households that earn \$100,000 a year or above. Lower-income shoppers continue to spend cautiously, but they are spending, said Rainey. "It appears there were choices between necessities within the quarter because of where gas prices are," he said.

Walmart also lowered some prices in the quarter, using some of the windfall of its \$2.9 billion in tariff refunds. Prices during the quarter were still slightly higher than the same period last year after overall cost increases, said Rainey, but

the company put in place additional price cuts near the end of the period and is giving priority to price investments on items that have been particularly affected, such as beef. Walmart is "muting what was otherwise a higher price increase where consumers were feeling pressure," he said.

The quarterly sales lift was enough for Walmart to raise its net sales and operating-income estimates for the full year. It now expects net sales to increase 4% to 5% for the full year, up from a previous estimate of 3.5% to 4.5%. Operating income will rise 7% to 8.5% for the full year, up from a 6% to 8% range set earlier this year, the company said.

Walmart's latest results add to a string of mixed quarterly-sales reports from retailers in recent days. Target said its quarterly comparable sales rose 3.8%, reversing last year's declines. TJX, which owns chains such as T.J. Maxx and Marshalls, said that its comparable sales rose 4% in the most recent quarter, but that its flagship U.S. store sales grew by just 1% after it made some apparel missteps.

Walmart's net sales rose 5.9% to \$186.1 billion in the most recent quarter ended July 31. Net income fell 9.4% to \$6.37 billion as the decline of some equity investments ate into profits.

Stripe Sets Stronger AI Footing

Continued from page B1 because of a crash in NFT sales volume.

Atallah is among a wave of entrepreneurs from the crypto boom who have pivoted to AI, part of a migration of leaders from earlier technology eras into the industry. Airbnb co-founder Brian Chesky, former Salesforce co-CEO Bret Taylor, Uber co-founder Travis Kalanick and LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman are all working on new AI companies.

People close to Atallah describe him as someone with a knack for spotting emerging technology trends early. Early in his career, he worked as a forward-deployed engineer at Palantir before moving through a pair of startups, one in human resources and another focused on anonymous social polling that he describes on LinkedIn as a "millennial Nielsen."

As the popularity of cryptocurrency reached new heights in 2018, he started OpenSea. The startup's value skyrocketed thanks to the surge in trading of digital artwork.

At its peak, OpenSea crossed \$5 billion in total monthly trading volumes. But amid the crypto collapse in 2022, NFT sales volumes dived and never recovered as investors soured on the assets.

Atallah started OpenRouter in 2023 with Chris Clark and Louis Vichy. OpenAI had recently launched ChatGPT, and Anthropic had just introduced its first large language model. As his startup grew, Atallah began referring to OpenRouter as the "Stripe of AI."

The startup rose as much of Silicon Valley was betting that OpenAI and Anthropic would dominate the market. OpenRouter had the opposite view: that no single model would win, and developers would increasingly use many of them for different tasks.

Hong Kong Company Files for Panama Arbitration

By MEGAN CHEAH

Hong Kong conglomerate **CK Hutchison** has launched international arbitration proceedings against Panama, escalating a dispute over two strategically important ports that have become caught up in U.S.-China tensions.

The conglomerate said it is seeking more than US\$1.5 billion in damages for the "destruction of the company's investments" in the country.

Hutchison alleged that Panama breached an investment protection treaty through a series of measures taken between 2025 and 2026, which it said resulted in the "destruction" of the concession contract for the ports of Balboa and Cristobal, located on either end of the Panama Canal, and Panama taking over these terminals.

Efforts to reach a resolution before initiating arbitration were unsuccessful, the company added.

The board added it "strongly disagrees" with the measures taken by Panama and will continue to seek resolution with the country while pursuing its rights under the treaty and international law.

The move intensifies a dispute that began in January, when a Panamanian court voided CK Hutchison's contracts to run two terminals at either end of the Panama Canal. Hutchison has been in dispute over the concessions since Panama's Supreme Court ruled its port operations unconstitutional.

The ruling was seen as a win for the Trump administration amid rising China-U.S. tensions, as the U.S. continued efforts to curb China's influence in the Western Hemisphere.

—Fabiana Negrin Ochoa contributed to this article.

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BUSINESS NEWS

Starbucks Plans More Layoffs

Tech, development teams targeted as investments in cafes will continue

By Heather Haddon

Starbucks will lay off more than 200 corporate staff, continuing a strategy to tighten its operations two years into a turnaround effort pursued by Chief Executive Brian Niccol. The Seattle company plans to cut about 120 technology workers, according to the company, after those staff declined to relocate to Nashville, Tenn., where a new corporate office is being built. Starbucks is cutting an additional 104 jobs in coffee-house design and development. Starbucks, the world's largest coffee chain, is working toward Niccol's goal of eliminating \$2 billion in costs by the end of its 2028 fiscal year. It is also investing more heavily in its cafe operations. The company recently estimated that its U.S. stores are nearly all fully staffed, and most in-store and drive-through orders are being delivered within four minutes, a target set by Niccol. Under Niccol, Starbucks has



The job cuts, detailed in a filing in Washington state, don't involve shutting down cafes.

scrutinized its store base, closing locations that haven't performed, don't provide the right store environment or should be relocated. Niccol has said that Starbucks needs to focus its operations to better serve this strategy. The job cuts, detailed in a filing in Washington state, don't involve shutting down cafes. Starbucks last month re-

ported quarterly earnings and sales that outpaced analysts' expectations, and increased its forecast for full-year same-store sales and earnings. Executives have said the turnaround efforts are gaining traction. Earlier this year, Starbucks laid off 300 U.S. corporate employees, while closing regional corporate offices in Chicago, Atlanta, Dallas and Burbank,

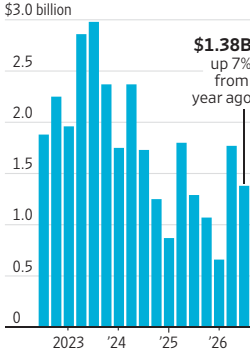
Calif. The company is developing a \$100 million corporate office in Nashville, which will house 2,000 employees, including technology and supply-chain functions. Starbucks in 2025 laid off around 2,000 corporate workers, while eliminating hundreds of open positions and closing hundreds of U.S. stores.

Deere's Profit Rises As Revenue Climbs

By Connor Hart

Deere posted higher profit and sales in its fiscal third quarter, as continued growth in the company's construction equipment business helped to offset continuing weakness in its production agriculture segment. The company posted a profit of \$1.38 billion for its three months ended Aug. 2, compared with \$1.29 billion in last year's comparable period. On a per-share basis, quarterly earnings of \$5.10 a share topped the \$4.69 a share that analysts polled by FactSet expected. Net sales and revenue climbed 6.2% to \$11 billion, ahead of Wall Street models for \$10.81 billion. The total top-line figure came in at \$12.61 billion. Sales across the company's production and precision agriculture division—its largest business unit—came in at \$4 billion, down 6.4% from a year ago. The company attributed the decrease primarily to lower shipment volumes. The decline was offset by construction and forestry sales, which jumped 18% to

Deere's quarterly net income



Note: Latest fiscal quarter ended Aug. 2, 2026.

\$3.62 billion, and small agriculture and turf sales, which rose 12% to \$3.38 billion. Chief Executive John May said Deere continues to believe 2026 will mark the bottom of the current agriculture equipment cycle. Deere raised the low end of its net income outlook to \$4.75 billion from \$5 billion, while maintaining the high end at \$5 billion. Shares advanced nearly 7% to \$620.94 in Thursday's trading.

JD Sports Shares Tumble After Profit-Guidance Cut

By Michael Hennessey

JD Sports Fashion shares dropped after the retailer cut its full-year profit guidance as second-quarter sales fell due to pricing pressure and a weak U.S. performance. Shares slid 14% in London Thursday. JD Sports cut its fiscal 2027 guidance for adjusted

pretax profit—the company's preferred metric, which strips out exceptional and other one-off items—due to underlying sales trends and a promotional backdrop in the sector. The company now expects adjusted pretax profit of between £700 million and £800 million, or \$952.5 million to \$1.09 billion, for fiscal 2027. It previously forecast adjusted

pretax profit between £750 million and £850 million, after reporting adjusted pretax profit of £852 million for the year ended Jan. 31, 2026. Analysts had forecast adjusted pretax profit of £781 million for fiscal 2027, according to the consensus provided by the company. JD Sports said group sales for its second quarter ended

Aug. 1 fell 3.1% on a like-for-like basis to £3.09 billion. On an organic basis, sales were down 1.3%. "Trading in the second quarter remained tough. The market stayed highly promotional, reflecting the consumer and footwear product cycle headwinds our industry has faced in recent quarters, whilst our core consumer was

impacted by incremental cost-of-living pressures," said Chief Executive Regis Schultz. North America sales in the second quarter were down 6.8% on a comparable basis, as incremental cost-of-living pressures hit particularly strongly in the region. The region generates around 35% of group sales. "[North America] sales per-

formance reflects weaker core consumer sentiment, a slower quarter for high-heat footwear product, and deferred 'back-to-school' demand from July into the first half of August," the company said. Sales for the U.S. were notably weaker than expected, partly due to a soft performance for retail chain Finish Line, Bernstein analysts noted.

Abbott To Pay \$670M in Settlement

By Kelly Cloonan

Abbott agreed to pay \$670 million to resolve a lawsuit over its specialty formulas for premature infants as well as about 2,000 related claims. The bulk settlement relates to the Gill lawsuit, in which a Missouri jury ordered Abbott to pay \$495 million in damages after determining the company failed to warn that its formula for preterm infants increased the risk for a bowel disease. Abbott's appeal to the 2024 verdict was denied. Abbott said it opted to enter agreements to resolve both the Gill case and other necrotizing enterocolitis claims to avoid continuing to appeal or paying about \$600 million for just the Gill case, which represents the initial judgment plus accrued interest to date. Abbott said the agreements aren't an admission of liability, and it stands by the safety of the products. Following the agreements, there are roughly 1,700 lawsuits pending in federal and state courts involving claims on behalf of about 12,700 individual infants, Abbott said.

Pop Mart Warns Of Revenue Miss

By Sherry Qin and Megan Cheah

Since the Labubu craze began, investors have wondered if the meteoric rise of **Pop Mart**, the maker of the ugly-cute dolls, was just a fad. Pop Mart's first-half earnings will do little to convince the skeptics. Top-line growth slowed sharply and Chief Executive Wang Ning warned the company will likely miss its annual target. Speaking on an earnings call Thursday, Wang said the toy company encountered more difficulties than expected in the first six months, and probably won't deliver the 20% revenue growth it hoped for this year. Revenue climbed 24% during the first half to 17.17 billion yuan, equivalent to \$2.55 billion, decelerating from the threefold increase seen a year earlier and missing expectations for a 37% rise, according to a Visible Alpha poll. Net profit rose 10% to 5.04 billion yuan, also undershooting consensus views. The results mark an acute downturn after a run of growth that sparked a rally in Pop Mart's stock, catapulting its market capitalization past \$56 billion at one point. For two years, the Beijing company was on a roll, winning the hearts of consumers

with the gremlin-like Labubu dolls. But as the hype waned, so too has market enthusiasm. Pop Mart's Hong Kong-listed shares are down nearly 20% so far this year. During 2025 and 2024, they doubled and more than quadrupled in value, respectively. Wang attributed the weaker-than-expected performance during the first half to tepid demand and difficulties stemming from geopolitical tensions. Revenue from overseas dropped 11%, weighing on gross profit margin. International sales generally offer higher margins than those in Pop Mart's home market. The Monsters collection—which includes the jagged-tooth Labubus—remained the biggest revenue contributor, accounting for about a quarter of overall sales in the first half, down from roughly one-third a year earlier. Analysts remain split on the durability of Pop Mart's business model. Deutsche Bank's Sammi Xu noted that demand for the latest generation of Labubus sporting long, styleable hair, has been much tamer than for previous iterations, while social media buzz has fizzled. If that continues, Pop Mart might need a new product format or another celebrity-endorsed character to reignite



The Monsters collection—which includes Labubu dolls—was the biggest revenue contributor.

consumer interest and the scarcity mindset that underpinned its earlier successes, the analyst said. The company is betting it can do just that with a new character, Twinkle Twinkle. Management said that the star-shaped character has been a hit with Asian customers and has huge potential. Twinkle Twinkle was Pop Mart's fastest-growing intellectual property in the first half, with sales surging over fivefold, contributing around

15% of group revenue. The company also announced a share buyback of 2 billion yuan to 5 billion yuan, which Wang said was a show of confidence in its outlook. While Pop Mart might scale down its revenue growth ambitions, the chief executive said the business is now much healthier and focused on prioritizing long-term development over sales growth. Whether Pop Mart can repeat the success of Labubu remains to be seen, but some

analysts think the company could become a Disney-esque business. "We believe Pop Mart has strong potential to become an IP powerhouse," Morningstar's Jeff Zhang said in a recent note. Concerns over slowing revenue growth and declining resale prices for Labubus have dragged on Pop Mart's valuation, but Zhang reckons investors are reading the wrong signal. "Resale prices do not reflect the underlying strength of Pop Mart's business," he said.



Shares of the home builder tumbled 7.5% on Thursday after it swung to a loss in its most recent quarter.

Weak Housing Market Hits Hovnanian

By Connor Hart

Hovnanian Enterprises continues to cope with a stagnant housing market, plagued by cautious consumers who are too anxious to buy new homes. "World events, as well as high mortgage rates, high gas prices, inflation and other factors have caused potential home buyers to hesitate," Chief Executive Ara Hovnanian said on a call with analysts Thursday. The hesitancy has forced the home builder to offer expensive incentives to spur sales, cutting into its bottom line and prompting the com-

pany to post its second consecutive quarterly loss. Contracts also declined, hurting its top line as well. Shares tumbled 7.5% to \$118.13 in Thursday's trading. Despite the drop, the stock is up 21% in the year to date. Other home builders are feeling the pressure, too. **Toll Brothers**, a luxury home builder, earlier this week reported lower sales in the latest quarter as it delivered fewer homes. And **Lennar** in June cut its full-year deliveries outlook after it similarly reported declining revenue. Hovnanian said underlying demand for housing remains strong, noting that the com-

pany's website continues to see solid traffic and that consumers continue to tour its communities. However, Hovnanian Enterprises is having a hard time converting interest into home sales. "Compared with last year's third quarter, our results continue to reflect the reality of a housing market operating under substantially higher mortgage rates, elevated incentives and concern about global instability," Hovnanian said. Quarterly contracts declined roughly 4% to 1,359 homes. The decrease in contracts weighed on revenue, which fell 12% to \$705.7 million.

The company swung to a loss of \$1.8 million for its three months ended July 31, from a profit of \$16.6 million a year earlier. On a per-share basis, the company reported a loss of 70 cents a share, compared with earnings of \$1.99 a share the year prior. While the housing market by and large is still heavily reliant on incentives to push new-home contracts, the incentives are starting to come down. Incentive levels have declined sequentially for the past two quarters, Hovnanian said, even though mortgage rates have increased over the same period.

TECHNOLOGY

Alibaba Invests Heavily In AI, Hurting Earnings

E-commerce giant continues to upgrade and integrate its Qwen model series

By Tracy Qu

Alibaba's earnings slumped in its fiscal first quarter as the Chinese e-commerce titan continued to invest heavily in artificial intelligence, racing to preserve its lead in the fast-growing sector.

The results come at a pivotal time for Alibaba, which has been sharpening its focus on AI. The company has continued to upgrade its Qwen model series and integrate it into its core ecosystem. It recently rolled out the Qwen3.8-Max, one of the largest open-source models globally.

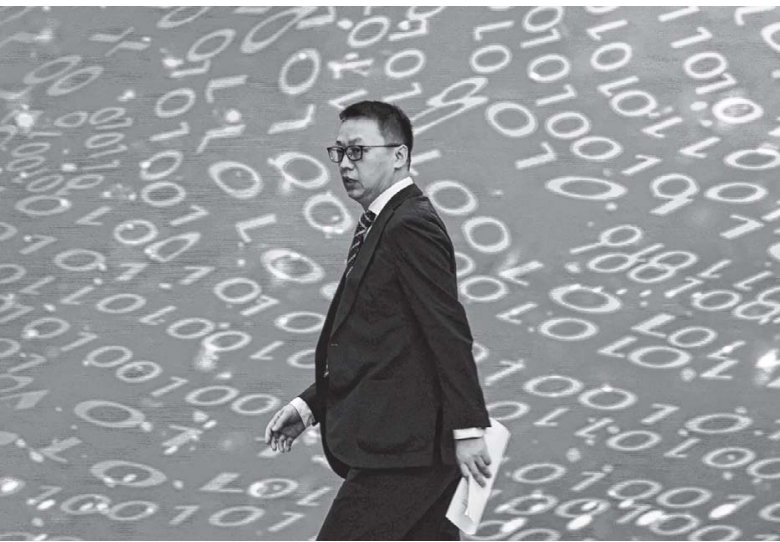
The Hangzhou, China-based company said Thursday that net profit dropped 76% to 10.54 billion yuan, equivalent to \$1.57 billion, while revenue grew about 8.6% from a year earlier to 268.95 billion yuan. Profit fell short of market expectations, though revenue beat estimates.

The company attributed the sharp drop in earnings to lower operating income, reduced net gains from the disposal of investments and other factors.

"We delivered a strong quarter, driven by the improving commercialization of our full-stack AI capabilities," Chief Executive Eddie Wu said.

Alibaba Cloud's external revenue growth accelerated to 45%, with AI-related product revenue delivering triple-digit growth for the 12th straight quarter, he said.

For the three months ended June, revenue from the company's e-commerce busi-



Alibaba, headed by CEO Eddie Wu, said the company had delivered a strong quarter.

ness rose 4%. Its AI cloud and compute services division recorded the fastest growth, with revenue jumping 45%, while AI labs and applications revenue climbed 16%.

Adjusted net profit—a metric closely watched by analysts, as it reflects core business operation profitability—fell 38% to 20.715 billion yuan. The measure excludes the effects of share-based compensation expenses, investment gains and losses, some impairments and other items.

The company said continued investments in AI infrastructure pushed capital expenditure for the quarter to 67.68 billion yuan, a 75% increase from a year earlier. The

rise was due to fluctuations in procurement cycles, increased CPU-compute capacity and higher pricing of a range of chip components, it said.

The heavy spending coincides with an intensifying AI race in China as model developers accelerate releases of ever more powerful models.

"This trend reduces the defensibility of any single model, shifting the competitive focus to the platforms and infrastructure that can seamlessly host and manage them," Citi wrote in a note.

Alibaba on Thursday said its Zhenwu chips, developed by chip arm T-Head, achieved broad commercial adoption through Alibaba Cloud ser-

vices from more than 650 external customers in industries spanning autonomous driving, internet and financial services.

As the company boosts spending on AI and e-commerce, it has in recent years pushed to make its noncore businesses profitable—or sell them—to strengthen its finances.

It reached an agreement to sell its videogame business, Lingxi Games, to Asian private-equity firm Trustar Capital, according to an internal memo The Wall Street Journal viewed this week. The deal would value the gaming studio at more than \$1.5 billion.

The company has also been battling Meituan and JD.com in the food-delivery industry, though competition has eased in recent months.

Alibaba's American depositary receipts rose 1.3% in New York after the results.

Super Micro Clears Its Top Management

By Connor Hart

Super Micro Computer completed its investigation into an alleged scheme from earlier this year in which two employees and a contractor were said to have smuggled high-end **Nvidia** chips to China.

The server maker on Thursday said a team led by independent members of its board reviewed the transactions that were the subject of a federal indictment. They didn't find evidence that any current member of Super Micro's senior management team had knowledge of the alleged diversion scheme, or of any actual diversion of restricted products.

The finding comes after Super Micro co-founder Yih Shyan "Wally" Liaw resigned from the company in March, as he was one of the people indicted for his alleged role in the scheme.

The alleged scheme—which involved billions of dollars of servers and dummy devices used to deceive an American inspector—also resulted in Super Micro placing a second employee on leave and firing a contractor.

Super Micro on Thursday said its investigation into the

matter additionally didn't find any evidence that the company directly sold export-controlled products to known restricted parties or locations, nor evidence that its previously issued financial statements can't be relied upon due to the potential diversion of restricted products.

The company said it took several personnel actions with respect to employees within its sales, technical support and business development functions, including terminations, for failure to follow company policies or the company's code of conduct.

Taking recommendations from the investigation team—which was led by Scott Angel, the company's lead independent director, and Tally Liu, chair of the board's audit committee—Super Micro said it has taken steps to further enhance its export compliance program.

"We are pleased to report the conclusion of this independent investigation," Angel said. "The independent directors support the actions the company has already taken to bolster its internal policies and procedures, as well as the additional enhancements that will be implemented."



Super Micro did its own review of an alleged smuggling scheme.

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WELLS FARGO BANK, NATIONAL ASSOCIATION, AS TRUSTEE, FOR THE BENEFIT OF THE HOLDERS OF CD 2018-CD7, MORTGAGE TRUST COMMERCIAL MORTGAGE PASS-THROUGH CERTIFICATES, SERIES 2018-CD7, acting by and through its special servicer, Rialto Capital Advisors, LLC, as Special Servicer under the Pooling and Servicing Agreement dated as of August 1, 2018, Plaintiff -against- PRINCE 26, LLC; 29 PRINCE STREET ASSOCIATES LLC, et al Defendant(s). Pursuant to that certain ORDER & JUDGMENT entered herein and dated August 5, 2026 ("Judgment"), I, the undersigned Referee will sell at public auction, at the front steps of 26 Prince Street, New York, New York 10012 on September 25, 2026, at 2:00 p.m., prevailing Eastern Time, the following Premises (to be sold as a single lot), as that term is defined below, and more particularly described and bounded as follows:

PARCEL A: ALL THAT CERTAIN plot, piece or parcel of land, situate, lying and being in the Borough of Manhattan, County of New York, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the northerly side of Prince Street, distant 27 feet 11 1/4 inches (deed), 27.94 feet (actual), easterly from the corner formed by the intersection of the northerly side of Prince Street with the easterly side of Mott Street; RUNNING THENCE northerly parallel or nearly so with the easterly side of Mott Street and part of the way through party walls, 83 feet 11 inches (deed), 82.54 feet (actual); THENCE easterly 26 feet 9 and 6/10 inches (deed), 24.40 feet (actual), to a point on a line distant 86 feet and 1 inch (deed), 86.08 feet (actual), northerly from the northerly side of Prince Street which line is parallel or nearly so with the easterly side of Mott Street and intersects the northerly side of Prince Street at a point 54 feet 7 1/4 inches (deed), 55.61 feet (actual), when measured in an easterly direction from the corner formed by the intersection of the northerly side of Prince Street with the easterly side of Mott Street; THENCE southerly and along said line drawn parallel or nearly so with Mott Street and part of the way through a party wall, 86 feet 1 inch (deed), 86.08 feet (actual), to the northerly side of Prince Street; THENCE westerly along the northerly side of Prince Street, 26 feet 9 and 6/10 inches (deed) 27.67 feet (actual), to the point or place of BEGINNING. Block: 508 Lot: 52.

Said premises to be sold is known as 29 PRINCE STREET, NEW YORK, NEW YORK 10012 ("Parcel A").

PARCEL B: ALL THAT CERTAIN plot, piece or parcel of land, situate, lying and being in the Borough of Manhattan, County of New York, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the Westerly side of Thompson Street, distant 169 feet 6 inches Northerly from the intersection of said Westerly side of Thompson Street and the Northerly side of Prince Street; RUNNING THENCE Westerly parallel with Prince Street, 100 feet; THENCE Northerly parallel with Thompson Street, 24 feet 8 inches; THENCE Easterly parallel with Prince Street and part of the distance through a party wall, 100 feet to the Westerly side of Thompson Street; THENCE Southerly along the Westerly side of Thompson Street, 24 feet 8 inches to the point or place of BEGINNING. Block: 517 Lot: 31.

Said premises to be sold is known as 137 THOMPSON STREET a/k/a 135-137 THOMPSON STREET, NEW YORK, NEW YORK 10012 ("Parcel B").

PARCEL C: ALL THAT CERTAIN plot, piece or parcel of land, situate, lying and being in the Borough of Manhattan, County of New York, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the southerly side of Prince Street, distant 47 feet 6 inches easterly from the corner formed by its intersection of the southerly side of Prince Street and the easterly side of Mott Street; RUNNING THENCE southerly and parallel with the easterly side of Mott Street a distance of 114 feet 7 inches to a point; THENCE easterly along the line forming on its northerly side an angle of 88 degrees 04 minutes 30 seconds with the last mentioned course a distance of 23 feet 1 inch to a point; THENCE northerly along a line forming on its westerly side an angle of 91 degrees 55 minutes 30 seconds with the last mentioned course a distance of 109 feet to a point on the southerly side of Prince Street which point is distant 24 feet easterly from the point or place of beginning; THENCE westerly along the southerly side of Prince Street a distance of 24 feet (record), 23 feet 7 inches (survey) to the point or place of BEGINNING. Block: 493 Lot: 15. Said premises to be sold is known as 26 PRINCE STREET, NEW YORK, NEW YORK 10012 ("Parcel C"). (With Parcel A, Parcel B, and Parcel C, collectively, being the "Premises").

Pursuant to Judgment, Premises will be sold a single lot and is not to be divided or sold separately. The approximate amount of the Judgment for Premises, collectively, is \$46,677,820.90 plus interest & costs.

Premises will be sold subject to provisions of filed Judgment and forthcoming terms of sale.

Civil Action File No. 22-cv-05586 (PAE) (OTW)

STEPHEN F. ELLMAN, ESQ., Referee

MATTHEW MANNION, from Mannion Auctions, LLC as Auctioneer

Holland & Knight, LLP

Attorney(s) for Plaintiff

787 Seventh Avenue, 31st Floor,

New York, New York 10019

BANKRUPTCIES

Bankruptcy Sale Notice
Embolec Acceleration, LLC ("Debtor"), as debtor-in-possession in Bankr. Case. No. 826-bk-01712-1ER (M.D. Fla.) gives notice of a proposed sale of substantially all of its assets, including all intellectual property and trademarks for a sum of \$1,500,000.00 to BlackSwan Vascular, Inc. (the "Sale") and deadline for any person or entity claiming an interest or license in the Debtor's intellectual property (including trademarks) to assert such a claim and to make a 365(n) election ("365(n) Deadline"). Any objection to the Sale must be filed with the United States Bankruptcy Court for the Middle District of Florida, Tampa Division by September 7, 2026 at 5:00 pm. The 365(n) Deadline is September 7, 2026 at 5:00 pm. The Court will conduct a hearing on the Sale on September 9, 2026 at 11:00 am. For copies of all relevant documents, contact Adam Gilbert (agilbert@underwoodmurray.com).

COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE

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Jeffrey Ferenz, Managing Director,
Call: 602-989-0923

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Flight Attendants Fight Google Bid for Spirit Data

By Alexander Gladstone

A bankruptcy court delayed approval of Google's \$10 million purchase of Spirit Airlines' data after former flight attendants objected, warning that the deal could violate worker privacy to feed artificial intelligence models.

A labor union representing thousands of former Spirit flight attendants asked the court to decline the transaction unless the agreement expressly provides that all confidential flight-attendant information is excluded from the sale or at least receives the same protection as consumer information, according to an objection filed with the U.S. Bankruptcy Court in Manhattan on Tuesday.

Alphabet's Google last week won the auction of Spirit's digital archives that include decades of payroll, travel and recruiting files, along with about 100 million emails, 80,000 email accounts and millions of additional digital items. Google said it plans to use the data to improve its products and AI models, and that personal customer information wouldn't be included in the purchase.

The flight attendants' asso-

ciation said in its objection that while customer data might be protected, the deal lacks adequate safeguards to protect information about attendants who worked for the defunct airline.

"We will not receive any personal information from this data set," said a Google spokesperson. "Any data we receive will be rigorously scrubbed of any personally identifiable information by a third party before receipt."

Spirit said it is "engaging a third party to identify the data and certify that the data sold at auction is compliant with applicable privacy laws and regulations."

Judge Sean Lane, who is overseeing the bankruptcy case, postponed the sale hearing to Sept. 9 to give the court time to evaluate the claims.

The sale agreement between Google and Spirit mandates that the data be "deidentified" to remove elements that would link the information to a consumer or otherwise be consid-

ered personal data.

The union countered that "deidentification addresses whether a record can be traced to a named individual. It does not address whether the contents of the record are confidential."

The union said there is an asymmetry in how the transaction treats customer information versus employee information. While customer profiles, email addresses, loyalty data and chat sessions were largely "not included," nearly every category tied to former employees, including time card information, payroll records, tax forms and business travel records, is part of the sale, it said.

"The privacy architecture of this transaction is consumer-facing; its payload is disproportionately employee-facing," the flight-attendant association said in the objection.

Alexander Gladstone writes for WSJ Pro Bankruptcy.



Google won an auction of Spirit's digital archives that include payroll, travel and other files.



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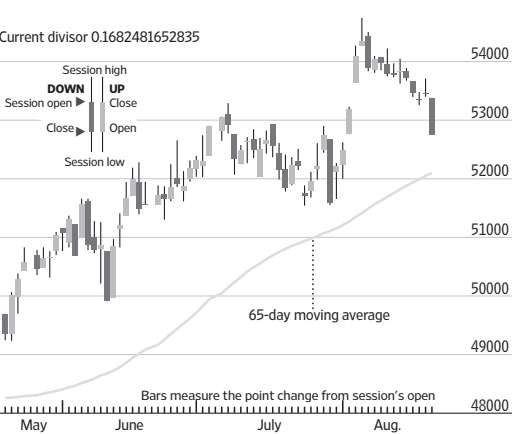


MARKETS DIGEST

EQUITIES

Dow Jones Industrial Average

52759.21 ▼703.84, or 1.32%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.



*Weekly P/E data based on as-reported earnings from Biriiny Associates Inc; *Based on Nasdaq-100 Index

Major U.S. Stock-Market Indexes

	High	Low	Latest Close	Net chg	% chg	High	52-Week Low	% chg	YTD	3-yr. ann.
Dow Jones										
Industrial Average	53381.22	52754.90	52759.21	-703.84	-1.32	54349.12	44785.50	17.8	9.8	15.2
Transportation Avg	21592.07	21272.59	21382.25	-78.59	-0.37	23933.14	15067.87	37.2	23.2	10.8
Utility Average	1114.74	1103.21	1103.50	-6.37	-0.57	1190.23	1048.33	0.1	3.3	7.9
Total Stock Market	76272.34	75678.23	75692.75	-688.24	-0.90	77313.23	62750.36	20.2	12.1	20.2
Barron's 400	1657.82	1647.37	1648.47	-12.68	-0.76	1685.46	1318.70	22.5	16.7	18.8

Nasdaq Stock Market										
Nasdaq Composite	26263.47	26023.12	26067.17	-263.92	-1.00	27093.90	20794.64	23.5	12.2	25.2
Nasdaq-100	29378.81	29118.07	29213.16	-212.86	-0.72	30660.60	22953.38	26.2	15.7	25.7

S&P										
500 Index	7699.96	7639.01	7641.16	-66.82	-0.87	7798.99	6343.72	20.0	11.6	20.5
MidCap 400	3844.40	3810.64	3810.89	-33.10	-0.86	3926.98	3109.89	20.3	15.3	13.9
SmallCap 600	1791.75	1777.07	1777.69	-19.53	-1.09	1828.54	1364.94	27.9	21.1	14.0

Other Indexes										
Russell 2000	3019.30	2989.22	2992.43	-40.51	-1.34	3068.42	2274.10	31.6	20.6	17.2
NYSE Composite	24753.26	24548.26	24548.26	-159.01	-0.64	24821.68	20818.60	17.9	11.6	15.9
Value Line	694.09	687.34	687.34	-6.75	-0.97	702.60	590.50	11.8	9.4	7.1
NYSE Arca Biotech	9461.62	9310.48	9328.65	-132.97	-1.41	9461.62	5936.96	55.2	30.4	21.8
NYSE Arca Pharma	1315.38	1287.58	1287.79	-27.59	-2.10	1315.38	925.18	35.5	14.4	12.1
KBW Bank	187.81	184.15	184.15	-3.50	-1.86	193.91	143.23	28.4	12.2	31.1
PHLX [®] Gold/Silver	409.38	397.21	408.95	9.93		470.37	234.99	74.0	19.5	54.1
PHLX [®] Oil Service	105.55	103.40	103.81	-0.35	-0.33	109.24	60.27	69.3	41.6	4.1
PHLX [®] Semiconductor	11863.72	11649.47	11800.02	61.79		14634.72	5592.82	110.6	66.6	50.5
Choe Volatility	16.14	14.91	16.01	1.12		31.05	13.47	-3.6	7.1	-2.6

[®]Nasdaq PHLX Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

Percentage Gainers...

Company	Symbol	Close	Net chg	% chg	High	Low	% chg
PicoCELA ADR	PCLA	8.49	2.09	32.66	19.61	1.35	-38.4
Wetour Robotics	WETO	27.53	6.77	32.59	251.00	2.70	-85.6
ARB IOT Group	ARBB	5.30	1.29	32.17	13.89	3.71	26.8
ProShares Ultra XRP ETF	UXRP	13.09	3.15	31.69	188.10	8.67	-92.6
Volatility Shr Tr XRP 2X	XRPT	28.75	6.86	31.34	400.40	18.96	-92.4
GrShr 2x Long MARA Daily	MRAL	38.40	9.06	30.86	366.30	22.14	-78.3
Teucrium 2x Long Dly XRP	XXRP	27.02	6.17	29.59	421.70	17.91	-93.2
StablecoinX	USDE	4.00	0.91	29.45	15.11	1.01	-71.0
Xos	XOS	3.72	0.82	28.28	8.27	1.60	24.0
Wing Yip Food ADR	WYHG	5.71	1.10	23.86	26.17	1.56	-4.8
MindForge	MF	18.11	3.31	22.36	103.00	2.12	-81.4
IP Strategy Holdings	IPST	10.31	1.86	22.01	532.00	1.54	-94.5
Direxion Dly Ether Bull	EVMU	27.81	4.85	21.12	28.20	13.19	...
ProShares Ultra Ether ETF	ETHT	15.20	2.63	20.92	131.74	7.07	-85.8
Next Technology Holding	NXTT	8.00	1.36	20.48	27200.00	5.22	-99.97

Volume Movers

Company	Symbol	Volume (000)	% chg from 65-day avg	Latest Session Close	% chg	52-Week High	Low
Next Technology Holding	NXTT	4,356	9898	8.00	20.48	27200.00	5.22
Fidelity CLO ETF	FCLO	350	4584	50.40	0.09	50.45	49.72
Twin Oak Shrt Horizon Abs	TOAK	345	2603	28.99	0.02	29.36	27.95
Defiance Tgt 2X Lg MRNA	MRNX	1,888	2304	74.31	-47.54	143.84	14.95
GS Corp Bond ETF	GIGL	559	2142	49.53	-0.39	51.97	49.40
iShares Govt/Credit Bond	GBF	203	1944	102.13	-0.28	106.43	101.85
Curanex Pharmaceuticals	CURX	108	1669	5.27	-2.55	183.59	3.58
GS Small Cap Eq ETF	GSC	238	1623	66.12	-1.49	69.87	50.70
Yields for You Incm A	YFYA	350	1421	9.81	0.10	10.27	9.30
NFT	MI	272	1314	7.23	5.09	536.00	6.42

* Common stocks priced at \$2 a share or more with an average volume over 65 trading days of at least 5,000 shares *Has traded fewer than 65 days

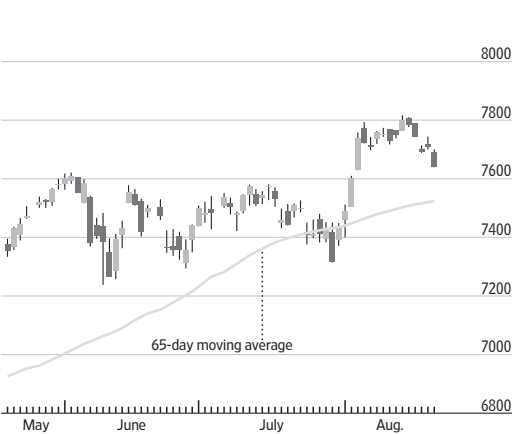
International Stock Indexes

Region/Country	Index	Close	Net chg	Latest % chg	YTD % chg
World	MSCI ACWI	1143.50	-3.24	-0.28	12.7
	MSCI ACWI ex-USA	483.15	3.71	0.77	14.8
	MSCI World	4947.36	-28.17	-0.57	11.7
	MSCI Emerging Markets	1699.97	31.59	1.89	21.0
Americas	MSCI AC Americas	2895.45	-24.114	-0.83	11.6
	S&P/TSX Comp	36365.42	-36.37	-0.10	14.7
	MSCI EM Latin America	2961.39	-2.28	-0.08	9.3
	Bovespa	167927.15	96.88	0.06	4.2
Europe	STOXX Europe 600	650.35	-0.81	-0.12	9.8
	Euro STOXX	675.55	-1.54	-0.23	10.3
	Bel-20	5743.62	-4.27	-0.07	13.1
	OMX Copenhagen 20	1618.66	-0.05	-0.003	0.7
Asia-Pacific	S&P/ASX 200	9083.80	30.03	0.33	4.2
	Shanghai Composite	3903.72	9.30	0.24	-1.6
	Hang Seng	25698.49	203.42	0.80	0.3
	BSE Sensex	77537.72	628.04	0.82	-9.0
Other	NIKKEI 225	66216.79	890.37	1.36	31.5
	Straits Times	5671.91	-22.33	-0.39	22.1
	KOSPI	6852.58	381.41	5.89	62.6
	TAIEX	44933.74	214.39	0.48	55.1
Global	SET	1609.99	0.23	0.01	27.8

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

S&P 500 Index

7641.16 ▼66.82, or 0.87%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.



Late Trading

Most-active and biggest movers among NYSE, NYSE Arca, NYSE Amer. and Nasdaq issues from 4 p.m. to 6 p.m. ET as reported by electronic trading services, securities dealers and regional exchanges. Minimum share price of \$2 and minimum after-hours volume of 50,000 shares.

Most-active issues in late trading

Company	Symbol	Volume (000)	Last	Net chg	After-Hours % chg	High	Low
NVIDIA	NVDA	15,355.8	217.06	0.21	0.10	230.38	203.24
IREN	IREN	10,078.3	42.58	-0.02	-0.05	42.95	42.44
Apple	AAPL	7,386.5	311.95	0.65	0.21	312.15	291.00
Nu Holdings Cl A	NU	7,370.7	14.23	0.02	0.14	14.26	14.17
Intel	INTC	6,711.8	92.03	-0.10	-0.11	92.33	90.41
State Street SPDR S&P 500	SPY	5,318.9	763.17	0.57	0.08	763.20	710.85
Coupage	CPNG	5,297.4	16.29	0.03	0.18	16.32	16.16
NIO ADR	NIO	4,631.5	4.55	0.02	0.43	4.55	4.53

Percentage gainers...

RF Acquisition II	RFAI	71.5	80.98	68.25	536.14	90.00	13.15
Ross Stores	ROST	1,245.1	247.20	18.21	7.95	248.00	228.99
Teucrium 2x Long Dly XRP	XXRP	57.3	28.67	1.65	6.09	28.95	27.00
Kura Oncology	KURA	109.2	12.26	0.55	4.70	12.27	11.71
Bitwise XRP ETF	XRP	62.1	14.20	0.41	2.97	14.34	13.77
...And losers							
OSI Systems	OSIS	78.3	188.20	-29.89	-13.71	224.68	187.01
Aveanna Healthcare	AVAH	144.1	11.79	-1.18	-9.10	13.00	11.70
Flowers Foods	FLO	998.1	6.76	-0.34	-4.79	7.53	6.52
Myriad Genetics	MYGN	227.5	3.15	-0.07	-2.17	3.22	3.15
Brookdale Senior Living	BKD	106.7	11.56	-0.25	-2.10	11.96	11.56

Percentage Losers

First Breach	FBDT	4.15	-10.85	-72.33	15.00	2.81	...
Defiance Tgt 2X Lg MRNA	MRNX	74.31	-67.33	-47.54	143.84	14.95	...
Profsa	PFSA	7.57	-6.00	-44.22	5190.00	3.22	-99.8
CDT Envlt Tech Invst	CDTG	1.83	-1.18	-39.20	53.25	0.73	-87.2
Tenon Medical	TNOM	7.07	-4.34	-38.04	54.95	4.38	-86.2
Onfolio	ONFO	1.57	-0.80	-33.76	123.92	1.49	-96.9
Advance Auto Parts	AAP	42.39	-13.79	-24.55	65.21	37.89	-25.1
Rising Dragon Acquisition	RDAC	6.65	-2.13	-24.26	23.99	4.59	-35.8
Moderna	MRNA	133.32	-41.06	-23.55	176.66	22.28	-395.8
YieldMax MRNA Opt Incm	MRNY	32.00	-9.77	-23.40	42.39	13.60	67.5
Hennessy Cap Inv VII	HVII	8.18	-2.35	-22.28	10.99	8.09	-19.4
ProSh UltSh Ether ETF	ETHD	35.50	-10.12	-22.18	106.80	27.60	-10.6
Exyn Technologies	EXYN	1.58	-0.44	-21.78	7.20	1.50	...
China SXT Pharm	SXTC	3.63	-0.91	-20.04	83758.79	3.10	-99.98
Digital Brands Group	DBGI	9.50	-2.35	-19.83	720.00	7.46	-97.9

CURRENCIES & COMMODITIES

Currencies

U.S.-dollar foreign-exchange rates at 5 p.m. ET

US\$				US\$			
Country/currency	Thurs in US\$	Thurs per US\$	YTD chg (%)	Country/currency	Thurs in US\$	Thurs per US\$	YTD chg (%)
Americas				Vietnam dong			
Argentina peso	.00071497	2557	3.2		.00003831	26102	-0.8
Brazil real	.1924	5.1973	-5.8	Europe			
Canada dollar	.7252	1.3790	0.5	Czech Rep. koruna	.04839	20.664	0.4
Chile peso	.001084	922.34	2.5	Denmark krone	.1562	6.4012	0.6
Colombia peso	.000325	3077.25	-18.4	Euro area euro	1.1679	8.563	0.6
Ecuador US dollar	1	1	unch	Hungary forint	.003202	312.29	-4.6
Mexico peso	.0590	16.9556	-5.8	Iceland krona	.008224	121.66	-3.0
Uruguay peso	.02493	40.1052	2.7	Norway krone	.1070	9.4286	-7.3
Asia-Pacific				Poland zloty	.2704	3.6981	3.0
Australia dollar	.7112	1.4061	-6.2	Sweden krona	.1054	9.4888	3.0
China yuan	.1487	6.7242	-3.9	Switzerland franc	1.2494	8.004	1.0
Hong Kong dollar	.1275	7.8436	-0.8	Turkey lira	.0208	47.9967	11.7
India rupee	.01044	95.778	6.6	Ukraine hryvnia	.0224	44.650	5.4
Indonesia rupiah	.0000562	17783	6.5	UK pound	1.3630	.7337	-1.1
Japan yen	.006287	159.06	1.5	Middle East/Africa			
Kazakhstan tenge	.002190	456.72	-10.0	Bahrain dinar	2.6525	.3770	0.01
Macau pataca	.1238	8.0805	0.7	Egypt pound	.0197	50.807	-5.8
Malaysia ringgit	.2472	4.0455	-0.3	Israel shekel	.3331	3.0021	6.6
New Zealand dollar	.5942	1.6829	-3.1	Kuwait dinar	2.3435	.3083	0.2
Pakistan rupee	.00360	272.56	-0.9	Oman sul rial	2.5995	.3847	-0.02
Philippines peso	.0616	61.749	-4.8	Qatar riyal	.2741	3.68	-0.2
Singapore dollar	.7860	1.2723	-1.0	Saudi Arabia riyal	.2663	3.7554	0.1
South Korea won	.0007171	1394.47	-3.2	South Africa rand	.0620	16.1264	-2.6
Sri Lanka rupee	.003288	330.16	6.5	Close Net Chg % Chg YTD chg (%)			
Taiwan dollar	.03137	31.873	1.7	WSJ Dollar index 95.46 0.12 0.12 -0.45			
Thailand baht	.03042	32.870	4.3	Sources: Tullett Prebun, Dow Jones Market Data			

Futures Contracts

Metal & Petroleum Futures						
	Open	High	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Copper-High (CMX) -25,000 lbs.; \$ per lb.						
Aug	6.4060	6.4615	6.4060	6.4600	-0.0275	1,948
Dec	6.6085	6.6160	6.5045	6.5695	-0.0260	128,277
Gold (CMX) -100 Troy oz.; \$ per Troy oz.						
Aug	4506.80	4530.00	4486.00	4516.30	26.90	374
Sept	4530.50	4545.10	4456.20	4520.70	25.60	4,414
Oct	4547.20	4562.30	4472.50	4537.10	25.80	53,910
Nov	4566.70	4579.60	4495.40	4555.20	26.10	629
Dec	4580.00	4597.10	4506.00	4571.40	26.10	326,214
Jan'27	4568.00	4569.30	4549.90	4591.00	25.90	461
Palladium (NYM) -50 Troy oz.; \$ per Troy oz.						
Aug	1370.00	1378.00	▲ 1363.50	1336.30	4.40	
Sept	1332.50	1347.50	1315.00	1338.40	4.20	9,364
Platinum (NYM) -50 Troy oz.; \$ per Troy oz.						
Aug	1612.10	1632.90	▼ 1612.10	1831.00	28.40	66
Oct	1834.40	1849.10	1792.60	1839.10	28.60	49,812
Silver (CMX) -5,000 Troy oz.; \$ per Troy oz.						
Aug	66.850	68.950	66.850	68.026	2.292	23
Dec	67.900	69.815	66.510	68.882	2.316	56,751
Crude Oil, Light Sweet (NYM) -60,000 bbls.; \$ per bbl						
Sept	85.80	89.00	85.60	87.83	2.00	13,648
Oct	84.40	87.69	84.23	86.83	2.44	287,051
Nov	82.93	85.46	82.50	84.86	2.05	160,866
Dec	81.04	83.17	80.61	82.67	1.60	209,341
June'27	74.17	75.28	73.82	75.08	0.79	137,251
Dec	71.53	72.45	71.26	72.23	0.57	155,489
NY Harbor ULSD (NYM) -42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.						
Sept	4.4399	4.5097	4.4103	4.4803	0.0280	34,418
Oct	4.3155	4.3884	▲ 4.2883	4.3735	0.0508	61,854
Gasoline NY RBOB (NYM) -42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.						
Sept	3.2050	3.2875	3.1937	3.2629	0.0078	42,058
Oct	2.9422	3.0225	2.9374	3.0091	0.0316	86,430
Natural Gas (NYM) -10,000 MMBtu.; \$ per MMBtu.						
Sept	2.781	2.804	2.711	2.733	-0.081	97,106
Oct	2.790	2.811	2.739	2.760	-0.066	269,204
Nov	2.962	2.987	2.908	2.925	-0.077	219,642
Dec	3.513	3.537	▼ 3.465	3.470	-0.084	156,343
Jan'27	3.925	3.945	▼ 3.863	3.878	-0.080	168,766
March	2.911	2.924	▼ 2.872	2.883	-0.054	144,400

Agriculture Futures						
	Open	High	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Corn (CBT) -5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Sept	472.75	481.25	472.25	478.75	5.75	235,924
Dec	498.00	506.25	497.25	503.50	5.50	925,396
Oats (CBT) -5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Sept	330.75	330.75	320.75	322.25	-9.25	304
Dec	347.50	348.75	340.75	342.50	-7.00	2,320
Soybeans (CBT) -5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Sept	1221.00	1228.25	1218.50	1220.75	-1.50	47,699
Nov	1236.50	1244.50	1234.50	1236.50	-7.5	483,250
Soybean Meal (CBT) -100 tons; \$ per ton.						
Sept	318.90	322.10	314.90	315.70	-3.20	63,885
Dec	325.90	328.80	323.10	323.80	-1.80	271,317
Soybean Oil (CBT) -60,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Sept	69.95	71.29	69.56	71.18	1.32	82,637

Cash Prices | [wsj.com/market-data/commodities](#)

These prices reflect buying and selling of a variety of actual or "physical" commodities in the marketplace—separate from the futures price on an exchange, which reflects what the commodity might be worth in future months.

Thursday			Thursday			Thursday		
Energy						Food		
Coal,CAPlc,12500Btu,125O2-r,w	81.000		BMI Lithium Carbonate, EXW China, ~95%-v,w	22150		Beef,carcass equiv, index		
Coal,PwdrRvrBsn,8800Btu,0.85O2-r,w	14.550		BMI Lithium Hydroxide, EXW China, ~56%-v,w	19975		select 1-3,600-900 lbs.-u	358.50	
Metals			BMI Cobalt sulphate, EXW China, >20.5%-v,w	11100		select 1-3,600-900 lbs.-u	335.88	
			BMI Nickel Sulphate, EXW China, ~22%-v,k	4433		Broilers, National comp wtd. avg.-w	1.1775	
			BMI Flake Graphite, FOB China, ~100 Mesh, 94.95%-v,m	425		Butter, AA Chicago-d	1.4300	
			Fibers and Textiles					
Gold, per troy oz			Burlap,10-oz,40-inch NY-yd-n,w	1.2500		Cheddar cheese,bbl,Chicago-d	156.50	
Engelhard industrial	4490.00		Cotton,11/16 std lw-mdMphs-u	0.8327		Cheddar cheese,blk,Chicago-d	152.25	
Krugerrand,wholesale-e	4724.60		Lookout "A" Index-t	*95.90		Milk,Nonfat dry,Chicago lb.-d	183.00	
Maple Leaf-e	4837.63		Hides,hvy native steers piece fob-u	n.a.		Coffee,Brazilian,Comp-y	3.3275	
American Eagle-e	4837.63		Wool,64s,staple,Terr del-u,w	n.a.		Coffee,Columbian, NY-y	3.6654	
Mexican peso-e	5832.73					Eggs,large white,Chicago-u,w	1.0150	
Austria crown-e	4434.63					Flour,hard winter KC-p	19.45	
Austria phil-e	4747.21					Hams,17-20 lbs,Mid-US fob-u	n.a.	
Silver, troy oz.						Hogs,Iowa-So. Minnesota-u	89.27	
Engelhard industrial	67.8000		Corn,wheat middlings, KC-u,w	100		Pork bellies,12-14 lb MidUS-u	1.9864	
Handy & Harman base	68.3450		Bran,No. 2,yellow, Cent IL-bp,u	4.6400		Steers,13-19 lb MidUS-u	1.1311	
Handy & Harman fabricated	85.4310		Cottonseed meal-u,w	320		Pork loins,Tex.-Okla. Choice-u	n.a.	
Coins,wholesale \$1,000 face-a	48819		Hominy feed, Cent IL-u,w	120		Steers,feeder,Okla. City-u,w	393.50	
Other metals			Meat-bonemeal,50% pro Mnpls-u,w	3.8225				
Platinum,Engelhard industrial	1820.00		Oats,No.2 milling,Mnpls-u	4.2625				
Palladium,Engelhard industrial	1347.00		Rice, Long Grain,Milled, No. 2 AR-u,w	28.63				
Aluminum,LME, \$ per metric ton	*3191.5		Soybean Meal, Cent L,Latrol,48%-u,w	319.90				
Copper,Comex spot	6.4600		Soybeans,No.1 yllw IL-bp,u	12.2900				
Iron Ore, 62% Fe CFR China-s	*96.0		Wheat,Spring,14-16% pro Mnpls-u	8.5075				
Steel, HRC USA, FOB Midwest Mill-s	*1200.0		Wheat-No.2 soft red,TxLouis-u	6.4025				
Battery/EV metals			Wheat- Hard - KC (USDA) \$ per bu-u	7.4525				
			Wheat-No.1soft white,Portld,OR-u	6.5500				

KEY TO CODES: A=ask; B=bid; BP=country elevator bids to producers; C=corrected; D=CME; E=Manfra,Tordella & Brookes; H=American Commodities Brokerage Co; K=biweekly; M=monthly; N=nominal; n.a.=not quoted or not available; P=Seoland Publishing; R=SNL Energy; S=Platts-TSI; T=Cotlook Limited; U=USDA; V=Benchmark Mineral Intelligence; W=weekly; Y=International Coffee Organization; Z=not quoted. *Data as of 8/19

Source: Dow Jones Market Data

Exchange-Traded Portfolios | [wsj.com/market-data/mutualfunds-etfs](#)

Largest 100 exchange-traded funds, latest session									
Thursday, August 20, 2026									
ETF	Symbol	Closing Price	Chg (%)	YTD (%)	ETF	Symbol	Closing Price	Chg (%)	YTD (%)
AvantissUS\$CValue	AVUV	125.62	-0.67	23.2	iShRuss1000	IWB	417.90	-0.82	11.9
CapGrpDivVal	CGDV	49.40	-0.79	14.4	iShRuss1000Grw	IWF	121.82	-0.69	3.0
DimenUSCoreEq2	DFAC	45.94	-0.81	14.7	iShRuss2000Val	IWD	256.17	-1.00	21.8
FidTotalBd	FBND	44.95	-0.33	-2.4	iShRuss2000Grw	IWM	297.67	-1.34	20.9
ImvsNasdt00	QQQM	292.79	-0.70	15.8	iShS&P500Val	IVE	138.37	-0.49	12.3
ImvsQQQ	QQQ	710.93	-0.72	15.7	iShS&P500Value	IYW	236.10	-0.99	11.3
ImvsS&P500EW	RSP	220.28	-0.81	15.0	iShSemiconduct	SOXX	522.35	0.52	73.5
iShBtltn	IBIT	41.20	6.24	17.0	iSh7-10YTreaBd	IEF	93.00	-0.41	-3.3
iShBrtUSDHYCPbd	DSHO	30.00	-0.19	-1.6	iShSilver	SLV	61.66	2.75	-4.3
iShCoreDivGrowth	DGRO	79.25	-0.99	14.2	iSh20+YTreaBd	TLT	82.34	-0.82	-5.5
iShCoreMSCIEAFE	IEFA	99.99	-0.47	11.8	iShNOSEqFacRotat	DYFN	68.86	-0.79	13.2
iShCoreMSCIEM	IEMG	81.85	0.60	20.6	iShUSTreasuryBd	GOWT	22.48	-0.27	-2.4
iShMSCIMtDev	IDEV	92.55	-0.24	12.2	iShO-3MTTreaBd	SGOV	100.59	--	0.2
iShCoreMSCITotInt	IXUS	97.20	0.04	14.9	JPMNasdEqPrem	JEPQ	59.66	-0.35	2.6
iShCoreS&P500	IUV	766.34	-0.83	11.9	JanusAAACLO	JAAA	50.65	0.04	0.1
iShCoreS&P Micro	LIV	76.37	-0.87	15.7	JPMEEqPremInclmcme	JEPI	57.72	-0.41	0.8
iShCoreS&P S&T	LJR	146.37	-1.05	21.8	JPM UtlShimcn	JPST	50.52	--	-0.1
iShCoreS&P S&TUSVal	ITOT	167.20	-0.90	12.4	ProShUtlPrqQQ	TQQQ	70.48	-2.19	33.7
iShCoreS&PUSGrw	IUSG	189.21	-0.73	12.7	SPDRGoldMini	GLDM	89.59	0.34	4.9
iShCoreS&PUSVal	IUSV	114.30	-1.05	11.5	SPDR Gold	GLD	415.26	0.34	4.8
iShCoreUSAggBd	AGG	97.49	-0.34	-2.4	SchwabIntlEquity	SCHI	28.22	0.04	17.4
iShCoreUnivUSD Bd	USDB	45.91	-0.31	-2.2	SchwabUS BrdMkt	SCHB	29.47	-0.87	12.4
iShEdgeMSCIUSAQual	QUAL	222.30	-0.91	11.9	SchwabUS Div	SCHD	34.83	-0.74	27.0
iShGoldTr	IAU	85.13	0.34	4.9	SchwabUS LC	SCHX	30.08	-0.82	11.8
iShBoxxIGCpBd	LQD	106.06	-0.48	-3.7	SchwabUS LC Grw	SCHG	35.10	-1.02	7.6
iShMBS	MBB	93.30	-0.29	-2.0	SEEnergySel	XLE	63.75	0.27	42.6
iShMSCIACWI	ACWI	159.97	-0.45	13.1	SSFInlSbl	XLFI	56.95	-0.92	4.0
iShMSCIEAFE	EFA	107.35	-0.29	11.8	SSHltHCrSel	XLV	172.39	-1.87	11.4
iShMSCIEM	EEM	66.62	0.77	21.8	SSIndlSel	XLI	179.77	-1.20	15.9
iShMSCIEAFEVal	EFV	81.42	-0.12	14.0	SSSPDRBbg1-3M	BIL	91.57	--	0.2
iShNatImUniBd	MUB	105.47	-0.20	-1.5	SSSPDR DJIA	DIA	527.51	-1.27	9.8
iShRussMC	IWR	112.65	-0.84	17.0	SSSPDRDexvUS	SPDW	51.61	-0.04	16.2
					SSSPDRS&P500	SPYM	89.78	-0.84	11.9
					SSSPDRS&P500G	SPVY	63.22	-1.02	11.1
					SSIMSPDRS&P500	SPY	762.60	-0.84	11.1
					STSTechSel	XLK	183.10	-0.29	27.7
					VanEckSemicon	SMH	562.65	0.31	
					VangDivdPerm	VIG	242.23	-1.13	10.0
					VangExtMkt	VXF	243.54	-1.21	16.0
					VangFTSEAWJUS	VEU	84.99	0.04	15.0
					VangFTSEdEvMk	VWA	72.84	0.01	16.0
					VangFTSEEM	VEO	60.02	-0.03	11.1
					VangFTSEEurope	VGM	92.01	-0.24	10.0
					VangHLDiv	VMK	164.04	-0.81	14.0
					VangInfoTech	VIG	118.36	-0.37	25.0
					VangInternrBd	BIV	75.52	-0.34	-3.1
					VangIntnrCorpBd	VCIT	81.10	-0.39	-3.1
					VangInternrTrea	VUT	58.39	-0.26	-2.0
					VangMstarGrw	VUG	87.17	-0.86	7.7
					VangMstarLC	VV	351.34	-0.79	11.1
					VangMstarMegaGr	MKG	88.61	-0.87	7.7
					VangMstarMk	VOT	302.83	-0.65	13.0
					VangMstarVb	VBR	276.49	-1.02	12.2
					VangMstarVtVal	VBR	247.49	-1.06	16.0
					VangMstarTot	VTV	376.50	-0.90	12.0
					VangMstarTot	VTV	225.19	-0.78	17.7
					VangRealEst	VNQ	68.40	-0.01	11.1
					VangRuss1000Grw	VONG	125.52	-0.61	3.0
					VangRuss&P500ETF	VWO	70.01	-0.83	11.1
					VangST Bond	BSV	77.62	-0.08	-1.1
					VangSTCpBd	VCSH	76.61	-0.10	-1.1
					VangShortTrea	VGSH	58.14	-0.03	-1.1
					VangTExpmtBd	VTEB	49.57	-0.18	-1.1
					VangTotalBd	BND	72.34	-0.30	-2.1
					VangTotalIntlBd	BNDX	47.65	-0.19	-1.1
					VangTotalInttStk	VXUS	87.03	0.07	15.0
					VangTotWrldStk	VW	159.93	-0.48	13.0

Borrowing Benchmarks | [wsj.com/market-data/bonds/benchmarks](#)

Money Rates

Key annual interest rates paid to borrow or lend money in U.S. and international markets. Rates below are a guide to general levels but don't always represent actual transactions.

Inflation				
	July index level	Chg From (%) June '26	July '25	
U.S. consumer price index				
All items	333.918	-0.01	3.4	
Core	337.133	0.07	2.5	
International rates				
	Latest	Week ago	-52-Week-High	-52-Week-Low
Prime rates				
U.S.	6.75	6.75	7.50	6.75
Canada	4.45	4.45	4.95	4.45
Japan	2.375	2.125	2.375	1.875
Policy Rates				
Euro zone	2.40	2.40	2.40	2.15
Switzerland	0.25	0.25	0.50	0.25
Notes on data:				
U.S. prime rate is the base rate on corporate loans posted by at least 70% of the 10 largest U.S. banks, and is effective December 11, 2025. Other prime rates aren't directly comparable; lending practices vary widely by location. Discount rate is effective December 11, 2025. Secured Overnight Financing Rate is as of August 19, 2026. DTCC GCF Repo Index is Depository Trust & Clearing Corp.'s weighted average for overnight trades in applicable CUSIPs. Value traded is in billions of U.S. dollars. Federal-funds rates are Tullett Prebon rates as of 3:30 p.m. ET.				
Sources: Federal Reserve; Bureau of Labor Statistics; DTCC; FactSet; Tullett Prebon Information, Ltd.				

	Latest	Week ago	-52-Week-High	-52-Week-Low
Britain	3.75	3.75	4.00	3.75
Australia	4.35	4.35	4.35	3.60
Overnight repurchase				
U.S.	3.67	3.63	4.45	3.49
U.S. government rates				
Discount				
	3.75	3.75	4.50	3.75
Federal funds				
Effective rate	3.6400	3.6400	4.3300	3.6300
High	3.7000	3.7000	4.5500	3.7000
Low	3.5500	3.5500	4.3200	3.5500
Bid	3.6300	3.6200	4.3200	3.6100
Offer	3.6400	3.6400	4.3300	3.6300
Treasury bill auction				
4 weeks	3.640	3.625	4.300	3.550

	Latest	Week ago	-52-Week-High	-52-Week-Low
13 weeks	3.715	3.735	4.130	3.540
26 weeks	3.780	3.830	3.945	3.470

Other short-term rates				
	Latest	Week ago	-52-Week-High	-52-Week-Low
Call money				
	5.50	5.50	6.25	5.50
Commercial paper (AA financial)				
90 days	3.84	n.a.	4.22	3.50
Secured Overnight Financing Rate				
	3.62	3.62	4.51	3.50
	Latest	Value Traded	-52-Week-High	-52-Week-Low
DTCC GCF Repo Index				
Treasury	3.682	56.500	4.492	3.500
MBS	3.675	113.892	4.623	3.510
Weekly survey				
	Latest	Week ago	Year ago	
Freddie Mac				
30-year fixed	6.65	6.67	6.58	
15-year fixed	5.95	5.96	5.65	

MARKETS & FINANCE

EverBank Investors Seek an Exit

Five private-equity owners of Florida-based lender clashed over its strategy

BY GINA HEEB
AND BEN GLICKMAN

Florida-based EverBank is up for sale three years after a group of private-equity firms banded together to buy the on-line bank, according to people familiar with the matter.

The bank, the sponsor of the Jacksonville Jaguars stadium and brand partner of quarterback Trevor Lawrence, could pursue an initial public offering if it isn't able to reach a deal to sell itself, the people said. The sales process has been a monthslong slog, according to some of the people.

“We’ve always considered a number of options for the bank’s future—including acquisitions; a potential sale of the bank or merger; or an initial public offering,” the bank said in a statement. “We continue to be enormously optimistic about the bank’s potential for growth and performance.”

EverBank operates mostly as a digital bank, with a few dozen branches, primarily in Florida and California. It had about \$47 billion in assets as of midyear, ranking as the 57th-largest bank holding company in the U.S. It had around \$38 billion in deposits.

The five private-equity firms—Stone Point Capital, Warburg Pincus, Reverence



EverBank operates mostly as a digital bank, with a few dozen branches, primarily in Florida and California.

Capital Partners, Sixth Street and Bayview Asset Management—bought the bank in 2023 from TIAA, the enormous pension fund serving academics. The price of that deal wasn't disclosed.

The deal was watched closely across the banking industry. Federal law limits how much of a bank a firm can own without becoming a bank holding company, meaning that private investors usually take minority stakes only.

The Federal Deposit Insurance Corp. earlier this year

moved to make it easier for private-equity investors to get involved in acquisitions of failed banks.

With EverBank, the firms split the ownership and, as a group, were considering gobbling up more banks after the TIAA deal, similar to how they often seek to roll up industries, The Wall Street Journal reported.

In 2024, EverBank agreed to acquire Sterling Bank & Trust for \$261 million, gaining 25 branches in California, and one in Queens, N.Y.

But, the five firms struggled to form a cohesive strategy at EverBank, leading to tension between the owners and inside the boardroom, the people familiar with the matter said.

Now, swarms of investment bankers and corporate lawyers are circling around a possible deal, further complicating those dynamics, the people said.

EverBank has sought to aggressively grow its balance sheet. It focused on its mobile-app service and leaned in to high-yield savings for consum-

ers, which bring in new customers but are less profitable.

Meanwhile, EverBank roughly doubled its loans to nonbank financial institutions, a category that includes much-scrutinized private-credit firms as well as firms such as real-estate investors and insurance companies.

“We’ve significantly improved the bank’s profitability, grown our retail presence across the country...and expanded our commercial banking capabilities,” the bank’s statement said.

Weil Stars In Talks To Leave

Continued from page B1

cies for Lehman Brothers, General Motors and Enron. The New York-based firm also has a significant corporate practice with more than 600 lawyers that advises big clients on M&A and other matters and is chaired by longtime dealmaker Michael Aiello.

The departures come at a sensitive moment, as Weil prepares to navigate a leadership transition. After a more

The industry is being disrupted by poaching.

than 16-year run, executive partner Barry Wolf will retire next year and Boston partner Ramona Nee will succeed him as the firm’s leader. Nee, who serves as co-managing partner, will become the first woman to lead the firm.

The firm has hovered in the top 20 by gross revenue, with over \$2 billion last year, but has slipped in the rankings as it lost ground to larger rivals such as Latham & Watkins and Kirkland & Ellis. Its profit per equity partner was about \$5.4 million last year, compared with more than \$12 million at the most profitable.

MONEY & INVESTING

Stock Spotlight

Strategy, Coinbase and American Bitcoin

Shares in the crypto-related companies jumped after President Trump had a friendly meeting with digital-currency leaders at the White House. Strategy gained 7.8%, Coinbase rose 7.6% and American Bitcon increased 7.2%.

Walmart

The retailer posted its weakest sales growth in over six years; shares declined 9.2%.

Advance Auto Parts

Shares closed down nearly 25% after the car-parts seller reported a decline in both same-store and net sales, noting fewer people were picking up DIY projects for their automobiles.

Alibaba

The Chinese company's U.S.-listed shares rose 1.3%

slightly reversing an earlier slight fall after it reported a steep drop in profit amid heavy investments in artificial intelligence.

Coty

The beauty company reported a bigger loss and forecast a drop in sales in the current quarter. Shares dropped 9.2%.

Deere

Shares climbed 6.9% after the machinery maker's quarterly profit topped expectations despite continued weakness in its large farm equipment business.

FRIDAY'S EVENTS:

◆ Economic data:
S&P flash U.S. services PMI,
S&P flash U.S. manufacturing PMI

EARNINGS EXPECTED:

BJ's Wholesale Club

Bitcoin Leaps on Bond Intervention, Crypto Summit

Bitcoin has broken out of its summer doldrums, rallying more than 12% over the past two days, in the wake of Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent's intervention in the bond market and an upbeat White House cryptocurrency summit.

The digital currency rose above \$72,600 on Thursday. It was the first time bitcoin traded above the \$70,000 level since early June.

Bessent's plan to step up buybacks of long-dated U.S. government bonds pushed down borrowing costs, which tends to benefit risky assets like bitcoin.

Separately, President Trump urged Congress to pass legislation desired by the digital-currency industry during a friendly meeting with crypto executives on Wednesday.

—Alexander Osipovich

Bitcoin price, past three months



Source: CoinDesk

On This Day In Market History

On this day in 1999, a record price of \$2.65 million was paid for a membership seat on the New York Stock Exchange. It was quite a rise from the record low price for a seat, set in 1942, of \$17,000. Five years later, seats would fetch only around \$1 million.

After Day of Exuberance For Moderna, Investors Pull Back

The day after Moderna's stock posted its biggest one-day gain on record, the shares plunged more than 23% as investors digested Wednesday's trial news and adjusted their positions.

Prior to Wednesday's rally on positive mRNA cancer-vaccine data, Moderna's stock had substantial short interest at 13.7%.

A so-called short squeeze, wherein short sellers buy back stock to moderate losses, likely contributed to the stock's meteoric Wednesday rise, analysts said. Thursday's move reflects the market cooling off, they said.

“Probably you had a lot of shorts who got it wrong covering, which put a lot of paraffin on the flame,” said Brookline Capital Markets analyst Leah Cann. “In the days after, they moderate a bit, and it settles down.”

UBS said its clients sold a record \$44 million in Moderna shares Wednesday, suggesting some investors were cashing out after the rally. “The stock traded nearly 200 million shares yesterday, roughly half of shares outstanding, suggesting a significant amount of short covering and fast-money repositioning likely occurred in a single session,” said UBS analyst Michael Yee. “Once that buying demand was exhausted, some pullback was to be expected.”

—Alex Janin



ADAM GLANZMAN/BLOOMBERG NEWS

DROP THE F*BOMB

TALK TO YOUR KIDS ABOUT FENTANYL

Fentanyl is being used to make counterfeit pills and is being laced into other illicit drugs. Make sure your teens know the facts.

Learn the facts on fentanyl and start a life-saving conversation with your teen.



DropTheFBomb.com



HEARD ON THE STREET

FINANCIAL ANALYSIS & COMMENTARY

Hyperscalers’ Off-Grid Power Push Has Risks

Data centers’ huge, fluctuating power demand is testing off-grid energy systems

Big technology companies are cobbling together off-grid power systems to match their rushed timelines for artificial-intelligence development. What if these systems are glitchy?

Off-grid power comes with hefty price tags and operating risks. Tech giants are pursuing them anyway. Power providers, some of whom don’t have much data-center experience, are jumping at the chance to sign deals with deep-pocketed customers. But cracks have shown at the few on-site power projects that started up, highlighting potential costs to tech companies and their power providers.

In the U.S., there are four operational data centers with off-grid or partially grid-connected power, according to data provider Cleanview. These are xAI’s Colossus and Colossus II, Crusoe’s Stargate Abilene and Vantage Data Centers’ Vantage VA 2. Three of these already reported issues.

This month, Bloomberg reported some data centers experienced cranks breaking off on combustion engines. The report said cracks had formed at gas-fired turbines powering xAI’s Colossus data center in Memphis, Tenn.

In response to the report, **Solaris Energy Infrastructure**, which operates turbines for the campus, didn’t directly confirm or deny the existence of turbine cracks on its earnings call but said its turbines were “in great shape.” In an emailed statement, Solaris co-Chief Executive Bill Zartler said the company has “not seen any extraordinary operating issues or failure rates on our generation equipment.”

Cracked turbines and broken engine cranks are major failures that require replacement, according to Nina Sadighi, founder of Eradeh Power Consulting, an electrical engineer who formerly worked at Amazon and Tesla.

In July, Vantage Data Centers experienced a critical power failure at its data-center campus in Loudoun County, Va., forcing the operator to switch over to diesel backup power for about a day, a spokesperson confirmed. Distributed Power Solutions, which **Kodiak Gas Services** bought earlier this year, operates the on-site power. Crusoe also ran into turbine glitches and other technical problems at Stargate Abilene, according to the Information. Stargate partner **Oracle** runs servers for OpenAI.

What’s causing these problems? First, AI data centers’ power demands can be incredibly taxing on



The xAI Colossus data center in Memphis, Tenn., is one of four in the U.S. using behind-the-meter power.

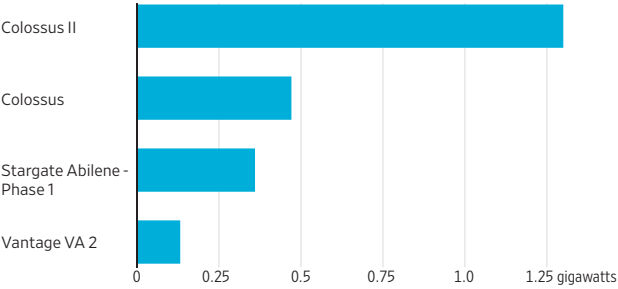
power systems. AI workloads cause massive power-demand spikes during computation, and a drop-off as those computation results are gathered, according to a paper from Schneider Electric. As data centers get bigger, oscillations could reach hundreds of megawatts or even gigawatts, according to the paper. Big swings can stress and shorten the life of engines and turbines, and can even cause shaft fractures, according to the energy research and consulting firm Wood Mackenzie.

The same problem surfaced on power grids, when grid-connected data centers suddenly drop power usage. Grid operators have had to scramble to take power supply offline to make sure the sudden excess of supply doesn’t damage power plants and infrastructure.

Troy Patton, general manager at on-site power provider Alpha-Struxure, said in an interview that he spoke to a potential hyperscaler client who required a very short power response time—tens of milliseconds, rather than hundreds of milliseconds as the industry is used to. These are response times that no rotating equipment, or a lithium battery, has ever had to respond to, he said.

Second, many off-grid power systems use a mishmash of different power equipment, depending

Planned power capacity of operating U.S. data centers with behind-the-meter power



Source: Cleanview

on what was available to buy. It can be challenging to make sure all the different pieces work together.

Downtime can be costly for everyone involved. Anthropic is paying xAI a monthly fee of \$1.25 billion for computing capacity on Colossus and Colossus II. While the contract details aren’t public, the monthly fee implies that one day’s worth of outage could be worth as much as tens of millions of dollars a day—either in lost fees for xAI or the cost to Anthropic of not having that computing power.

Outages can be costly for power providers. These providers typically don’t get paid for electricity they

fail to provide, and in some cases must pay penalties for failing to deliver, according to industry experts. They are typically on the hook for repairing and replacing broken power equipment. Sadighi said that at one of her client’s former on-site data-center power systems, a power provider had to replace equipment worth millions of dollars after a multiday outage.

Power failures are the most acute risk, but a more insidious problem is if equipment keeps degrading more quickly than expected. Higher replacement costs would hurt power providers’ margins.

Power providers do try to limit

their maximum damages. Take Solaris Energy Infrastructure, the power provider to xAI’s Colossus campuses. In its contracts, Solaris must refund the customer’s fees when it fails to deliver power and must cover the cost of repairing or replacing equipment, according to a public filing. But it can’t be held liable for the customer’s lost revenue from that downtime.

Of course, power providers build in redundancies to make up for these risks and model their best guesses for how long each piece of equipment will last. It is too early to tell if these are short-term learning pains or structural issues. “Nobody has enough operating history yet to say how this equipment holds up,” Sadighi said. What is clear is that these data-center power loads are challenging enough to cause problems even for experienced, large-grid operators.

The stakes are getting higher because off-grid power systems are getting bigger. Amazon is planning an AI data-center campus in Pecos County, Texas, that would use natural-gas-powered turbines to generate as much as 7.65 gigawatts of power, according to Cleanview. That is equivalent to seven or eight nuclear power plants.

If these off-grid glitches are fixable learning pains, then power providers might only take a slight hit on their margins. But at worst, it could lead to losses, and a drying up of data-center business if hyperscalers scrap their off-grid power plans. At least hyperscalers have highly profitable business models and strong balance sheets; many of these new power providers don’t.

In addition to early players such as Solaris and VoltaGrid, many companies in the oil-and-gas industry—including **Liberty Energy**, **Williams Cos.**, **Atlas Energy Solutions** and Kodiak Gas Services—announced business units that will provide on-site power for data centers. Investors are willing to pay up for those with contracts. Solaris, which signed on two additional customers after xAI, fetches an enterprise value that is 10 times forward earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization, 19% higher than its oil-field service peer group.

Tech customer contracts are enticing indeed, but investors need to keep in mind that off-grid power at this scale is still an experiment. Technical challenges today can turn into financial problems in the future.

—Jinjo Lee

Here’s the Real Problem With Stock Buybacks

Warren Buffett is normally courteous, but he had some choice words for critics of stock buybacks a few years ago.

“When you are told that *all* repurchases are harmful to shareholders *or* to the country, *or* particularly beneficial to CEOs, you are listening to either an economic illiterate or a silver-tongued demagogue (characters that are not mutually exclusive),” he wrote.

Note Buffett’s emphasis on the word “all.” Companies need to return cash to investors eventually to be worth owning. For the most part, the differences between doing that via dividends or buybacks are minor. Buybacks give long-term investors a larger stake in a smaller company instead of handing them

cash they may not need and a dividend tax bill they definitely don’t. For management, dividends create future expectations whereas buybacks can be turned on and off.

But buybacks aren’t always a good idea because sometimes stocks are expensive. Companies that grant lots of stock options can be indifferent because they want to soak up those cheaply issued shares. Buffett’s **Berkshire Hathaway**, which doesn’t pay dividends, suspended buybacks for nearly two years, amassing a record cash hoard. Red-hot chip maker **SK Hynix**’s announcement Wednesday that it would conduct South Korea’s largest-ever buyback sent its shares higher. It’s a head-scratcher, though.

Even after a recent slump, the stock was up 470% from a year earlier. Management had ample financial firepower to buy during that ascent and didn’t. Even weirder is that they sold nearly the same amount of stock to U.S. investors last month in the biggest share sale ever by a foreign company at an effective price 50% higher than today.

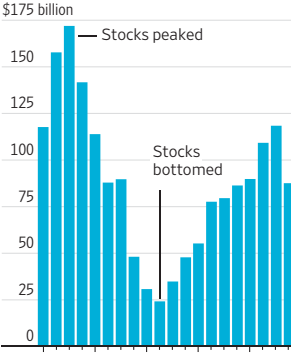
At least SK Hynix sold high and is buying lower. U.S. companies often get that backward. S&P 500 members marked what was then a record for buybacks in the same quarter the dot-com bubble peaked. The effective buyback yield—the value of repurchases as a ratio of the S&P 500’s value—was 1.2%. Three years later, they spent about 40% less, yet the yield was a third higher.

The contrast was even more extreme during the financial crisis. Buybacks hit a record just as stocks did in 2007. By the spring of 2009, when the market was dirt cheap, buybacks dropped by 85%.

Buybacks aren’t accounting trickery, and they don’t starve companies of capital unless done recklessly. The share of profits returned to investors one way or another has been pretty steady over many decades. But paying a dividend, reducing debt or building up cash for a rainy day can be better choices sometimes. Executives can’t control the business cycle or share prices. They’re in the best position to know when they’re frothy and don’t always act like it.

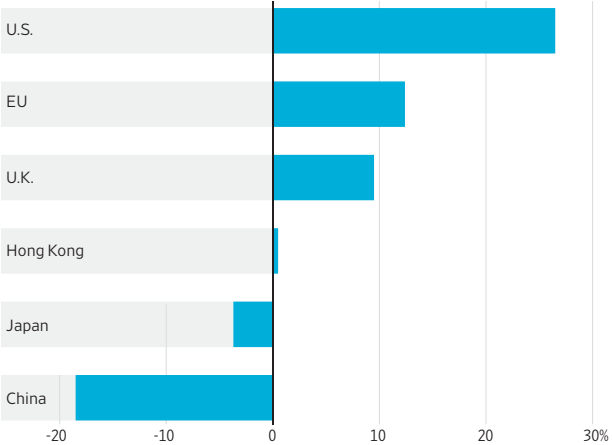
—Spencer Jakab

S&P 500 stock buybacks by quarter



Source: S&P Dow Jones Indices

Swiss watch exports in July, change from a year earlier



Source: Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry

Swiss Watches Are on U.S. Time Now

Demand for luxury watches varies a lot depending on which time zone you are in. Companies like Watches of Switzerland that do most of their business in the U.S. are big winners.

Data released Thursday by the Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry shows that exports of Swiss watches to the U.S. rose 27% in July compared with the same month of last year. The booming U.S. stock market, and the wealth created by artificial intelligence, is driving demand for expensive watches.

The U.K., where per-capita spending on luxury watches is high, and the EU were also bright spots. Meanwhile, watch exports to China fell 18.5% in July and

Japan was weak.

Swiss watch exports were also very skewed by price.

Exports of watches that cost roughly \$250 to \$630 rose 26%. This price range is probably getting a boost from the viral Audemars Piguet x Swatch Royal Pop watch that launched earlier this year and costs around \$400 in the U.S.

Exports of watches that cost more than 3,000 Swiss francs, equivalent to \$3,760, rose 12%. Demand for midpriced Swiss watches is weak.

Getting exposure to the parts of the luxury watch industry that are growing can be tricky for public-market investors. The most coveted watch brands such as Patek

Philippe, Rolex and Audemars Piguet, are privately owned.

Listed companies, including TAG Heuer’s owner LVMH, either have a lot of exposure to China, or they sell mid-priced watches that aren’t doing well these days.

Watches of Switzerland is in a sweet spot. The London-listed retailer is an official dealer for Patek Philippe and Rolex, so owning the stock is a way for investors to get indirect exposure to these names.

And the company has steered clear of China altogether. It gets half of its sales from the U.S., and the rest from the U.K. That is turning out to be a winning strategy. The stock is up more than 50% so far this year.

—Carol Ryan



Teen Hang
A Virginia couple's home is a go-to spot for their kids **M3**

MANSION

History Class
Jamie Peva is an Instagram hit with his focus on Georgetown **M6**



HOMES | MARKETS | PEOPLE | REDOS | SALES THE WALL STREET JOURNAL. Friday, August 21, 2026 | **M1**



Lauren Sánchez Bezos, left, Jeff Bezos, Jared Kushner and Ivanka Trump. The island, top.

Miami's Hardest Country Club To Get Into

Jeff Bezos and Jared Kushner have yet to secure membership at the exclusive Indian Creek Country Club

By Deborah Acosta

Miami
Jeff Bezos and his wife, Lauren Sánchez Bezos, were special guests in February for the annual dock party at Indian Creek Country Club, where members gathered to meet the famed entrepreneur.

Miami's nearly century-old, exclusive membership outfit sits in the heart of Indian Creek, a private island brimming with so many ultrawealthy residents it is known as the Billionaire Bunker. The club features a private golf course, a clubhouse modeled on a Mediterranean villa, and a swimming pool with bayfront views of the Miami skyline. Members dressed in white could be seen playing croquet on the lawn overlooking Biscayne Bay that day, attendees said.

Jeff Bezos went to the event hoping to persuade board members to admit him to the club, according to people who attended

the event. The Amazon.com founder, one of the world's wealthiest individuals, owns three properties on Indian Creek island and has spent about \$234 million combined to acquire them, public records show.

He worked the scene, engaging in small talk with members, said some of those who engaged with him. A few club members who relocated to South Florida or spend time there lined up to shake Bezos's hand. Yet to gain admission to the country club, Bezos would have to win over the longtime members whose roots often went back generations.

Six months later, Bezos still hasn't received an invitation to join the club.

Florida has become one of the world's strongest magnets for the billionaire jet set. Between 2019 and 2023, the Sunshine State swallowed \$137 billion in income from out-

Please turn to page M4

350

Members at the Indian Creek Country Club

\$1

MILLION
Initiation fee

\$44,000

annual dues



Indian Creek, left, is accessible by boat or by a gated bridge.

HISTORIC HOMES

It Did Time as a 'Jail' During the Revolution

The Connecticut home, parts of which date back to 1695, was once used to confine Benjamin Franklin's Loyalist son

By Sarah Paynter

WHEN JAMES and Kelsey Shutts planned their move to Connecticut from Georgia, they had a single goal: to buy a really old house. "Where else are you going to be able to own a home that was built prior to the 1770s?" Kelsey asks, referring to New England's historic properties.

In 2024, they bought a home in South Windsor for \$399,000. According to the National Register of Historic Places, Loyalist William Franklin was once confined at the house, which features sections dating to as early as 1695.

For the Shuttses, taking



The home's front, with the elaborate, oft-photographed door.

on an ambitious renovation was part of the charm of Connecticut living—and it was a good thing they felt

that way. Most of the plumbing didn't work, and unstable support beams put

Please turn to page M2

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MANSION



This Old House Has a Revolutionary War Past

Continued from page M1

a second-floor bathroom at risk of collapsing into the dining room, says Kelsey, 32, who works in marketing. The couple spent \$1 million and two years renovating the house, says James, 41, whose job as CEO of a granola company brought them to Connecticut.

The history

Carpenter Samuel Grant built a small house on the site in 1695. Around 1757, his son, Ebenezer, built a large Georgian home on the property, incorporating the original structure, according to the National Register.

During the American Revolution, the house served as an alternate prison for William Franklin, the son of Benjamin Franklin and New Jersey's last royal governor. Franklin's health deteriorated inside a Connecticut



jail, so Revolutionary leaders eventually relocated him to the Grant house. In October 1778, the Patriots traded him for another prisoner, according to the Journal of the American Revolution.

The Grant family sold the house in 1913, and it traded hands several times over the next few decades, records show. Owners moved the house 25 feet farther from the road, destroyed historic outbuildings and removed part of the 1695

structure, according to the National Register.

In 1972, psychiatrist and history buff Constantine Zariphes Jr. fell in love with the house's elaborate front door and bought it with his wife, Demetra Zariphes, says their son Alex Zariphes, who grew up there. They paid about \$70,000, according to property records, restoring the front door while preserving elements such as wood paneling and fireplace mantels. They moved out around

2020 before both died in 2024, Alex says.

Modern day

The Shuttses shored up the structural problems and updated mechanicals, installing air conditioning and new plumbing, electricity and heating. That meant cutting hundreds of holes in the walls and ceilings, which James says he meticulously repaired by hand.

Historic details

Tourists take pictures of the doorway, Kelsey says. The entrance is an elaborate example of a Connecticut River Valley Doorway, a style created by elite New England homeowners to display their wealth, says Christopher Wigren, deputy director of Preservation Connecticut. "It's just a wham-bang statement of power and wealth," says Wigren. "They're actually pretty rare."

The house, circa 1890-1910, top left. The grand staircase, above. James and Kelsey Shutts display a sold sign at their newly purchased property in 2024, below.



they planned to stay longer, they are moving to Florida to be closer to James's three children.

Market snapshot

Jacob Wint of William Pitt Sotheby's International Realty is marketing the property not as a historic house but as a turnkey home with high-end finishes and amenities. Still, he believes its historic designation will motivate buyers to pay more than they would for a new-construction house with equivalent finishes and square footage.

The median sale price in South Windsor was \$477,000 in July, up about 16% from last year, according to Realtor.com, which is operated by News Corp, parent of The Wall Street Journal.

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The arrest of Loyalist William Franklin (son of Benjamin), in a 19th century engraving, top, The primary bedroom, above.

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MANSION

INSIDE STORY

A Home Where Teens Want to Hang

A couple didn't want their kids 'disappearing into their rooms,' so they built a house with a sports room and swimming pool

By Nancy Keates

Yuri and Michelle Sagatov wanted to make their home the go-to spot for their teenage children before and after football and soccer games, as well as prom parties. But the family also wanted to spend quality time with them while giving everyone enough privacy. Their solution: to build a striking contemporary \$2.8 million house with four interconnected pavilions—each with its own bedroom and bathroom—to provide both communal and individual spaces. The 7,000-square-foot house has a large open kitchen and a separate living room taken up entirely by a circular sunken conversation pit. For separation, the pavilions angle away from each other, connected by a central staircase. They bought the property in Arlington, Va., in 2019 for \$870,000 and tore down the existing small ranch-style house. Then they started the new build, finishing in 2021. The house was close to the high school their kids attended; to encourage their teenagers' friends to spend time there, the Sagatovs put in a swimming pool with an adjacent heated outdoor lounge and a sports room with a 12-foot-high ceiling in the basement for playing



soccer, basketball and tennis. “We didn’t want our kids just disappearing into their rooms,” said Yuri, 50, founder and principal designer of ODE Design, a design-build company based in Falls Church, Va. “We wanted places where they would want to hang out with us and their friends.” The plan worked, said Alina, now 19 and a rising sophomore at the University of Virginia. “My friends in high school loved coming over,” she said. “Now, all my college friends have been here.” James, 17, a rising high-school senior, said his friends are at the house at least

once a week during the school year, playing board games in the conversation pit and soccer in the basement, and in the pool all summer. He’s leaning toward going to college nearby so he can come home often. Yuri grew up working on construction projects in Northern Virginia with his father, a general contractor, and the couple have built or renovated five homes for themselves, all within a few miles of each other in Arlington. “It’s our side hustle,” said Michelle, a real-estate agent. In past homes, they always thought about resale value, so they shied away from design choices that might divide buyers. “In this house, we wanted to do what we really wanted,” Yuri said. When the Sagatovs saw the ranch house where their house now stands, they knew they had to pounce. Its lot was unusually large for the neighborhood, where developers routinely scoop up oversize lots. Michelle spent six years as an Arlington police officer, which she said helped give her a thorough understanding of the city. Alina said this house is her favorite, which makes her worry about losing it. That feeling comes from having moved so often as her parents renovated and built new homes. “They say this is their forever home, but I think they could move again,” she said.

Above, the front exterior of the Sagatov home. The 7,000-square-foot house replaced a ranch house. Below, a bedroom overlooks the swimming pool. James and Alina Sagatov work in the family’s home office, bottom.



The Sagatov family in the kitchen with their dog, Roxy, above. At top, the house includes a sports room with 12-foot ceilings.



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MANSION

Miami’s Most Exclusive Club

Continued from page M1

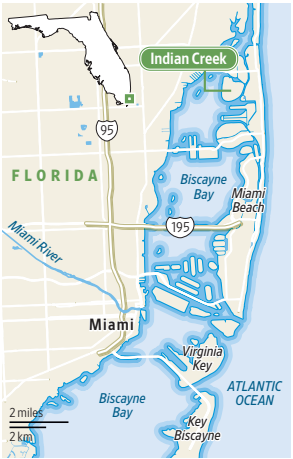
of-state movers—nearly four times that of runner-up Texas, according to data from the Internal Revenue Service analyzed by trade association Miami Realtors +RWorld.

When the club was founded in 1929, Miami was just starting to emerge as a real-estate boomtown. Since then, the country club has catered to the blue-blood families who spend time in South Florida and famous residents, such as Julio Iglesias.

Owning a property on the island doesn’t guarantee admission to the country club. And people who live outside the island can still apply for membership. Visiting the island requires an invitation from either a homeowner or a member of the country club. While nonmembers living on the island might have views of the golf course, they cannot play on it without an invitation from a club member.

Indian Creek represents one of South Florida’s major battlefields, where the region’s newly minted billionaires are clashing with those of more modest affluence who often trace their Miami roots back generations.

“Most communities, you buy a



Sources: Census Bureau (roads); Florida Department of Environmental Protection (lakes, rivers)
ANNA DEEN/WSJ



Two of the three properties that Jeff Bezos owns on the island.



The nearly century-old Indian Creek Country Club features a private golf course and a clubhouse modeled on a Mediterranean villa, Below, former AutoNation CEO Mike Jackson is president of the club.

home, you become a member of the club, and this community doesn’t fall in line with that,” said Dina Goldentayer, a real-estate agent who has sold homes on the island. “It’s the most exclusive single-family home community, it’s the most exclusive private members club.”

The club’s six membership committee members determine the nominees. Then, the board of directors, consisting of 15 members and led by the country club’s president, former AutoNation CEO Mike Jackson, votes up or down, one member said.

These elder statesmen have witnessed leaders of the world’s tech, finance and real estate businesses flock to South Florida, often attracted by lower taxes. They are taking over its top restaurants and best private schools while gobbling up much of the most desirable waterfront property.

Now, the old guard—many of them retirees—is mounting a last stand against what it often views as billionaire interlopers. They are the gatekeepers for Indian Creek Country Club and don’t offer membership to just anyone who has struck it rich.

The wealth and power of this

old guard, by most measures, is astronomical—except when compared with the island’s more recent residents, which include Jared Kushner and Ivanka Trump, Bezos, the Qatari royal family and Meta Platforms CEO Mark Zuckerberg. None are members of the club.

The roughly 350-member club charges an initiation fee that is close to \$1 million and annual dues of about \$44,000, people connected to the club said.

The old guard is mounting a last stand against what it views as billionaire interlopers.

Admission to this kingdom on the sea usually requires a long courtship. It starts with sponsorship from two current members and letters of recommendation from five others. Then, applicants need to mingle with existing members to make a good impression. That means showing up to club events, throwing back a drink at cocktail meet-and-greets and teeing off at the golf course, some members said.

As with many private country clubs, admission often comes down to hitting it off with members. And while social status and name recognition can help, they are hardly a guarantee, according to some people connected to the club. In fact, too much wealth or notoriety has become a deterrent, as wealthy new applicants arriving in Florida are learning.

Developers acquired and enlarged the island in the 1920s, with the golf course and clubhouse developed at the center. The home lots were organized in a ring, so each could face both the bay and the William S. Flynn-designed course.

Traditionally, its membership

roster included local doctors, real-estate developers, entrepreneurs, attorneys and financiers such as Carl Icahn. Some powerful politicians have also been members, including former U.S. Senate Majority Leader Howard Baker, and sports figures such as basketball coaching legend Rick Pitino.

Beyond the matter of prestige, celebrities and the uber wealthy say they like the country club because of its ironclad security.

Indian Creek Village, which operates independently from the country club, is an entire incorporated municipality with its own legislative powers. The 300-acre island is accessible only by boat or by a single gated bridge and maintains its own private police force. The vast majority of the land belongs to the country club. It is a literal citadel with a natural, crystal-blue moat surrounding it.

For some of the world’s wealthiest people, that kind of security and privacy is priceless. Club member Lampert survived a kidnapping in Greenwich, Conn., in 2003, where he was held for ransom at a motel. He now lives on Indian Creek island behind dense hedges that prevent even his wealthy neighbors from peering into his estate—the only home like that on the island, one club member said. He paid \$38.4 million for his property, public records show, setting a record for the most expensive home sale in Miami-Dade County at the time.

Icahn got in early, paying \$7.5 million for his Indian Creek mansion in 1997. For the legendary value investor, the island wasn’t a status symbol; it was an undervalued asset. In late 2019, Icahn became the prophet of the modern exodus: He told his employees, pack your bags for Florida.

Certain new homeowners, such as Jersey Mike’s founder Peter Cancro and NFL legend Tom Brady, had no trouble getting into the club, some members said. But others haven’t had it so easy.

Jared and Ivanka Kushner bought 1.26 acres on the island and transformed a Spanish-style mansion into a more modern estate. Mary Anne Shula, the widow of famed Dolphins coach Don Shula, sponsored the couple for club membership, club members said. She hosted a cocktail party at her home on the island to introduce the couple to the club’s board. But when the Kushners hosted a housewarming cocktail party at their own compound, only about half the board showed up, these members said.

While some board members were out of town, the signal still seemed clear: The Kushners weren’t about to get in.

Dr. Aaron Rollins, a celebrity plastic surgeon who was building a home on the island, got frustrated after four years of failed efforts to receive membership to the club. He put his unfinished estate on the market late last year for \$200 million. Four months later, Meta’s Zuckerberg shelled out a record-shattering \$170 million to purchase the in-progress fortress.

“I determined after being there for a while that it wasn’t the right place for me to raise a family,” Rollins said.

Meanwhile, the Kushners are biding their time. Since their initial snub, Jared has taken on the role of unofficial envoy under his father-in-law, President Trump.

But he has also turned his diplomatic skills inward. For a period of time, he took on a role as council member on Indian Creek Village’s governing

board. His diplomacy around fixing a busted sewage system might prove to be crucial to gaining club membership, members said.

For years, the island’s obsolete septic systems have been leaking waste into the pristine waters of Biscayne Bay. A new sewage pump station will be built and installed across from Kushner’s home, and the club will allow landscaping on the golf course. A person familiar with the matter said this is a compromise with the club, which owns the golf course.

Meanwhile, the couple have built a relationship with the community, attending some of the club’s events, said a person familiar with the matter. Ivanka plays golf with members.

With victories on both the political and social fronts, the social tide is turning. Jared and Ivanka are edging ever closer to club membership, according to a person familiar with the club’s current thinking.



board. His diplomacy around fixing a busted sewage system might prove to be crucial to gaining club membership, members said.

FROM TOP: FELIX MIZDZIKOV/SHUTTERSTOCK; ANDREW HARRER/BLOOMBERG NEWS; EAGLEVIEW

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HOUSE CALL | JARED HARRIS

Free Beer in College Lured ‘Mad Men’ Actor Onto the Stage

‘Brink of War’ co-star on his famous father, Richard Harris, coping with a double rejection and his house in Ireland

The best advice my father gave me when I was young is that life’s a little bit mad. He was the acclaimed Irish actor Richard Harris, and what he meant was that if you’re not willing to accept chaos and shrug it off, you’ll be ground down. I didn’t fully appreciate what he meant until later.

My family first lived in the Kensington section of London and then in Notting Hill, in a spacious



row house with a cherry tree out front. My mother, Elizabeth, was Welsh and had a warm personality. She always wanted to be an actress but gave up that dream because she had three kids to care for by age 25.

In the 1960s and ’70s, when I grew up, my father was busy with Hollywood films, including “Mutiny on the Bounty,” “Camelot,” “The Molly Maguires” and “Cromwell.” The chaos Dad was talking

about began for me at age 7, when my parents divorced. My younger brother, Jamie, was 5, and my older brother, Damian, was 10.

Shortly after the split, Damian and I were sent away to a strict boarding school, which seemed like a double parental rejection. They loved us, but they were no longer together and I was no longer with them.

My mother came to school each half-semester. My father didn’t come as often. In 1971, my mother married actor Rex Harrison, who was in his early 60s. He wasn’t fond of kids and we were hellions. My mother finally hired a female Israeli ex-army sergeant-major as a nanny. She got us in line.

Mom and Rex divorced in 1975.

When I was 9, I began visiting my father in the summer on Paradise Island in the Bahamas. He had bought a house on 1½ acres, with the ocean on one side and the harbor on the other. My brothers and I loved it there.

On our first visit, we kicked around a soccer ball in the living room and smashed a vase, followed by admonishment from my soon-to-be stepmom. My father said, “Boys, if you can break the matching one, I’ll give you a hundred

Jared Harris in 2022. Below, the family in London in 1964, with Jared seated on the couch.

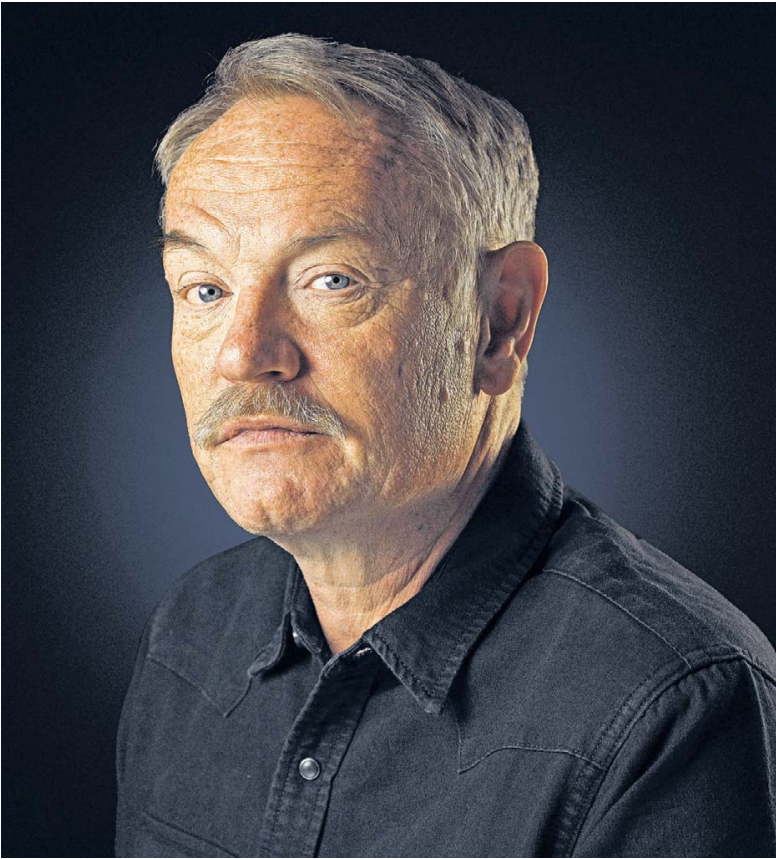
quid. If you can do it with a header, I’ll give you 200.”

Back at school, everyone was drafted into school plays. I was shy but liked the smell of the grease paint. I attended Duke University in the U.S. to get a clean slate. During Orientation Week, before classes began, I saw a campus flier offering free beer at Duke’s theater.

I went and decided to audition for Agatha Christie’s “A Murder Is Announced.” Richard Aumiller, who was the program’s director, cast me. I enjoyed the camaraderie and being in front of an audience trying to figure out what they were paying attention to and what they weren’t. My mother came to see me and was supportive.

At the end of four years, Aumiller said, “I never encourage students to go into this business because of the high failure rate. But maybe you should think about it.”

Following graduation, I stuck around at Duke to appear in the dark comedy “Entertaining Mr



Sloane.” My father finally came to see me perform. I had no idea where he was seated, but about 15 minutes in, I heard him laugh. I thought, “OK, I got him.”

Afterward, his face expressed surprise and excitement: “Oh, my God, you’ve got it. You’ve got it!” He was thrilled that he could now share his passion for acting with someone who was interested. I took a year off and then attended London’s Central School of Speech and Drama.

The first project that raised my American visibility was the 2008 film “The Curious Case of Benjamin Button.” Matt Weiner, the creator of “Mad Men,” saw it and cast me in 2009 as Lane Pryce, the ad agency’s financial officer.

Today, my wife, lighting designer and TV host Allegra Riggio, and I divide our time between

homes in Los Angeles and New York. We also have a place in Ireland.

In L.A., we live in a cozy, ivy-covered, shabby-chic house I bought in 2004. There, I have pieces from my father’s Bahamas house. In Manhattan, we have a downtown duplex with art-deco furniture.

In Ireland, our home is on the west coast and has great big windows that look out at the ocean. My father’s family had spent summers in the town. When we’re there, he’s definitely in the air.

—As told to Marc Myers

Jared Harris, 64, is a British actor known for TV’s “Mad Men,” “The Crown” and “Chernobyl” series, and the movie “Reawakening.” He co-stars in the newly released film “The Brink of War.”



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MANSION



Real-estate agent Jamie Peva pauses in a house he is selling in the neighborhood.

THE TRADE

Today’s Lesson in Georgetown History...

Real-estate agent Jamie Peva has become a hit on Instagram with his lively stories about the D.C. neighborhood’s past

By CECILIE ROHWEDDER

On a recent morning in Georgetown—Washington, D.C.’s oldest neighborhood—real-estate agent Jamie Peva strode down leafy N Street, brimming with historical tidbits.

Jackie Kennedy once lived on the street, he said. So did Ben Bradlee, former executive editor of the Washington Post, along with a former Miss America and a powerful U.S. senator. Bradlee’s widow, author Sally Quinn, and Eric Schmidt, former CEO of Google, own homes there.

“I’ve seen a picture of Lyndon Johnson coming out of this house,” Peva said, passing a Federal-style brick mansion. “Also, the Beatles went to a lawn party here.”

Peva, a 60-year-old agent with Washington Fine Properties, has sold Georgetown real estate for over three decades, often traversing the area by bicycle. Of the roughly 2,500 houses in the neighborhood, he has been involved in the sale of 460, he estimated. A self-styled historian of the area, he knows stories behind its houses and their owners going back generations.

With a knack for lively storytelling, he shares his knowledge with some 37,500 Instagram followers, who have made Peva—sporting the bow ties he has worn since boarding school—an unlikely social-media influencer. Many of his followers are locals, and most have no plans to buy or sell real estate—until they do. It is then, Peva says, that his spirited reels bring him to mind. “It’s the digital version of a refrigerator magnet,” he said.

After Peva’s first video in November 2023, his eponymous Instagram account sparked a 10% increase in sales volume in the first year, and an additional 20% the next, he estimated. “It’s



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MANSION

been very good for business, there is no question about it,” he said.

But Peva’s posts have also made him a local celebrity. As he walked down N Street, the driver of a Mercedes station wagon slowed down to honk and wave. A lady walking a large gray dog stopped to ask what he was filming (a reel about a Colonial-era bottling plant). Peva knew the dog from walking his two springers, Jumpy and Peggy-O, in the neighborhood.

A growing number of real-estate agents now use social media to sell, and some have millions of followers with reels featuring ultraluxury pads, selling tips or reality TV-style reports on their daily lives. While Peva posts about his listings—and sometimes those of other agents—he mostly focuses on Georgetown history, local businesses and community events, saying his goal is to benefit both his business and the neighborhood.

“If we don’t find something genuinely interesting and worth sharing, we won’t do it,” said Peva’s daughter, Violet Peva, a New York social-media strategist who films, edits and posts his reels.

Peva is from Connecticut but has lived in Georgetown for more than 30 years. Over the years, the neighborhood has changed. The Georgetown Set, a powerful group of Cold War-era residents whose Sunday-night potlucks are said to have swayed U.S. policy, has long faded away. The community is still home to high-profile Washingtonians, including a Republican senator and several cabinet members. But it increasingly also attracts technology and finance executives, Peva says. He now routinely signs nondisclosure agreements, ensuring privacy for wealthy clients.

The shift has made him rethink his marketing approach. “For years, a big part of our Georgetown business was made up of people who maintained a low profile,” he said. Agents were low-key, too. Today, curb appeal is more important, he said, and agents are promoting themselves more. “As this change was underfoot, I was thinking that I needed to evolve myself, too,” he said.

Though his own social-media use is mostly limited to sailing accounts, he asked his daughter Violet,

he said, but he turns them down, feeling that followers would lose interest in constant commercials. One exception is a recent paid post on Mount Vernon, the former home of George Washington. Peva wanted to share its history, he said, and didn’t want to lose the opportunity to another Instagrammer.

Anthony Arend, a professor at Georgetown University, has lived in his current home for 19 years without any plans to sell or buy real estate. But he follows Peva and has referred house-hunting friends to him.

One of Peva’s biggest deals—the \$10.5 million sale of a 19th-century Italianate mansion—came after he made two 2024 reels featuring it. Last year, Kate Watts, 49, a digital consultant, called Peva to sell her late father’s three-bedroom house on Q Street; her husband had seen Peva on Instagram. In an October reel, Peva praised the architecture of the house, designed by modernist Hugh Newell Jacobsen. Halfway through, he mentioned an open house the next day, ending with an upbeat: “Did I also mention this house is for sale? \$3.75 million!” The reel got 27,000 views, the open house was packed, and the buyers made an offer at the list price the same day.



The Georgetown neighborhood in Washington, D.C.

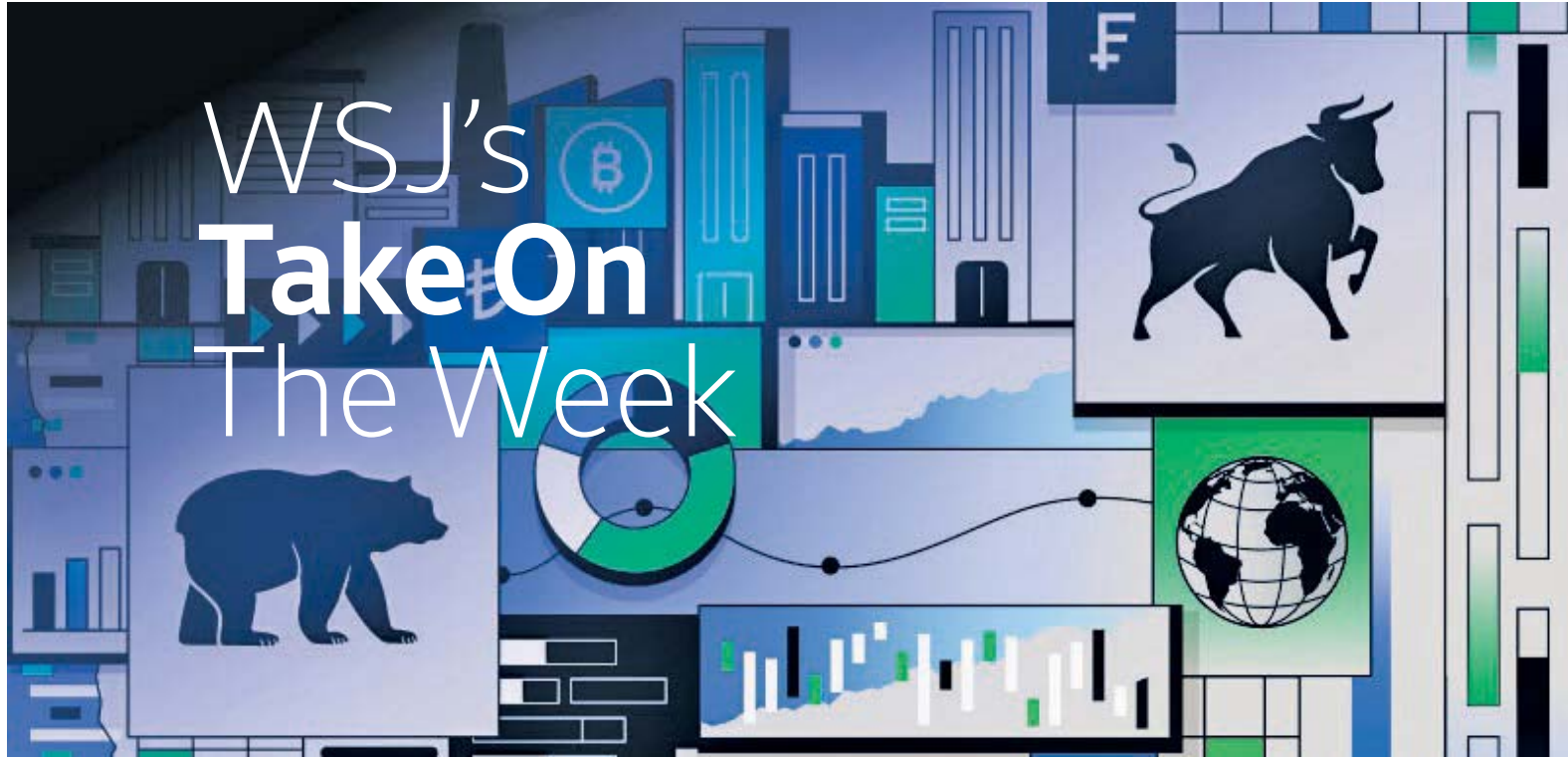
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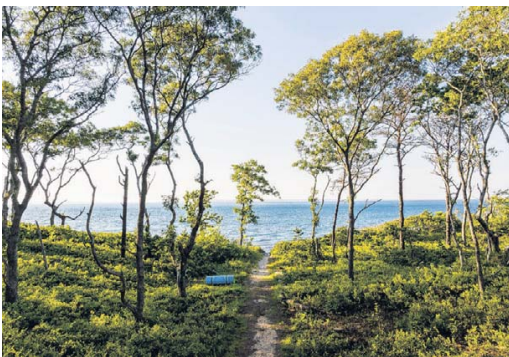
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PRIVATE PROPERTIES



‘Arthur’ Creator Sells Martha’s Vineyard Home

“Arthur” creator Marc Brown and his wife, artist Laurene Krasny Brown, sold their 7.8-acre Martha’s

Vineyard property for \$6.4 million, a year after listing the Vineyard Haven property for \$6.9 million. It was

most recently listed for \$6.495 million before going into contract in June.

An author-illustrator, Marc created an aardvark character named Arthur who anchored a popular kids’ book series and TV show of the same name. He and his wife, who goes by Laurie, spent years and millions of dollars restoring the property before deciding they wanted another project closer to their main home in New York City.

After a price drop in October, there were multiple bidders, said listing agent Alexis Holden of Tea Lane Associates/Forbes Global Properties, who marketed the property with colleague Elle Lash. The buyer from California was represented by Julie Flanders of Flanders Up-Island Real Estate. She didn’t respond to requests for comment.

Located in the Pilot Hill Farm enclave, the Brown property was originally part of a 225-acre dairy farm. There is a roughly 3,700-square-foot main house and a pool.



SOLD
\$6.4 MILLION
3,700 sq. ft. main house, 5 bedrooms, pool, carriage house

“The high-end has definitely been pretty active this spring,” said Holden. While the number of home sales on Martha’s Vineyard slipped 5% during the first half of the year, compared with the first half of 2025, dollar volume rose 23% year-over-year, driven by demand for high-end properties, according to data from Tea Lane Associates. The average sale price rose 29% year-over-year to a record \$2.53 million.

—E.B. Solomont

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A Waterfront Home
In Miami Beach
Changes Hands

A waterfront home with its own nightclub in Miami Beach, Fla., has sold off-market for \$51.5 million. The sum is a record for the gated Hibiscus Island, said Denis Smykalov of Wolsen Real Estate, who represented the seller.

Developer Luis Bosch, founder of Luis Bosch Luxury Homes, said that when he bought the roughly half-acre property, there was an incomplete residential structure that he described as a “shell.”

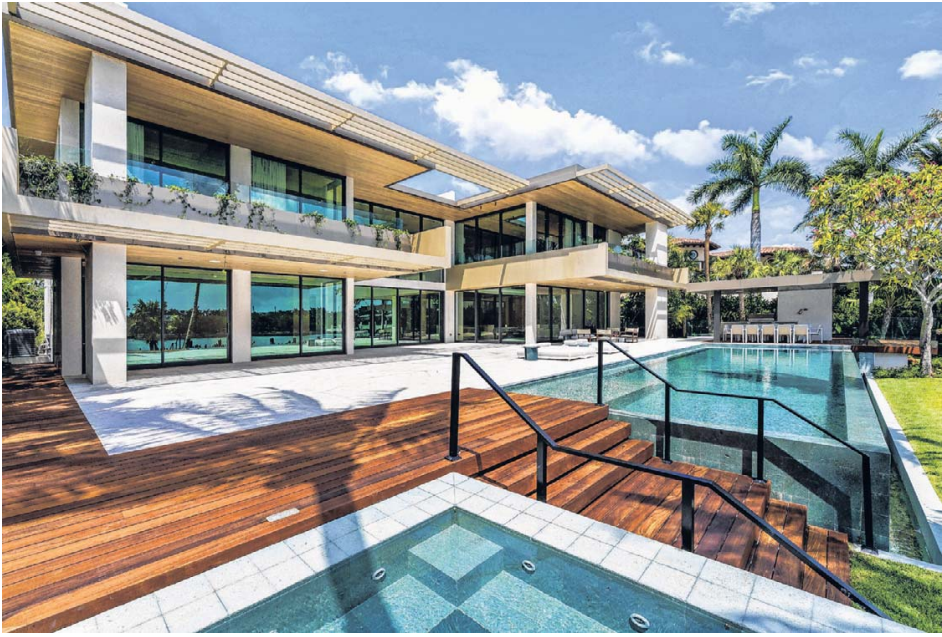


SOLD
\$51.5
MILLION

10,000 sq. ft., 5 bedrooms,
fitness center, nightclub

In 2021, Bosch bought the property for \$19 million and spent around five years re-designing, re-permitting and building out the home. The cost of construction was around \$15 million, he said.

Smykalov and Bosch declined to name the buyer, but said the



buyer approached them about purchasing the home around March.

The home spans roughly 10,000 square feet and has five bedrooms. There is also a fitness center and a private nightclub that has its own entrance, laser effects and disco balls. Bosch said he has

built several homes with nightclubs because people enjoy hosting large parties in Miami Beach.

The previous home-sale record on Hibiscus Island was \$40.3 million in 2024, Smykalov said.

Hibiscus Island is accessed by a road that passes through its neighbor, Palm Island. According to Smykalov, the home sale also tops the most expensive sale on Palm Island, which is \$45 million.

—Libertina Brandt

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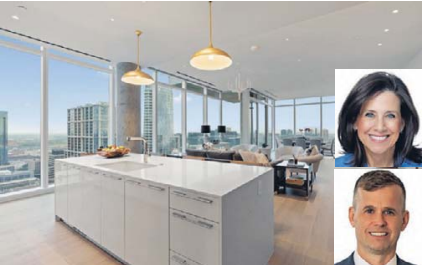
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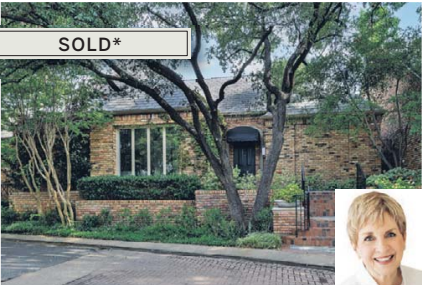
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